

CITY: PG 3

Rain and cloud cover bring welcome relief



NATION: PG 5

Rahul spreading misinformation on NEET hearing: BJP



FILM: PG 14

'Toxic changes how you see man-woman dynamic'



GOVT SAYS PM PERSONALLY SUPERVISING SITUATION

SC seeks accountability for NEET mess as Centre promises reforms

NEET-UG to shift to computer-based test mode from 2027, NTA tells SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday voiced concern over recurring irregularities in the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET-UG), saying young aspirants should not be let down and that the issue would persist unless clear accountability is fixed within the examination system.

Hearing a batch of petitions linked to the cancellation of NEET-UG 2026 over alleged paper leaks, a bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe observed that lasting reform would only be possible when responsibility is assigned to specific individuals and institutions.

"We should not disappoint our youngsters," the bench remarked, adding that the "real



problem won't stop till actual accountability arises".

The court was considering several petitions, including one seeking the replacement or restructuring of the National Testing Agency (NTA), which conducts the medical entrance examination, with a more

robust and autonomous body.

During the proceedings, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta informed the court that the Centre was treating the matter with utmost seriousness and that new safeguards had been introduced for the NEET-UG re-exami-

nation scheduled on June 21.

Mehta said details of the new measures could not be publicly disclosed because doing so could undermine their purpose. He told the court that the process was being monitored at the highest executive level and that Prime Minister Narendra

- KEY POINTS
- Judges described paper leak incidents as traumatic for students and families
 - Centre said Prime Minister Modi is personally monitoring the situation
 - Solicitor General cited new safeguards for June 21 NEET re-test
 - Court urged NTA to learn from UPSC's examination practices
 - Bench stressed strong institutions matter more than individual officers

students but also their families, who invest years of effort, hopes and resources in preparation. It described such incidents as "very traumatic" and pointed out that accountability becomes meaningful only when it is clear who bears responsibility for a lapse.

Responding to the court's observations, Mehta said, "The buck must stop somewhere."

The judges also underlined the importance of building strong institutions rather than relying on individual officers. Referring to the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), the bench observed that examinations conducted by the commission had not witnessed controversies of this nature and said the NTA could learn from such institutions.

Continued on P4

Shivakumar likely to take oath as Karnataka Chief Minister on June 3

HIGHLIGHTS

- Swearing-in ceremony to be held at Lok Bhavan Glass House in Bengaluru
- Siddaramaiah resigned after three years as Chief Minister
- Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot accepted Siddaramaiah's resignation
- Shivakumar expected to be elected Congress Legislature Party leader on Saturday
- Leadership transition follows consultations with Congress high command in Delhi
- Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge among leaders involved in discussions



BENGALURU: Senior Congress leader D K Shivakumar is set to take oath as Karnataka's 25th Chief Minister on June 3 in Bengaluru, government sources said, marking the end of a prolonged leadership battle within the state Congress.

The swearing-in ceremony will be held at the Lok Bhavan Glass House and is expected to draw senior Congress leaders, ministers, party workers and supporters from across the state.

Shivakumar, 64, will suc-

ceed Siddaramaiah, who stepped down after serving three years as Chief Minister. The change comes after a series of consultations between the Karnataka leadership and the Congress high command in New Delhi.

Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot accepted Siddaramaiah's resignation after it was submitted through the Governor's Special Secretary while Gehlot was away from Bengaluru for personal reasons. The resignation formally cleared the way for the leadership transition.

Continued on P4



Public will force even non-BJP state govts to implement UCC

Law Minister Meghwal

In today's paper

CITY

GRAP-1 RESTRICTIONS REVOKED 3

NATION

CIVIC POLLS: MVA SEAT-SHARING FINALISED 5

EDIT

BEYOND THE BATTLEFIELD 7

INTERNATIONAL

RUSSIAN DRONE VEERS OFF 8

BUSINESS

RUPEE RISES 73 PAISE TO 94.85 PER DOLLAR 10

SPORT

SATWIK-CHIRAG IN SEMIS 12

Spurious liquor kills 14 people in Pune

8 held; probe transferred to CID



Bereaved family members mourn after several people died following the consumption of suspected spurious liquor, at Phugewadi area of Pimpri Chinchwad, in Pune district, Maharashtra, Friday

MPOST BUREAU

PUNE: At least 14 people have died and five others are undergoing treatment after allegedly consuming spurious liquor in Maharashtra's Pune and Pimpri Chinchwad areas, prompting a large-scale police crackdown that has led to the arrest of eight persons and the transfer of the investigation to the Crime Investigation Department (CID).

The deaths were reported from Phugewadi in Pimpri Chinchwad and Pandhare Mala in Pune's Hadapsar area. According to police, 10 men from Phugewadi and four from Hadapsar died after allegedly consuming liquor suspected to have been mixed with methanol. Authorities are awaiting forensic and laboratory reports to establish the

exact cause of death.

The tragedy has cast a shadow over both localities, where families and residents mourned the victims.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis described the incident as "very serious" and said authorities had identified the network involved in the illegal liquor trade.

"Eight persons have been immediately arrested in this connection, and some more are also likely to be held. We have identified the complete ecosystem behind it," Fadnis told reporters in Mumbai.

He said the police and state excise department were jointly investigating the case and were trying to determine the extent of the network's operations.

Pimpri Chinchwad Joint Commissioner of Police Dr Basavraj Teli said six persons

Continued on P4

CONG ON SECOND SPOT

AAP sweeps Punjab civic polls, wins 954 wards across state

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Punjab's ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) emerged as the clear winner in the state's municipal body elections on Friday, securing more than 48 per cent of the wards counted till late evening and strengthening its position ahead of the Assembly elections due next year.

According to data released by the Punjab State Election Commission till around 9.30 pm, AAP won 954 of the 1,977 wards. The Congress finished second with 393 wards, followed by the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) with 192 and the



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann

Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann described the outcome as an endorsement of his government's development agenda. He said the people of Punjab had supported "developmental politics" and rejected what he called the opposition's "politics of hatred" and divisive campaigns.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal thanked voters for what he termed a "spectacular" victory. "By casting this historic vote, the people have applauded the work of the Bhagwant Mann government. We will continue to do good work in the same way in

Continued on P4

Govt asks fuel retailers to build LPG reserves for at least 30 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has directed state-run fuel retailers to prepare plans for creating liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) reserves sufficient to meet at least 30 days of demand, as recent supply disruptions linked to the conflict in West Asia have underlined the need for larger energy buffers.

Speaking to reporters on Friday, Petroleum Ministry Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma said oil marketing

Continued on P4

Vinesh Phogat set for Asian Games trials after Top Court green signal



Aditi Chauhan, MM Somaia to be government observers for Phogat's trial

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday allowed wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the Asian Games 2026 selection trials scheduled for May 30 and 31, refusing to halt a Delhi High Court order that had cleared her entry into the competition. At the same time, the apex court voiced reservations about parts of the High Court's reasoning and raised questions about anti-doping compliance issues linked to the wrestler. The decision comes amid a prolonged dispute between Phogat and the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) over her eligibility to return to competition following a maternity break.

A bench comprising Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe heard the WFI's challenge against the Delhi High Court verdict. With the trials set to begin within hours, the court decided against disrupting the process.

"Today at this stage, the high court having passed the order, the hope and expectations have risen. To tell her to go back home and we can't do anything, will not be proper," the bench told the WFI's counsel.

The court ordered that Phogat be allowed to participate in the Asian Games selection trials. "We are not stopping."

Continued on P4

IMD forecasts below-normal monsoon at 90% of average rainfall as El Nino threat looms

Weak El Nino expected in June, potentially strengthening by September

NEW DELHI: India is likely to receive below-normal rainfall during the southwest monsoon season this year, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Friday, lowering its earlier forecast and warning that most parts of the country, particularly key rain-fed agricultural regions, could receive less rain than usual. The forecast comes as the Centre prepares contingency plans for the Kharif season amid concerns over the possible impact of El Nino conditions, while several northern and eastern states are experiencing rain and thunderstorms that have brought temporary relief from the summer heat.

In its second forecast for the



People cover themselves during heavy rainfall, in Bengaluru, Karnataka, on Friday

June-September monsoon season, the IMD projected seasonal rainfall at 90 per cent of the Long

Period Average (LPA), with a model error margin of 4 per cent. The LPA,

Continued on P4

Storms, lightning claim 30 lives across UP, Bengal and Bihar

NEW DELHI: At least 30 people were killed across Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal and Bihar as powerful thunderstorms, heavy rain, lightning and strong winds battered large parts of northern and eastern India, triggering bridge and house collapses, transport disruptions and widespread damage.

Continued on P4

AMID OSM CONCERNS

CBSE delays re-evaluation portal launch to June 1

Around 20 cases of answer-sheet mix-ups were detected

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Friday announced that its portal for post-result activities, including verification and re-evaluation of answer books, will now become operational from June 1, postponing the earlier expected launch date of May 29. The board said the decision was taken to ensure a transparent and smooth process for students seeking verification and re-evaluation of their answer sheets, amid concerns over technical issues and answer-sheet mix-ups linked to its newly introduced on-screen marking (OSM) system.

In a statement posted on X, CBSE said the designated portal would be opened

found that the uploaded documents did not belong to them.

Among the cases that drew attention was that of Class 12 student Vedant, who alleged that the physics answer sheet provided to him during the revaluation process was not his. Another student, Sanjana, also reported a similar issue. According to sources, CBSE later contacted the affected students and shared the correct answer sheets.

"In some cases, there was a mix-up in scanning. Such cases are around 20. Students pointed it out after accessing their answer sheets," sources said.

Officials said more than 98 lakh answer sheets, amounting to nearly 40 crore pages, were scanned under the OSM system.

Continued on P4

TILJALA-KASBA 'ILLEGAL CONSTRUCTIONS'

Cal HC stays demolition move, directs KMC to hear residents

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court has directed the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) to hear both occupants and property owners before proceeding with demolition action against several buildings in Tiljala and Kasba that have been identified as unauthorised constructions.

The court directed the occupants to appear before the concerned municipal authorities within 30 days. The KMC commissioner has been asked to ensure that hearing notices are served on both occupants and owners.

THE CASE

- The court directed the occupants to appear before the concerned municipal authorities within 30 days
- According to the petitioners, the notices were merely affixed to the buildings and were not individually served on those residing or operating from the premises

Pending the exercise, the court ordered maintenance of status quo

Continued on P4

W DELHI: MANHUNT FOR 19-YR-OLD DRIVER

Pedestrian crushed to death by speeding car

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 40-year-old pedestrian was killed after a speeding car ran him over on the Ring Road in the Rajouri Garden area early Friday morning, an official said.

Police identified the vehicle's 19-year-old driver as Daksh Maurya, a resident of Shalimar Bagh in northwest Delhi. Police said they found the victim, whose identity is not yet established, lying unconscious in the middle of the road near the Marble Market on Ring Road, on the carriageway leading from west Delhi's Rajouri Garden towards Mayapuri.

"A PCR call reporting the accident was received at Rajouri Garden police station around 3:40 am, following which local police rushed to the spot. The injured man was found unresponsive, and no identity documents were recovered from him," a senior police officer said.

The victim was immediately shifted to Deen Dayal Upadhyay (DDU) Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. Police said they are trying to establish the deceased's identity and trace his family members.

The body has been preserved at the DDU Hospital mortuary for identification and postmortem, they said.

According to police, the breakthrough came after the



TAKEAWAYS

- » A PCR call reporting the accident was received at Rajouri Garden police station around 3:40 am, following which local police rushed to the spot
- » The injured man was found unresponsive, and no identity documents were recovered

- from him,' a senior police officer said
- » The victim was immediately shifted to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hosp, where doctors declared him brought dead
- » Cops said they searched the area, located the suspected offending vehicle, a Honda City

PCR caller, Gulshan, informed them that he had noticed a damaged vehicle parked on the roadside, 250 metres from the accident spot.

Police said they searched the area, located the suspected offending vehicle, a golden-brown Honda City with a Delhi registration number, abandoned on the roadside and took it into their possession for forensic examination and further investigation.

"Efforts are underway to apprehend the accused. The teams have been deployed,

and raids are being conducted at possible locations," the officer said.

An FIR has been registered under sections 281 (rash driving or riding on a public way) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the BNS at Rajouri Garden police station. Police are also examining CCTV camera footage from the stretch of Ring Road and adjoining areas to reconstruct the sequence of events and determine the vehicle's speed and movement before the collision.

Jahangirpuri: Minors apprehended for fatally stabbing man on Eid

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old man was stabbed to death allegedly following a dispute over a cigarette in northwest Delhi's Jahangirpuri on Eid night, with police apprehending three juveniles in the matter on Friday, officials said.

The deceased, Arbaaz, was a resident of C Block in Jahangirpuri and worked at a jewellery shop in the locality, police said, adding that the accused and the victim were known to each other.

According to the police, the incident took place around 11 pm on Thursday when Arbaaz was near his house and his family was celebrating Eid.

"A minor altercation reportedly broke out between him and a group allegedly over a trivial issue related to a cigarette. The argument soon escalated, following which the accused allegedly attacked Arbaaz with knives, inflicting multiple injuries," the officer said.

Arbaaz was rushed to Babu Jagiwan Ram Memorial Hospital in a critical condition and died during treatment. Soon after the incident, heavy police force deployment was made in the area to avoid any law and order situation.

Family members alleged Arbaaz was stabbed to death by six minors and an adult over a dispute that began over a cigarette. Police apprehended three juveniles and recovered the knife used in the crime. The victim's brother claimed the accused had been planning the attack for a week. A murder case has been registered and investigation is underway.

Police probes suspicious death of man in Gzb

GHAZIABAD: A 30-year-old man died under suspicious circumstances in Muradnagar's Radha Kunj Colony, prompting police to launch an investigation after the deceased's family accused his wife and in-laws of involvement in the incident.

The deceased, identified as Rahul, was living with his wife in the colony. According to police, he was taken to a nearby hospital in a critical condition, where doctors declared him dead.

After receiving information, police reached the spot, took custody of the body and sent it for postmortem examination. Officials said the exact cause of death would be known only after the report is received.

Rahul's family members alleged foul play and claimed that he had been facing domestic disputes with his wife for a long time. His mother, Saroj, alleged that the ongoing conflict between the couple may have led to the incident.

The family demanded a fair probe and strict action against those found responsible. They also urged police to thoroughly investigate the role of Rahul's wife and her family members.

FOLLOWS CITY-WIDE ANTI-DRUG DRIVE

Police to launch women safety & empowerment drive in June

Campaign to cover schools, colleges, RWAs...

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police will launch a campaign on women's safety and empowerment from June, with units of all 15 police districts organising awareness and outreach programmes to strengthen public participation and encourage prompt reporting of crimes, an official said on Friday.

Specialised units of the force will carry out the initiative with activities designed to engage women and girls from different sections of society, including students, working professionals and senior citizens, he said.

"The objective is not only to enhance awareness about safety measures but also to empower women by familiarising them with the functioning of police and the support systems available to them," the officer said.

As part of the drive, police will organise interactive sessions in schools, colleges, residential areas, community centres, resident welfare asso-



Delhi Police's PMMC Unit organised a women safety and awareness programme at YWCA Campus, Ashok Road. SI Komal Sharma conducted a cyber safety session on digital arrest scams, online frauds

Similar to anti-drug campaign, the women-centric drive will rely on extensive public outreach, community participation

cations and local stakeholders.

Women and girls will learn about emergency response systems, helpline numbers, cyber safety and legal provisions related to crimes against women, the official said.

"Participants would also be allowed to understand various police operations and interact with officers during the campaign," he stated. The initiative follows the recent launch of "Nasha Not Cool", a week-long

Ex-CCI chief Dhanendra Kumar died in blaze days before 80th birthday; son remains critical

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Days before his 80th birthday on June 6 and with preparations underway for a family gathering on May 30, former bureaucrat and the first chairman of the Competition Commission of India, Dhanendra Kumar, died after a fire tore through his south Delhi residence.

The blaze on Wednesday night also left his son, who had flown down from London especially for the celebrations, critically injured.

Kumar, a retired 1968-batch IAS officer of Haryana cadre and a former executive director representing India at the World Bank, died due to smoke inhalation after the blaze broke out at his house in the Hauz Khas Enclave late Wednesday night.

His son, Gaurav, remains admitted to a hospital after suffering injuries due to smoke inhalation. A case has been registered under sections 106 (Causing death by negligence) and 287 (rash or negligent conduct involving fire or combustible materials) of the BNS.

A pre-birthday bash with relatives and close associates



had been planned for May 30.

"Everyone was preparing to sleep after dinner. Sir's son was in his room while sir himself was inside the bathroom. Madam was in the living room. The fire was first noticed by two staff members," Abhishek Ranjan, Kumar's manager for the past 14 years, told reporters.

According to Ranjan, the fire appeared to have started after a short-circuit in the indoor unit of an air-conditioner.

"The curtains caught fire first and then the sofa beneath it. It spread very rapidly to the ground floor," he said.

According to Ranjan, the domestic staff managed to evacuate Kumar's wife, who uses a wheelchair. Kumar, how-

ever, was unaware of the fire while inside the bathroom.

"When he opened the door, there was a sudden rush of smoke. He inhaled it, fainted immediately and became unconscious. He had to be dragged out of the house," Ranjan said. Kumar's son also suffered heavy smoke inhalation while trying to locate his father inside the smoke-filled house, he added.

Ramesh Singh, who works in the neighbourhood, said the retired officer's son was "frantically searching" for his father as thick smoke engulfed the house. "The officer could not initially be located because of the smoke. Later he was found unconscious and rushed to a hospital," Singh said.

Ramesh Singh, who works in the neighbourhood, said the retired officer's son was 'frantically searching' for his father as thick smoke engulfed the house

His next door neighbour said, "A night guard on a routine round noticed the fire and alerted the neighbours who came forward to help douse the flames."According to Delhi Fire Service officials, a call reporting the blaze was received at 11.24 pm on Wednesday. Two fire tenders were rushed to the spot, which brought the fire under control by 12.20 am.

Before the firefighters arrived, Kumar and his son had already been shifted to the AIIMS Trauma Centre by police and the locals. While Kumar succumbed during treatment, his son remains hospitalised.

Police suspect no foul play and are conducting an electrical inspection. Kumar, survived

by his wife, son and daughter, was remembered as compassionate, disciplined and professionally respected. He was the first chairman of the CCI.

In the wake of frequent AC blast incidents, the Chamber of Trade and Industry (CTI) on Friday issued an advisory asking traders and market associations across Delhi to get air conditioners serviced and inspected by trained technicians amid rising temperatures and power load.

CTI chairman Brijesh Goyal said the body has written to 768 market associations and 56 industrial associations, urging them to spread awareness about safe AC usage in shops, offices and factories. The advisory follows the death of a retired IAS officer after an AC blast at a Hauz Khas residence.

CTI warned against using unauthorised mechanics for gas refilling and repairs, alleging that some use inflammable gases to cut costs, increasing fire risks. It also advised keeping inflammable materials away from outdoor AC units and ensuring regular servicing during peak summer.

Delhi Police confers honorary ranks on 221 retiring personnel

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Friday conferred honorary rank promotions on 221 retiring personnel during a pipping ceremony held at the Police Headquarters, officials said. The ceremony was presided over by Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha,

Pipping ceremony held at Police HQ

who, along with senior officers, awarded honorary promotions under the Delhi Police Honorary Rank Promotion Scheme introduced in December 2025.

According to police, 180 sub-inspectors were given the honorary rank of inspector, 30 assistant sub-inspectors were elevated to sub-inspector, and 11 head constables were promoted to assistant sub-inspector. Addressing the gathering, Golcha congratulated the retirees and said they had devoted 35 to 40 years of service to Delhi Police, the city and the nation. He described policing as more than a profession and urged the personnel to continue upholding the force's values and dignity after retirement.

Karawal Nagar shooting: 3 nabbed, weapon recovered

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested three individuals, including a 19-year-old woman, in connection with a firing incident that left a 23-year-old man injured following a minor dispute in northeast Delhi's Karawal Nagar area.

The accused were identified as Yash alias Golu alias Ashu (21), son of Brijesh, and Arpit (20), son of Vinod Kumar, both residents of Loni in Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad district. The woman was also apprehended in connection with the case.

Police said a PCR call regarding the incident was received at Karawal Nagar Police Station on May 24, while information about a gunshot injury victim admitted to GTB Hospital was also received. A police team reached the hospital, where the injured man,

Police officials said Yash later confessed during interrogation; a bike used in the crime was seized

identified as Mayank, narrated the sequence of events.

According to investigators, Mayank had gone to Magic Chilli Restaurant and Café in Shiv Vihar with his friends, including the accused, for a social gathering when an argument broke out between him and Yash alias Golu. Though Mayank tried to avoid further confrontation and leave the restaurant, Yash allegedly followed him outside and opened fire.

Police said Yash later confessed during interrogation. The pistol used in the crime and the motorcycle used to flee were recovered. Further investigation is underway.

Youth shot dead in Khajuri Khas

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 26-year-old man for allegedly shooting dead a 23-year-old youth in northeast Delhi's Khajuri Khas area over an old enmity, officials said on Friday.

The accused was identified

as Saleem Khan alias Mota alias Fighter, a resident of New Mustafabad. The victim, Raja Mevati alias Akki alias Aakib (23), was allegedly involved in a long-standing dispute with him, police said.

According to investigators, the incident took place late on May 26 after Khajuri Khas

police station received information about a firing incident. By the time police reached the spot, the injured man had already been shifted to JPC Hospital by a PCR van, where doctors declared him brought dead. Police registered a case under relevant sections of the BNS and Arms Act.

Noida airport to offer buses and cabs from day one of operations

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Passengers travelling through Noida International Airport in Greater Noida will have access to multiple transport options, including inter-city buses, airport taxis and app-based cab services, from the first day of operations on June 15, officials said.

The airport management has completed preparations to ensure smooth connectivity for travellers and has signed agreements with several transport companies and state road transport corporations. IndiGo and Akasa Air are expected to begin flight operations during the initial phase.

Officials said passengers will be able to use app-based



cab services such as Uber, Ola and Rapido directly from the airport. Mahindra Logistics will also launch premium electric cab services, offering chauffeur-driven vehicles for business and premium travellers.

To improve regional connectivity, multiple road transport corporations will operate direct bus services linking the airport with key NCR cities and neighbouring states. Uttara-

khand Transport Corporation will run buses to Dehradun, Haridwar, Rishikesh and Haldwani, while Haryana Roadways will connect the airport with Chandigarh, Gurugram, Faridabad and Palwal.

Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses will provide services to Kashmiri Gate ISBT, Sarai Kale Khan ISBT, Anand Vihar ISBT and New Delhi railway station. Airport authorities said an agreement has also

been signed with Uttar Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation (UPSRTC), and direct services from several cities in Uttar Pradesh will start soon.

In addition, NCR airport shuttle services will operate from Noida, Greater Noida, Botanical Garden metro station, Ghaziabad and Akshardham to make airport access easier for commuters.

Airport officials said bus services will initially operate from 8am to 8pm and could be expanded depending on passenger demand.

Noida airport nodal officer Shailendra Bhatia said all transport arrangements had been finalised to ensure hassle-free travel for passengers from the first day of airport operations.



Free DTC rides for NEET students: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major relief for students appearing in NEET (UG) 2026, the Delhi government has announced free travel in all DTC buses for candidates on June 21, the day of the national medical entrance examination.

The decision was announced by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who said candidates would only need to show their valid NEET admit card to avail the free travel facility and reach their examination centres without hassle.

The move comes amid concerns over stress and logistical difficulties faced by students after the recent cancellation and rescheduling of the examination. The government said the initiative aims to reduce transportation-related anxiety and ensure that aspirants can focus entirely on the exam.

Announcing the decision, the Chief Minister said, “The future and time of students are invaluable, and it is our responsibility to keep them free from stress.”

She added that important examinations like NEET are directly linked to the future of lakhs of young students and the government must extend every possible support during such crucial moments. “Our effort is to ensure that candidates do not face any transportation-related inconvenience on the day of the examination,” she said.

According to the government, DTC buses will also provide improved connectivity to metro stations and key examination routes to ensure seamless last-mile travel for students

“The future and time of students are invaluable, and it is our responsibility to keep them free from stress — CM Gupta

across Delhi. Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh welcomed the initiative and thanked the Chief Minister for what he described as a “student-centric decision.”

“The Delhi Government is committed to ensuring that NEET aspirants can appear for their examination without transportation concerns. Through free DTC travel and enhanced connectivity arrangements, we aim to support students in reaching their centres smoothly and on time,” he said.

Officials said the facility will be available across the DTC network throughout June 21 and candidates will simply have to present their NEET admit cards during travel.

The government also appealed to students to plan their commute in advance and make use of the facility to avoid delays on examination day.

Extending her best wishes to aspirants, the Chief Minister urged students to appear for the examination with confidence and dedication. She said the Delhi government remains committed to creating a supportive environment for students and ensuring that no candidate faces avoidable difficulties while pursuing their academic goals.

AI shield for city’s dust pollution

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major technology-driven step to curb dust pollution in the Capital, the Delhi government is set to launch the upgraded DUST Portal 2.0, an artificial intelligence-powered monitoring platform designed to keep 24x7 surveillance on construction sites across the city.

The advanced portal, developed by the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC), was reviewed on Friday by Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa during a high-level meeting attended by senior officials.

Officials informed the minister that the new system will use AI-powered cameras, PM sensors, automated audits and real-time analytics to detect dust pollution violations and strengthen environmental compliance at construction sites.

According to the government, the portal will monitor critical pollution-control measures including installation of



high-density green anti-dust nets, deployment of anti-smog guns and particulate matter levels at project sites. Automatic alerts will be generated if pollution levels exceed prescribed limits, enabling authorities to take swift corrective action.

Speaking during the review meeting, Sirsa said, “Our objective is not merely to collect data but to establish accountability. Every construction site must comply with dust control norms, and technology will help us identify violations in real time.”

“Development works in Delhi cannot come at the cost of public health. DUST Portal 2.0 will ensure transparency,

accountability and swift action against negligence,” he added.

One of the key features of the platform is a QR code-based site monitoring system. Every registered construction site will receive a unique QR code, allowing field officers to instantly access site details, compliance records and audit reports through mobile devices during inspections.

The portal will also include a three-tier AI-based alert mechanism. A Yellow Alert will act as an early warning when pollution thresholds are crossed, while an Orange Alert will indicate moderate violations linked to non-compliance.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Clouds shrouded the city and trace rain was reported in a few areas on Friday as Delhi recorded its lowest maximum in 21 days and witnessed a sharp fall in temperatures of up to 9.4 degrees Celsius in places over the past 48 hours.

The city’s maximum temperature settled at 36.8 degrees Celsius on Friday, the lowest since May 8 when it stood at 36.4 degrees Celsius. During the intervening 21 days, the mercury steadily climbed, crossing the 45-degree Celsius mark amid prolonged heatwave conditions.

According to India Meteorological Department (IMD)



data, temperatures across the national capital dropped sharply over the past 48 hours.

Safdarjung recorded a decline of 7.5 degrees Celsius, with the maximum temperature falling from 44.3 degrees Celsius

on May 27 to 36.8 degrees Celsius on Friday. Ridge witnessed a drop of 8.8 degrees Celsius, from 45.6 degrees Celsius to 36.8 degrees Celsius.

The sharpest decline was recorded at Ayanagar and

Palam, where maximum temperatures fell by 9.4 degrees Celsius each. Ayanagar cooled from 45.4 degrees Celsius to 36.0 degrees Celsius, while Palam dropped from 44.6 degrees Celsius to 35.2 degrees Celsius. Lodhi Road also saw a substantial fall of 8.9 degrees Celsius, with the maximum temperature decreasing from 44.6 degrees Celsius to 35.7 degrees Celsius. The minimum temperature was recorded at 25.3 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 1.3 degrees below normal, 24.1 degrees Celsius at Palam, 2.8 degrees below normal, 25.6 degrees Celsius at Lodhi Road, 0.4 degrees below normal, 24.0 degrees Celsius at Ridge, 2.6 degrees below normal, and 25.4

degrees Celsius at Ayanagar, 2.0 degrees below normal. Rainfall during the 24-hour period ending 8.30 am was recorded at 4.0 mm at Safdarjung, 4.3 mm at Palam and 3.8 mm at Ayanagar, while Lodhi Road recorded trace rainfall. No rainfall was recorded at Ridge during the period. The IMD has forecast thunderstorms accompanied by rain to persist till May 31. For Saturday, the weather office has predicted a minimum temperature of around 23 degrees Celsius and a maximum temperature of around 35 degrees Celsius. A yellow alert has been issued for thunderstorms accompanied by rain. Mahesh Palawat of Sky-

met Weather attributed the weather activity to a western disturbance over the hills, an induced cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan and adjoining areas, along with humid winds from the Bay of Bengal that have increased moisture levels over the city. “The current spell of pre-monsoon rains is likely to be stronger than the pre-monsoon showers witnessed in Delhi earlier this month and in April, leading to widespread rainfall activity across the city,” Palawat said. Delhi’s Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 123 in the ‘moderate’ category at 4 pm on Friday, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

TO SLASH CAPITAL’S TRAVEL TIME

Malhotra unveils signal-free road plan

AIMAN FATIMA

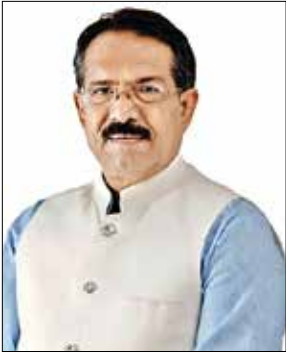
NEW DELHI: Promising major relief from Delhi’s worsening traffic congestion, newly appointed Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra on Friday unveiled an ambitious road-map for signal-free corridors and elevated roads across key stretches of the Capital, aimed at drastically cutting travel time for commuters.

Speaking about the party’s infrastructure vision after taking charge as Delhi BJP chief on May 28, Malhotra said the proposed projects would ensure

uninterrupted vehicular movement on some of Delhi’s busiest routes. The projects, estimated to cost between ₹650 crore and ₹850 crore, are targeted for completion before 2029.

A major focus of the plan is easing congestion around Kalindi Kunj, one of Delhi’s most traffic-choked stretches connecting multiple routes towards Noida and Faridabad. Malhotra said elevated signal-free roads are being planned near Kalindi Kunj Metro Station to reduce bottlenecks.

“Today it takes nearly an hour to cross that stretch.



Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra

After the project, travel time will reduce to just five to seven

minutes,” he said. He added that authorities are assessing whether the existing Okhla Barrage bridge can be utilised for the project. “If the current bridge cannot be used, we will have to construct a new two-lane bridge,” he said.

Malhotra also revealed that three major elevated road corridors are currently in the proposal stage. These include the heavily congested Ashram-Badarpur stretch, where three elevated roads are planned to ensure smoother traffic flow.

Another key proposal is an 8-km elevated corridor from

Punjabi Bagh to the Tigri border. “At present, commuters spend nearly two hours travelling on this route. After completion, the journey will be reduced to around 25 minutes,” he said.

The third proposed corridor will connect Mehrauli to Gurgaon, targeting smoother inter-city movement between Delhi and Haryana. Malhotra described the Punjabi Bagh-Tigri project as the costliest among the planned developments.

“There is not a single major congestion point that we are ignoring. Our effort is to create a

network of signal-free roads that gives Delhi faster and smoother connectivity,” he said.

Referring to the BJP forming the government in Delhi after 27 years under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Malhotra said the focus is now on delivering long-term infrastructure solutions.

Malhotra also highlighted one of the key proposals, stating, “where Faridabad is ending, from there we are working on an elevated road for Jewar. Once completed, travel time from Sarai Kale Khan to Jewar will come down to around 45 minutes,” he said.

Surprise: CM Rekha fumes over poor facilities at Rohini sub-registrar office

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday expressed strong displeasure over the poor condition and alleged administrative negligence at the Revenue Department’s E-Sub-Registrar offices in Rohini after conducting a surprise inspection of the premises.

During her visit to E-Sub-Registrar Offices VI-A (Model Town/Pitampura) and VI-C (Rohini), operating from Ambedkar Bhawan in Rohini Sector-16, the Chief Minister found several deficiencies including broken flooring, poor lighting, non-functional air-conditioners, unhygienic toilets, inadequate seating arrangements and disorganised record management.

Taking serious note of the situation, the Chief Minister directed officials to complete all repair and improvement work within one week and warned of strict action in case of corruption, negligence or unnecessary delays in public service delivery.

Calling the condition of the office unacceptable, Rekha Gupta said, “Providing basic amenities in offices is the government’s responsibility. Such disarray will not be tolerated under any circumstances.”

The Chief Minister also



interacted directly with citizens present at the office, many of whom complained about long waiting hours, lack of seating, poor ventilation and the absence of a proper token system.

She instructed officials on the spot to ensure that citizens are not subjected to inconvenience while visiting government offices for property registration and documentation work. “It is unacceptable that elderly citizens, women and others visiting the office for official work should be made to stand for hours,” she said.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister expressed surprise over the deteriorat-

ing condition of the building and questioned the accountability of officials. “If lights are not working, toilets are unusable, floors are damaged and even basic seating arrangements are unavailable, it raises serious questions about administrative responsibility,” she remarked.

The Chief Minister also inspected the record room and directed officials to prioritise the digitisation, preservation and security of important revenue records to prevent any loss of documents due to accidents or technical failures.

She further directed authorities to fix responsibility for regular maintenance of the premises

and appoint dedicated officers or caretakers for monitoring cleanliness and civic upkeep.

Taking a tough stand against corruption and delays, Rekha Gupta warned, “No citizen should have to run from office to office or face harassment for getting legitimate work done.” She added that any complaint related to bribery, harassment or deliberate delay would invite the “strictest action” against the concerned officials.

The Chief Minister has sought a detailed compliance report within one week and said she would personally conduct a follow-up inspection to review the improvements.

NDMC says around 80% desilting work complete

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Friday said around 80 per cent of the second phase of desilting works in its areas has been completed, and the remaining work will be finished before June 15 as part of its monsoon preparedness plan.

NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal conducted an inspection of drainage arrangements and waterlogging-prone stretches between Africa Avenue and RK Ashram Marg, along with senior officials from the engineering and public health departments.

Chahal said only two vulnerable waterlogging locations — South Avenue and Janpath — remain in NDMC area, and CCTV cameras and sensor-based surveillance systems are being installed for real-time monitoring during heavy rainfall.

“Effective solutions will be implemented at both locations before the onset of the mon-

soon,” he said, adding that the NDMC aims to become a “zero waterlogging-sensitive zone.”

According to NDMC officials, the first phase of desilting operations was completed by March 31, during which 7,888 bell mouths, 4,833 gully traps and 8,913 manholes were cleaned.

“The second phase of desilting is around 80 per cent complete and is targeted 100 per cent completion before June 15,” Chahal said.

He said the civic body has arranged de-watering pumps, generator sets, manpower and control rooms to tackle waterlogging during monsoon.

NDMC teams are working round-the-clock to ensure citizens do not face any inconvenience during monsoon, Chahal said. GIS mapping of the underground drainage network has also been initiated to improve monitoring and management of waterlogging-prone areas. MPPOST

City Briefs

SHALIMAR BAGH TO GET 1,000-SEAT AUDITORIUM, COMMUNITY CENTRE

New Delhi: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Friday signed a memorandum of understanding with NBCC (India) Ltd for constructing a 1,000-seat auditorium and community centre in Shalimar Bagh. Officials said the proposed project, to be developed under the Chief Minister Development Fund, will feature a ‘modern’ auditorium with a seating capacity of around 1,000 people and two conference halls, each accommodating nearly 100 persons. The officials said the facility is planned as a multi-purpose civic and cultural hub for hosting seminars, public events, cultural programmes, workshops and official functions. It will be used by educational institutions, resident welfare associations, cultural groups and government departments. “The upcoming auditorium and community centre are expected to become an important social and cultural hub for residents of Shalimar Bagh and nearby areas,” the statement said.

MCD INSTALLS MODERN LIFT AT CITY-SP ZONE OFFICE TO IMPROVE PUBLIC ACCESS

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Friday inaugurated a modern lift at its City-SP Zone office as part of efforts to improve accessibility and upgrade civic infrastructure. The facility, inaugurated by Mayor Pravesh Wahi, is to ease access to the office for citizens, according to a statement by the civic body. “The new lift would greatly benefit not only the general public but also senior citizens, persons with disabilities, and employees,” Wahi said. Addressing the public, the mayor said the corporation is making its offices more modern, accessible and citizen-friendly through infrastructure upgradation initiatives.

AAP STAGES ‘MATKA PHOR’ PROTEST OVER WATER SHORTAGE IN DELHI

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party on Friday held a ‘Matka Phor’ protest in Delhi against the alleged water scarcity in several parts of the city and alleged a decline in water supply under the BJP government. The AAP leaders and workers led by MLA Kuldeep Kumar gathered during the protest at the Delhi Jal Board office in Mayapuri Vihar Phase-2, carrying earthen pots and placards with slogans such as “Rekha Gupta Paani Do” and “BJP Haye Haye”. The protesters alleged that many areas in the national capital were facing a shortage of drinking water and claimed that in several localities, households were receiving contaminated or sewer-mixed water.

SUPREME COURT ORDERS DERC APPOINTMENTS IN TWO MONTHS

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday asked a selection committee appointed by the city government to ensure the appointments of chairperson and two members to the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission within two months. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi took on record a notification issued by the BJP government in Delhi that said it constituted a search and selection committee to fill up three vacant posts in the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) on May 27 in pursuance of an earlier direction. The bench asked the search panel to make an endeavour to select and ensure the appointments of the chairperson and two members in the DERC within a period of two months.

GRAP-1 restrictions revoked

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) on Friday revoked stage one curbs under the Graded Response Action Plan in Delhi-NCR, following significant improvement in air quality.

Owing to favourable meteorological conditions, the air quality index (AQI) of Delhi was recorded at 123, in the ‘moderate’ category on Friday, according to CAQM.

Further, the forecast by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM) indicates that AQI is likely to remain in ‘moderate’ category in the coming days, an official said.

GRAP-1 restrictions have been in force under an order issued May 19.

With the revocation of GRAP-1, restrictions such as ban on use of coal and firewood as fuel in tandoors in hotels, restaurants, and open eateries, and use of diesel generators only in emergency or essential situations, are removed.

There are four stages under GRAP, each linked to AQI readings. The first stage, GRAP-1, kicks in when AQI is between 201 and 300; the second stage, GRAP-2, is invoked when the AQI is between 301 and 400; GRAP-3 kicks in between 401 and 500; and GRAP-4 is invoked when the AQI is more than 450.

From Page 1

SC seeks

“It is not the individual who has the capability, it is the institution which has the capability,” the court said, stressing the need for durable systems and continuity.

The hearing came after the court’s May 25 order directing responses from the Centre, NTA and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on pleas seeking structural reforms in the examination agency. The court had then observed that it was unfortunate that lessons from the earlier NEET controversy had not been fully absorbed.

The bench noted that the NTA’s Director (Legal) had filed an affidavit detailing steps taken after previous controversies and said it would continue monitoring the implementation of reforms. It also took note of an affidavit filed by Dr K. Radhakrishnan, former chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), who heads the high-powered steering committee overseeing NTA reforms.

The court asked the Centre to file a detailed affidavit within six weeks explaining how examinations would be conducted and concluded in future years and what measures would ensure continuity of expertise, specialised personnel and institutional memory within the agency.

According to the court, the objective is to ensure that the NTA possesses the physical and intellectual capacity needed to prevent a repeat of incidents such as those witnessed in the 2024 and 2026 examinations. The matter has been scheduled for further hearing in the second week of July.

Questioning Radhakrishnan on the implementation of reforms, the bench asked how the latest failure had occurred despite monitoring mechanisms being put in place. The judges observed that if an incident still took place after recommendations were made, it was necessary to examine whether the original framework had anticipated all possible risks.

Radhakrishnan informed the court that many recommendations had already been initiated. He said the 2025 NEET-UG examination had been conducted “almost satisfactorily”, with only a few instances of power failure at some centres.

In a separate affidavit, the NTA informed the court that it plans to shift NEET-UG to a computer-based test (CBT) format from the next examination cycle after consultations with the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.

The agency stated that a High-Level Committee of Experts (HLCE), constituted by the Ministry of Education in June 2024 under Radhakrishnan’s chairmanship, had recommended moving away from the pen-and-paper format. The committee submitted its report in October 2024, containing 101 recommendations.

To oversee implementation, the ministry set up a High-Powered Steering Committee in November 2024. According to the affidavit, a substantial number of the recommendations have already been implemented or are at advanced stages of execution.

The NTA said NEET-UG 2026, conducted on May 3, was held at 5,432 centres and attended by more than 22.05 lakh candidates. Following allegations of a paper leak, the examination was cancelled on May 12 and a re-test was scheduled for June 21. The alleged leak is currently under investigation by the CBI.

The agency said the upcoming re-examination would be conducted under a strengthened standard operating procedure framework featuring multi-layer authentication, enhanced surveillance and greater inter-agency coordination. The NTA also outlined additional reforms, including greater randomisation and rotation in the selection of paper setters, moderators, translators and proofreaders. It said artificial intelligence tools would be used for at least 85 per cent of translation work to reduce human intervention, shorten processing time and lower the risk of security breaches. Calling examination integrity a matter of public trust, the NTA told the court that it was fully cooperating with the CBI investigation and remained committed to safeguarding the interests of millions of genuine aspirants across the country.

Shivakumar

At a breakfast meeting with cabinet colleagues on Thursday, Siddaramaiah informed ministers of his decision and indicated that Shivakumar would take over in accordance with directions from the Congress leadership. The move brings to a close months of speculation over a possible change at the top.

Shivakumar is expected to be elected leader of the Congress Legislature Party on Saturday, after which he will become Chief Minister-designate.

The transition follows intense discussions in Delhi this week. Both Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar met senior Congress leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge, K C Venugopal and Randeep Surjewala.

Talk of a rotational chief minister arrangement has circulated since Congress returned to power in Karnataka in 2023. Under the widely discussed formula, Siddaramaiah was expected to step aside midway through the term to allow Shivakumar to lead the government for the remaining period, although the arrangement was never publicly confirmed.

Attention has now shifted to the composition of the new cabinet. Sources said discussions on Friday focused on balancing continuity and change, with the possibility of retaining some ministers while bringing in fresh faces. Several ministers and legislators have been in Delhi as consultations over portfolios and cabinet berths continue.

Spurious liquor

had been arrested in connection with the deaths in the industrial township. The accused were identified as Karnelsingh Takhtsingh Virka (73), Gurmangatsingh Karnelsingh Virka (45), Yogesh Ramchandra Wankhede (23), Radhesham Hariaram Prapajati (35), Indarjit Kaur Karnelsingh Virka (60) and Kalpesh Agrawal (29).

According to police, Karnelsingh, Gurmangatsingh, Wankhede and Prapajati have been remanded in police custody until June 8, while Indarjit Kaur and Agrawal will be produced before a court on Saturday.

The accused have been booked under several provisions, including culpable homicide not amounting to murder. Teli said the probe had now been handed over to the CID.

Investigators suspect the accused supplied methanol-laced liquor to Phugewadi and parts of Pune city.

The victims from Phugewadi were identified as Pandurang Sakharam Phuge (53), Akbar Azimkhan Pathan (48), Rajesh Shantaram Rajput (50), Anand Panderao Desai (53), Anand Kashinath Nikalje (64), Bhimania Basanna Nagara (27), Akshay Ashok Avasarmal (28), Sachin Ramchandra Netke (36), Surappa Manappa Bangari (55) and Raju Rathod (34).

In Pune city, Commissioner of Police Amitesh Kumar said four deaths linked to suspected spurious liquor consumption had been reported from Hadapsar.

“The post-mortem examinations of the deceased have been conducted. The viscera samples have been preserved and sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory. Once the FSL report is received, the exact contents in the body and the precise cause of death will be ascertained,” he said.

Police have registered a case against Akash Jadhav and several unidentified persons under charges including culpable homicide not amounting to murder, causing hurt through poisonous substances, negligent acts endangering life, sale of noxious food or drink, and provisions of the Maharashtra Prohibition Act.

Kumar said investigators were also examining CCTV footage from the location where the liquor was allegedly consumed.

“We will not spare anyone involved in this racket,” he said.

Senior Inspector Sanjay Mogale of Hadapsar police station said the deceased had allegedly purchased the liquor from Jadhav in the Pandhare Mala area. After consuming it, they reportedly suffered vomiting and dizziness.

The four victims from Hadapsar were identified as Arun Dadar (60), Rahul Kshirsagar (45), Ashok Chavan (52) and Datta Suryawanshi (55). State excise department official Atul Kanade said the department had launched a parallel inquiry. He said Yogesh Wankhede, allegedly involved in supplying spurious liquor to both Phugewadi and Hadapsar, had been detained and handed over to Pimpri Chinchwad police. Doctors treating the victims described symptoms commonly associated with toxic alcohol consumption. Dr Rajendra Wable, Dean of Yashwantrao Chavan Memorial Hospital, said most of the deceased had a history of heavy drinking and arrived with breathing difficulties, acidosis, frothing, dizziness and unconsciousness.

“Usually, the symptoms begin with respiratory complaints, followed by heaviness in the head and increased heartbeat. Subsequently, the patient’s condition becomes critical,” he said.

Meanwhile, NCP (SP) leader

Rohit Pawar and party workers demolished an alleged liquor den in Hadapsar. In a social media post, Pawar termed the incident “extremely horrifying” and alleged administrative failures, claiming that 18 people had died after consuming poisonous liquor in the affected areas. Authorities, however, have officially confirmed 14 deaths so far while investigations continue.

AAP sweeps

the future,” he said.

Kejriwal also targeted the BJP, referring to it as the “ED party” and claiming that voters had responded to raids conducted on traders in the state. Senior AAP leader Manish Sisodia echoed the criticism, saying people had rejected “ED politics”. He also claimed that 1,142 BJP candidates had forfeited their security deposits.

The elections were held on May 26 across 102 urban local bodies, including eight municipal corporations, 75 municipal councils and 19 nagar panchayats. Voting was conducted through ballot papers and recorded a turnout of 63.94 per cent. Of the 1,977 wards, candidates in 80 were elected unopposed. A total of 7,554 candidates contested the polls.

In the municipal corporation elections, AAP recorded sweeping victories in Moga, Barnala, Bathinda and Batala, winning 30, 36, 31 and 30 wards respectively. The party also emerged as the single largest formation in Mohali with 26 wards. Congress dominated Kapurthala by winning 31 wards, while the BJP became the largest party in Pathankot and Abohar with 22 and 28 wards respectively. Each municipal corporation has 50 wards.

AAP also performed strongly in several municipal councils. In Dhuri, Mann’s home constituency, the party won 19 of 21 wards, while Independents secured the remaining two. In Gidderbaha, regarded as a stronghold of Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, AAP won 17 of 19 wards and Congress took two. Congress, however, performed well in Chamkaur Sahib Municipal Council, winning seven of 13 wards. AAP and Independents secured three wards each. In Majitha Municipal Council, AAP won seven wards while SAD claimed six.

Among notable results, AAP candidates Sunny Ahluwalia and Sarabjeet Singh, son of AAP MLA Kulwant Singh, won from wards 6 and 42 in Mohali. Congress leader and former health minister Balbir Singh Sidhu’s son, Kanwarbir Singh Sidhu, lost from ward 10.

Opposition parties accused the AAP government of misusing official machinery during the election process. Despite criticism, the results provided a major boost to the ruling party, while Congress showed pockets of strength, SAD retained a visible urban presence, and the BJP fell short of its expectations of expanding its support base in Punjab’s urban centres.

Govt asks fuel retailers

companies had been asked to work on a strategy to maintain a minimum 30-day LPG reserve in addition to their regular commercial inventories. “We are working on the strategic reserves. Oil marketing companies have been asked to work out (a plan) to have LPG reserves for a minimum of 30 days with them, and they are working on it,” Sharma said.

The directive has been issued to state-owned fuel retailers Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL), which together dominate India’s fuel market.

The move comes after a three-month conflict in West Asia disrupted global energy supplies. According to the government, around 40 per cent of India’s crude oil imports, 65 per cent of natural gas imports and 90 per cent of LPG supplies originate from Gulf countries and were affected by the disruption.

While India has managed to secure alternative supplies of crude oil and natural gas, LPG availability has been impacted, leading authorities to regulate supplies to commercial consumers.

Sharma also said the government was working on expanding crude oil storage capacity, although she did not provide further details.

Despite the disruptions, the government said the country currently has adequate stocks of crude oil, petrol, diesel, LPG and natural gas. Refineries are operating at optimum levels, while domestic LPG production has reached a record high of around 52,000 tonnes per day.

“No dry out reported at any LPG distributorship,” Sharma said.

At the same time, authorities have observed unusually high

fuel sales across several regions. Sharma said more than 150 districts recorded petrol sales growth of over 30 per cent, while sales doubled in 14 districts. Diesel sales increased by more than 30 per cent in 156 districts, with six districts reporting growth exceeding 100 per cent.

According to the ministry, higher demand is being driven partly by agricultural activity and by consumers shifting purchases from private retailers and bulk suppliers to state-run outlets because of pricing differences.

IOC, BPCL and HPCL, which control about 90 per cent of the market, have increased petrol and diesel prices by around Rs 7.50 per litre since May 15. The government said it is reviewing the situation and has advised states and Union Territories to form special squads to check hoarding and black marketing. Consumers have also been urged to avoid panic buying and purchase fuel only through authorised channels.

CBSE delays

During the process, around 68,000 answer sheets were identified as having scanning quality issues and were rescanned. However, more than 13,000 answer books still failed to achieve the required level of legibility and had to be evaluated manually.

Sources said experts from IIT Madras, IIT Kanpur and the Digital Infrastructure Corporation of India (DICI) are reviewing the system and working on strengthening the portal and payment gateway integration. “The teams are examining the code and the system to make it seamless and glitch-free,” they said.

Defending the technology-driven evaluation system, officials said it improves transparency and enables digital sharing of answer sheets with students. They added that from next year, answer sheets will also be made available through DigiLocker alongside mark sheets.

The OSM contract has also attracted political attention. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has questioned the award of the contract to Coempt, formerly known as Globarena, and demanded an independent judicial inquiry and a Special Investigation Team probe into the matter. According to government sources, Coempt emerged as the lowest bidder after quoting about Rs 24.75 per answer booklet, compared to Tata Consultancy Services’ bid of around Rs 65-66.

Vinesh Phogat

You go ahead and participate,” the bench observed, while noting her contributions to Indian wrestling and stating that she had made the country proud.

However, the Supreme Court clarified that its decision should not be interpreted as approval of the High Court’s findings. The judges questioned how the WFI’s selection policy, introduced in February 2026 and applicable to all wrestlers, had been termed “exclusionary” without detailed reference to existing rules or sports policies.

The bench also expressed concern over issues related to anti-doping compliance. During the hearing, it referred to records indicating that Phogat had missed a doping test and had faced questions regarding whereabouts filings. The judges noted that international sports regulations treat such matters seriously and that any disqualification at the global level could reflect on the country. The court referred to Phogat’s decision to take a sabbatical in December 2024 and her subsequent communication that the break had ended in June 2025. It also noted a communication indicating that a doping test scheduled on January 5 was missed and that there were concerns regarding her whereabouts information. The bench observed that the International Testing Agency had considered her explanation in an order issued in May this year. Phogat, who is also a Haryana MLA, had cited participation in an Assembly session as part of her explanation.

Senior advocate Madhavi Divan, appearing for Phogat, maintained that the wrestler was not seeking any special treatment. “I just want to participate,” Divan told the court, adding that Phogat was not asking for concessions or exemptions and merely wanted an opportunity to compete.

The Supreme Court acknowledged Phogat’s stature, describing her as “not an ordinary athlete”. At the same time, the bench repeatedly stressed that eligibility and compliance standards must apply in national team selection. “Country first,” the court remarked during the proceedings.

The controversy began after the WFI revised its selection policy and declared Phogat ineligible for domestic events until June 26, cit-

ing the mandatory six-month notice period required for athletes returning from retirement under anti-doping regulations. Phogat challenged the decision, arguing that the policy unfairly affected her return to the sport after childbirth.

On May 22, a division bench of the Delhi High Court allowed her to compete in the trials, ruling that the federation’s policy lacked sufficient discretion to accommodate an accomplished athlete returning from maternity leave. The High Court directed that the trials be video-recorded and ordered the presence of independent observers from both the Sports Authority of India (SAI) and the Indian Olympic Association (IOA).

The High Court had also observed that motherhood should not become a basis for excluding female athletes from competition and criticised a show-cause notice issued by the WFI on May 9. It described the federation’s reference to Phogat’s disqualification from the Paris Olympics as a “national embarrassment” as “deplorable” and “ought to have been avoided”.

For the trials in New Delhi, former India football goalkeeper Aditi Chauhan will serve as the IOA observer, while Olympic gold medalist and former hockey captain M.M. Somaiya will represent the Sports Ministry and SAI. Chauhan, who earned 57 caps for India and previously played for West Ham United in England, currently serves as programme officer for the IOA Athlete Commission. Somaiya was a member of India’s gold medal-winning hockey team at the 1980 Moscow Olympics and later captained the side at the 1988 Seoul Games.

The legal battle has drawn significant attention because of Phogat’s standing in Indian sport and her history of conflict with the WFI. She was among the leading wrestlers who protested in 2023 against former WFI president and BJP leader Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh over allegations of sexual harassment.

Phogat’s sporting career also drew international attention in August 2024 when she was disqualified from the women’s 50kg final at the Paris Olympics after being found 100 grams overweight during the morning weigh-in.

The Supreme Court has posted the matter for further hearing next week. For now, the ruling clears the way for the 31-year-old wrestler to compete for a place in India’s Asian Games squad, with the outcome now set to be decided on the mat rather than in the courtroom.

Cal HC stays

of the buildings. Municipal authorities have, however, been permitted to remove portions considered dangerous after consulting the occupants. The question of the petitions’ maintainability remains open for further consideration.

A vacation bench of Justice Shampa Dutt (Paul) passed the order while hearing a batch of petitions filed by residents and occupants of around five buildings.

The petitioners challenged demolition notices issued by the civic body under Section 400(1) of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation Act, which empowers authorities to order the removal of structures raised without approval.

According to the petitioners, the notices were merely affixed to the buildings and were not individually served on those residing or operating from the premises. They argued that the proposed action would affect more than 150 occupants, many of whom had not been given an opportunity to present their case before the authorities.

Appearing for the state, Additional Advocate General Biddwal Bhattacharyya questioned the maintainability of the petitions, contending that the occupants had not established that the buildings possessed valid municipal sanction.

The state also argued that serving notices on every individual occupant would be impractical.

Senior advocate Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharyya, representing the petitioners, criticised the manner in which the notices had been issued. He submitted that the structures had existed for years and that residents should not face demolition without being heard.

Storms, lightning

Uttar Pradesh reported the highest death toll, with 16 people losing their lives after a severe storm swept through several districts late Thursday night and early Friday. The deadliest incident occurred in Hamirpur district, where six labourers were killed when a slab of an under-construction bridge over the Betwa river collapsed during intense rain and hailstorms.

The accident took place around 2 am in the Lalpura area, about 25 kilometres from the district headquarters. Officials said workers engaged in the bridge project had taken shelter beneath the structure as the storm intensified. Moments later, a massive slab gave way, trapping them under the debris.

State Disaster Response Force teams conducted a rescue operation that lasted nearly seven-and-a-half hours. Three injured workers were rescued and shifted for treatment, while six labourers were found dead. Four of the deceased were from Banda district and two were residents of Hamirpur.

A survivor said workers from two shifts were present at the site. “To protect ourselves from the storm, we lay down on the bridge. Suddenly the slab collapsed,” he said.

The 700-metre-long two-lane bridge, being constructed by the Uttar Pradesh State Bridge Corporation between Morakand and Kurara village at a cost of around Rs 90 crore, has been under construction since March 2024 and is scheduled for completion by December 2026. Corporation Managing Director Dharmveer Singh said preliminary information suggested the collapse was linked to the severe storm and rainfall, adding that an inquiry would be conducted.

The weather system caused destruction across several other districts in Uttar Pradesh. Four members of a family, including a mother, son and daughter, died in Kaushambi after a tree fell on their mud house. Two tourists were killed in Saharanpur when heavy rain triggered a sudden flow of water and debris from nearby hills, washing away around 10 vehicles, including an Innova and a tractor. One death each was reported from Azamgarh, Pratapgarh, Fatehpur and Ambedkar Nagar.

Strong winds and rain affected Lucknow, Varanasi, Prayagraj and nearly 20 other districts. Wind speeds in Hamirpur reached 70 to 80 kmph, while some places reportedly recorded gusts of up to 100 kmph. Waterlogging was reported outside the trauma centre of Banaras Hindu University in Varanasi. Trees and electric poles were uprooted in several districts, disrupting power supply and traffic. In Jhansi, a pipeline collapsed, while snapped overhead electric wires delayed train services.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath directed district officials to carry out relief operations and provide assistance to affected families. The Meteorological Department issued thunderstorm warnings for all 75 districts of the state and heavy rainfall alerts for at least 12 districts.

In West Bengal, seven people died in weather-related incidents after intense thunderstorms and heavy rain struck Kolkata and several districts of south Bengal on Friday afternoon. Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari said the deaths were caused by house collapses, electrocution and lightning strikes in South 24 Parganas, North 24 Parganas, Howrah, Hooghly, Paschim Medinipore and Purulia districts. The state government announced compensation of Rs 4 lakh each for the families of the victims.

The storm disrupted normal life across Kolkata and surrounding areas. Flight operations at Kolkata airport were suspended for more than an hour due to waterlogged airstrips. Train services on the Bongaon section of the Sealdah suburban network were affected after uprooted trees fell on tracks and overhead wires. Around 36 trees were uprooted in and around Kolkata, damaging vehicles and disrupting traffic. A delivery worker in Salt Lake was injured by a lightning strike.

Strong winds of 50 to 60 kmph, with gusts exceeding 80 kmph at times, also damaged portions of the overhead structure at Sahid Kshudiram Metro station, affecting services on the Blue Line. The India Meteorological Department said thunderstorm activity was likely to continue across south Bengal over the next two days and advised fishermen not to venture into the sea along the West Bengal and north Odisha coasts.

Bihar reported seven deaths due to lightning strikes as heavy rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds swept through several districts. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary said three people died in Gaya district, two in Aurangabad and one each in Saran and Khagaria. He announced an ex gratia payment of Rs 4 lakh for the families of the deceased and directed officials to assess crop damage caused by heavy rain and hailstorms.

Authorities across the affected states urged residents to remain indoors during severe weather and follow safety advisories as unstable conditions persisted in the region.

MP05T

IMD forecasts

calculated from rainfall data

recorded between 1971 and 2020, stands at 87 cm.

The latest forecast is lower than the IMD’s first outlook issued on April 13, when it had estimated seasonal rainfall at 92 per cent of the LPA.

According to the weather office, the Northeast is expected to receive normal rainfall, while most other regions of the country are likely to experience below-normal precipitation. Rainfall over the monsoon core zone, which includes a large share of India’s rain-fed agricultural areas, is also expected to remain below normal.

“The southwest monsoon seasonal rainfall over the monsoon core zone consisting of most of the rain-fed agriculture areas in the country is most likely to be below normal (less than 94 per cent of LPA),” IMD Director General of Meteorology Mrutyunjay Mohapatra said.

He added that rainfall during June is also expected to be below normal, at less than 92 per cent of the LPA.

The IMD classifies seasonal rainfall below 90 per cent of the LPA as “deficient”, placing this year’s forecast close to that threshold.

The weather department linked the outlook to evolving conditions in the Pacific Ocean. It said neutral El Nino-Southern Oscillation conditions are gradually transitioning towards El Nino. Weak El Nino conditions are expected in June and could strengthen to moderate or strong levels by September. El Nino events are generally associated with weaker monsoon rainfall across India.

The forecast prompted a response from the Centre, with Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan asking state governments to prepare for the possibility of lower rainfall and other weather-related challenges.

Chouhan said the Agriculture Ministry is working on contingency plans to address any adverse situation during the upcoming Kharif season. He also said there is sufficient availability of seeds and fertilisers to meet demand when sowing begins with the onset of the monsoon.

The IMD also revised its outlook on the arrival of the monsoon over the Indian mainland. While it had earlier projected the onset over Kerala by May 26, it now expects the monsoon to reach the state within the next seven days. The normal date for monsoon onset over Kerala is June 1.

The southwest monsoon entered parts of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands on May 16 and has since advanced further. As of Thursday, it covered the entire Andaman and Nicobar Islands, the Andaman Sea, parts of the South Arabian Sea, the Lakshadweep region, the South Bay of Bengal and the East-Central Bay of Bengal.

Alongside concerns over rainfall, the IMD said maximum temperatures during June are likely to remain above normal across most parts of the country. Above-normal heatwave days are expected in Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Punjab, Bihar, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh, along with isolated parts of Maharashtra. Rajasthan and Jharkhand, however, are likely to witness fewer heatwave days than usual.

Even as the seasonal forecast pointed to a weaker monsoon, several states received rain and thunderstorms on Friday.

Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 36.8 degrees Celsius, its lowest daytime temperature since May 8. Temperatures at some monitoring stations dropped by more than nine degrees over the past 48 hours. The IMD has forecast rain and thunderstorms in the capital until May 31 and issued a yellow alert for Saturday.

Weather expert Mahesh Palawat attributed the change to a western disturbance, a cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan and adjoining regions, and moisture-laden winds from the Bay of Bengal.

Punjab, Haryana and Chandigarh also saw temperatures fall into the thirties. Chandigarh recorded a maximum temperature of 35.6 degrees Celsius, more than four degrees below normal.

In Uttar Pradesh, strong winds of up to 100 kmph, thunderstorms and heavy rainfall affected around 20 districts, including Lucknow, Varanasi and Prayagraj. Saharanpur witnessed heavy rain that triggered a strong flow of water from nearby hilly areas. Lucknow recorded a maximum temperature of 33 degrees Celsius, 7.1 degrees below normal.

The IMD has also forecast wet weather in Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand over the coming days, while rainfall and thunderstorms were reported in parts of Jharkhand and South Bengal. Rajasthan continued to battle severe heat, with Sri Ganganagar recording 47.1 degrees Celsius, though thunderstorms and rain activity are expected to increase and bring some relief in the coming days.

CONGRESS LEADER INTENSIFIES ATTACK ON GOVT

Rahul spreading misinformation on NEET hearing: BJP

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A political slugfest erupted on Friday between the BJP and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination and the CBSE's on-screen marking (OSM) system, with the ruling party accusing the Leader of Opposition of spreading misinformation and distorting court proceedings for political gain.

The BJP's sharp response came after Gandhi took a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi over remarks made by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta in the SC during hearings related to the NEET paper leak issue.

Mehta had told the apex court that the Centre was seriously concerned about students and that Prime Minister Modi was personally supervising the situation to ensure there were no lapses.



School students join an NSUI protest rally against the alleged NEET scam, in Chikkamagaluru, Karnataka, Monday, May 25 PTI

Reacting to the statement, Gandhi posted on X, "PM Modi also personally supervising the NEET paper leak."

BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra accused Gandhi of twisting the Supreme Court proceedings and misleading the public. "Blatantly distorting the Highest Court's deliberations to

spread misinformation clearly shows the intent of the LoP is not welfare but extracting political benefit," Patra said in a post on X.

BJP Rajya Sabha MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi also attacked Gandhi, claiming he had selectively interpreted the Solicitor Gen-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The BJP's sharp response came after Gandhi took a swipe at PM Modi over remarks made by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta in the SC during hearings related to the NEET paper leak issue
- » Mehta had told the court that the Centre was seriously concerned about students and that the PM was personally supervising the situation to ensure there were no lapses

closely monitoring the situation and remained sensitive to the concerns of students.

Meanwhile, Gandhi intensified his attack on the government over alleged irregularities in the CBSE's OSM tender process and questioned the award of the contract to COEMPT. He alleged that tender norms were repeatedly diluted to favour the company despite objections and concerns raised by teachers and experts. In a series of posts on X, Gandhi claimed the CBSE called for tenders three times and gradually relaxed eligibility criteria, including lowering technical standards and removing penalties for evaluation errors, before COEMPT qualified. He alleged that TCS, despite qualifying in the final round, lost out to a company with what he termed a "track record of failure."

"The futures of 18.5 lakh children were handed to a com-

pany that could only qualify after the rules were bent for it," Gandhi alleged, demanding an independent judicial probe into all contracts awarded to COEMPT. He further accused the government of ignoring concerns raised by students over poorly scanned answer sheets, missing pages and technical glitches in the evaluation portal. Sharing a student's blog post, Gandhi claimed it exposed how the tender process had allegedly been manipulated. "The question is simple: who are they protecting, and why?" he asked.

The Congress leader also reiterated concerns over the integrity of competitive examinations, alleging that question papers were being openly sold through messaging platforms and claiming that students themselves better understood the loopholes in the system than the government.

Guj minister: Eight lion cubs die of suspected 'Babesia' infection

GANDHINAGAR: Eight lion cubs have died due to suspected 'Babesia' infection in Gujarat's Gir Somnath and Amreli districts, state Forest Minister Arjun Modhwadia said on Friday.

To prevent potential spread, authorities have isolated lions living within a 10-km radius of the areas where the infection has been reported, he said.

"In the suspected Babesia-related cases, eight cub deaths have come to light," the minister said.

Babesia, a parasitic disease, spreads through ticks and can cause weakness, coughing and nasal discharge in affected animals.

The deaths of the big cat cubs due to suspected Babesia infection have been reported in the revenue areas outside the Gir sanctuary, particularly in

Gir Gadhada of Gir Somnath and Babra Kot of Amreli districts, he said. A team of veterinary doctors collected samples, which have been sent to the state-run Gujarat Biotechnology Research Centre for testing, Modhwadia said.

The report is expected within the next three to four days, which will confirm if the deaths are due to Babesia infection, he said. No such "incidents (deaths)" have been repeated in the last two days, he said. "Forest officials, along with a team of veterinary doctors from Junagadh, visited the site and isolated the lions living within a 10-km radius," Modhwadia said.

Earlier this week, the minister had said that two lion cubs from the Gir forest region had died due to suspected Babesia infection, while three other

big cats succumbed to natural causes and infighting in separate incidents.

On Wednesday, Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel held a high-level meeting in Gandhinagar, where he was informed that four lion cubs had died from suspected infection, and 17 had been isolated in the wake of the possible spread of disease. Considering that Babesia is transmitted by ticks, the authorities have launched tick-removal operations both within Gir Sanctuary and in surrounding areas, alongside the implementation of other necessary precautionary measures, the minister said.

At present, the situation is under control, and the forest department has formed teams at the site to take all necessary preventive measures, he added.

MVA finalises seat-sharing for Maha council polls; Cong gets 8 of 17 seats

MUMBAI: The Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) on Friday said it has finalised the seat-sharing agreement for the June 18 Maharashtra Legislative Council elections, with the Congress set to contest the highest eight of the 17 seats.

State Congress chief Harshwardhan Sapkal said the MVA, which also includes the Shiv Sena (UBT) and Nationalist Congress Party (SP), reached a consensus on all 17 seats.

Congress will contest Chandrapur, Yavatmal, Bhandara, Amravati, Ahilyanagar, Solapur, Dharashiv and Nagpur (where a byelection is being held), he said. The Uddhav Thackeray-led Shiv Sena (UBT) will contest six seats: Raigad, Jalgaon, Parbhani-Hingoli, Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, Nanded and Nashik. The Sharad Pawar-led NCP will contest Pune, Thane

and Sangli-Satara, Sapkal said. The ruling BJP-NCP-Shiv Sena alliance has yet to announce its seat-sharing formula. June 1 is the last date for filing nominations. Scrutiny of nominations will take place on June 2, the last date for withdrawal is June 4, and polling will be held on June 18. Votes will be counted on June 22. Elected members of local governing bodies form the electorate for the election, necessitated by the expiry of the six-year term of the incumbent MLAs. The Solapur seat was held by Prashant Paricharak of the BJP. Ahilyanagar was represented by Arun Jagtap of the undivided NCP.

Thane was represented by Ravindra Phatak of the undivided Shiv Sena. Jalgaon was held by Chandubhai Patel of the BJP, while Sangli-Satara was represented by Mohanrao

Kadam of the Congress.

Nanded was represented by Congress leader Amar Rajurkar. Yavatmal was represented by Dushyant Chaturvedi of the Shiv Sena. Pune seat was held by Anil Bhosale of the NCP. Bhandara-Gondia was represented by BJP leader Parinay Fuke. Raigad-Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg was held by NCP leader Aniket Tatkare. Nashik was represented by Narendra Darade of the Shiv Sena. Wardha-Chandrapur-Gadchiroli was represented by BJP's Ramdas Ambatkar. Amravati was held by BJP's Pravin Pote. Dharashiv-Latur-Beed was represented by BJP's Suresh Dhas.

Parbhani-Hingoli was represented by Shiv Sena leader Viplay Bajoria, while Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar-Jalna was represented by Ambadas Danve of the Shiv Sena (UBT).

Cong top brass meet to discuss strategy for Punjab polls

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Congress top brass on Friday held a meeting with the state leaders from Punjab and discussed the party's strategy ahead of assembly elections in the state next year.

The meeting was convened at the residence of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, where former party chief Rahul Gandhi and AICC general secretary K C Venugopal were present.

Congress leader and in-charge of party affairs in Punjab, Bhupesh Baghel, said the meeting was held with all our Punjab state leaders along with our national president Kharge, LoP Rahul Gandhi and K C Venugopal.

"Extensive discussions took place on the party's strategy and how we should reach out to the people of Punjab. The assembly elections in Punjab are to be held soon, with only a few months.

Baghel told reporters that Punjab is a very important state for the Congress as well as the country, and the party would "very soon" prepare an action plan and hit the streets.

"We have to move forward unitedly in Punjab and highlight the corruption and deteriorating law and order situation in the state under Bhagwant Mann, besides highlighting the attitude of the central government due to which Punjab is suffering. We will take all these issues before the public," the former Chhattisgarh chief minister said.

Former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi, former deputy chief minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Punjab Congress chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring and Vijay Inder Singla attended the meeting.

Punjab goes to the polls to elect its state assembly early next year.

Manohar Lal reviews Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban's progress in Mizoram

NEW DELHI: Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs and Power Manohar Lal chaired a high-level review meeting on the implementation of the Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban (SBM-U) in Mizoram, with emphasis on improving visible cleanliness and sanitation standards in urban areas.

The meeting reviewed 18 key issues related to urban sanitation and waste management, in line with priorities highlighted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the recent PRAGATI review meeting held on May 27.

During the review, the minister directed state officials to prepare a detailed action plan with clearly defined timelines for addressing the issues identified under the mission. He also stressed the need for Mizoram



The Union minister said the govt remains focused on achieving visible and sustainable sanitation outcomes across Mizoram

to release its 10 per cent state share linked to central assistance already provided under the SBM-U scheme.

Manohar Lal further announced that the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs would organise training programmes for local youth in advanced landfill remediation technologies, including drone mapping and LIDAR scanning techniques used for assessing

sites. Officials said the initiative would also extend opportunities to participants from other northeastern states, with the aim of strengthening regional capacity in urban sanitation, waste processing and scientific waste management practices.

The minister said the government remains focused on achieving visible sanitation outcomes.

NEW DELHI: The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has sought a response from the Centre, several states and others regarding scorching maximum temperatures and intense extreme heat across the country. The statutory body was hearing a matter in which it had taken suo motu cognisance of a newspaper report about rising temperatures that are affecting people's health, learning, and productivity, besides impacting the economy.

In an order dated May 25, a bench of NGT chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad said according to the report, heat rarely leaves any dramatic visuals yet affects a vast part of the country, and is among the most unrecognised disasters.

"The latest IMD bulletin shows scorching maximum temperatures across northwest,



west, central and adjoining eastern and north-peninsular India, with the highest temperature recorded at 48°C in Banda, Uttar Pradesh. Delhi remains under heatwave conditions through May," the bench said, citing the report. It added that after distinguishing between urban and rural heatwave conditions, a policy with region-specific strategies and adaptation planning is required.

The tribunal impleaded as respondents the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, the depart-

Punjab: Mann credits welfare schemes for AAP's civic poll surge

'People rejected divisive politics'

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Friday termed the Aam Aadmi Party's strong performance in the municipal elections a "decisive endorsement" of his government's development-focused governance model and a rejection of what he described as the Opposition's "politics of hatred, division and negativity."

Addressing mediapersons in Chandigarh as counting of votes continued across the state, Mann said the results reflected people's faith in the AAP government's welfare initiatives, including free electricity, better school education, free healthcare through Aam Aadmi Clinics and employment generation.

According to trends available till around 9 pm, the ruling AAP had won more than 950 of the 1,977 wards and was leading in several others. Mann claimed the party had registered victories across Punjab and cited Dhuri, his own assembly constituency, where AAP won 19 of the 21 wards.

"The people of Punjab have defeated politics of hatred and supported developmental politics. The Congress, Shiromani Akali Dal and BJP together could not even match the number of seats won by AAP," he said.

Mann also targeted the BJP, calling it the "ED Party", and claimed the party had slipped to the fifth position in the civic polls. He claimed that in more than 1,000 seats, BJP candidates failed to save their security deposits.

"In many places, even independent candidates have won more seats than the BJP. It looked as though the BJP was



» Mann said the results reflected people's faith in the AAP government's welfare initiatives, including free electricity, better school education, free healthcare through Aam Aadmi Clinics and employment generation

» Mann also targeted the BJP, calling it the 'ED Party', and claimed the party had slipped to the fifth position in the civic polls

competing only with NOTA," he remarked.

The chief minister said the results indicated that AAP was on course to improve upon its historic 2022 Assembly poll performance in the 2027 elections. He asserted that the party had consistently won every election since coming to power, including panchayat polls, assembly bypolls and a Lok Sabha by-election.

Citing constituency-wise results, Mann said AAP won 17 of 19 seats in Gidderbaha, the home turf of Punjab Congress chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, and 37 of 50 seats in Barnala, associated with newly-appointed Punjab BJP president Sunil Jakhar.

Mann said the mandate showed support for AAP across the Doaba, Majha and Malwa regions. "People have voted for free electricity, daytime power supply for farmers, quality education and healthcare," he said.

NGT seeks Centre's response on heatwave

It has also sought responses from several states and others regarding scorching maximum temperatures

ment of science and technology in the national capital, the Ministry of Earth Sciences, the Ministry of Jal Shakti, the Central Pollution Control Board, the Delhi government and the states of Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Uttarakhand, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh.

"Issue notice to the respondents for filing their response/reply by way of affidavit before the tribunal at least one week before the next date of hearing

(on August 18)," the NGT said.

It added that a response from the states and their authorities is required to have a short-term and long-term adaptation strategy to address the increasing temperature due to climatic conditions and anthropogenic activities during the summer months.

The bench noted that the news report underlined an urgent need for a dedicated research program on heat risk, a stronger support system, ground observations, high-resolution thermal mapping, mobile temperature surveys, open-access data, environmental impacts and climate adaptations. "The issue is very serious as it relates to climate change and also anthropogenic activities. Hence, there needs to be a proper adaptation strategy formulated, and, as highlighted in the news item..." it said.

Op Sindoor commemorative volume with accounts of officers and aviators released

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday released a commemorative volume on Operation Sindoor, which documents the personal testimonies of 100 officers, sailors, and airmen who participated in the decisive military operation last year.

Singh described the operation as an unprecedented success wherein India "compelled Pakistan to seek a ceasefire within four days."

"It was different from all other wars that India has fought so far. The commemorative publication goes beyond historical account and captures the personal experiences of brave soldiers. It also offers insight into the human dimension of modern warfare where leadership, courage, judgment under pressure and commitment translate strategy into success," the defence minister said in a post on X.

He also shared some photos of the release function here, which took place in the presence of Chief of Defence Staff



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in a photograph with Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Chief of the Air Staff, Air Chief Marshal AP Singh, Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi and others during the release of a book on Operation Sindoor, in New Delhi PTI

(CDS) Gen Anil Chauhan, Navy Chief Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi, and IAF Chief Air Chief Marshal A P Singh.

"The accounts span across the three Services as well as Headquarters, Integrated Defence Staff and include combat aviators, naval watchkeepers, surface-to-air missile crews, special forces operators, signalers, logisticians, medical officers and the personnel of the joint and integrated organisations that knit the operation together," the ministry said.

The volume has been compiled under the guidance of the

CDS.

Singh in his post said the document is a tribute to those who executed this operation and "gives us a connect with the devotion and resilience of our soldiers."

The citizens need to draw inspiration from this book and become citizens worthy of the tremendous cost the nation pays to ensure security and maintain sovereignty, he added.

The volume departs deliberately from the conventions of official military historiography. "Most accounts of war

KEY POINTS

- » Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday released the commemorative volume
- » Singh described the operation as an unprecedented success wherein India compelled Pakistan to seek a ceasefire within four days

privilege the view from the headquarters and the operations room, as the decisions of commanders are recorded, analysed and debated. Yet the texture of the war as it was actually lived - by soldiers on the Line of Control targeting adversary bunkers, the air defence operator tracking and neutralising inbound drones, the pilot in the cockpit at the moment of weapons release and the sailor at action stations as the fleet moves to a heightened posture - is almost always lost," the ministry said in a statement.

TN transfers several senior IAS officers

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Friday transferred several senior IAS officers and district collectors across the state.

E Sundaravalli, Commissioner of Collegiate Education, has been transferred and posted as Special Secretary, Public and Rehabilitation Department, vice K Balasubramaniam.

P Ponniah, Commissioner of Rural Development, will succeed Sundaravalli as Commissioner of Collegiate Education.

R Lalitha, Managing Director of New Tiruppur Area Development Corporation Limited, has been posted as Secretary (Expenditure), Finance Department, in place of Prashant M Wadnere, who has already been transferred, the state government said in a release.

T G Vinay, Managing Director of Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation, has been transferred and posted as Commissioner of the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department, vice P N Sridhar.

Court sends Twisha's mother-in-law to CBI remand for five days

MPOST BUREAU

BHOPAL: A local court here on Friday remanded Twisha Sharma's mother-in-law Giribala Singh and her husband Samarth Singh in CBI custody for five days in connection with the death of the model-actress.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) produced the two before the court here and sought a five-day remand for each. The custody of Samarth Singh, who was already in CBI remand, has now been extended by five more days.

Justice Shobhana Bhalaw's court granted the CBI's petitions seeking the custody of Giribala Singh, a former judge, and Samarth Singh, a lawyer by profession.

Anurag Srivastava, the lawyer representing Twisha's family, told reporters that both have been remanded in CBI custody until 2 pm on June 2.

He said the central agency told the court that it needed to question both accused in detail, and that their custody was necessary.

Srivastava said, "We now

The custody of her husband, who was already in CBI remand, has now been extended by five more days

feel that the investigation is moving in the right direction. The real facts will come to light."

A sessions court had granted anticipatory bail to the former district judge on May 15. However, the Madhya Pradesh High Court overturned the decision on Wednesday, allowing petitions that sought the cancellation of her bail.

In a 17-page order, Justice Devnarayan Mishra observed that "in the light of the factual aspects of the case and the allegations levelled against the respondent (Giribala Singh), the anticipatory bail granted by the additional sessions judge deserved to be quashed." The CBI arrested Giribala Singh on Thursday.

SINGAPORE SUMMIT

India & US hold talks on security challenges in Indo-Pacific region

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/SINGAPORE: Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh met Commander of the US Indo-Pacific Command Admiral Samuel J Paparo in Singapore on Friday and held wide-ranging talks on security challenges in the region.

Singh's talks with Paparo – on the sidelines of the Shangri-La Dialogue 2026 – focused on “strengthening military-to-military cooperation and addressing emerging security challenges” in the Indo-Pacific region, the Directorate of Public Relations under India's Ministry of Defence said in a social media post. The meeting reaffirmed the “shared commitment” to deepening India-US defence ties at a time when the Indo-Pacific has emerged as the central theatre of global strategic competition, it said.

Earlier this week, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio noted that 60 per cent of global maritime trade passes through the Indo-Pacific, underscoring the region's critical importance for Washington.

For India, the Indo-Pacific forms the core of its security calculus. The Indian ocean flanks it on three sides – the Arabian Sea to the west, the Indian Ocean proper to the south, and the Bay of Bengal to the east. And it has growing strategic interests stretching from the Strait of Malacca to the Persian Gulf.

The development comes days after India hosted the Quad foreign ministers' meeting in New Delhi, where External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, along with his



Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh with US Indo-Pacific Command (USINDOPACOM) Commander Admiral Samuel J Paparo during a meeting on the sidelines of Shangri-La Dialogue 2026, in Singapore

HIGHLIGHTS

» Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh met Commander of the US Indo-Pacific Command Admiral Samuel J Paparo in Singapore on the sidelines of the

Shangri-La Dialogue

» Singh's talks with Paparo focused on 'strengthening military-to-military cooperation and addressing emerging security challenges' in the Indo-Pacific region

counterparts from the US, Australia and Japan, announced the grouping's first-ever joint infrastructure project – a port in Fiji. The Quad also launched an Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Cooperation Initiative, aimed at establishing a Common Operating Picture and sharing near-real-time data across strategic shipping lanes.

On the sidelines of the Singapore summit, Singh also held separate meetings with Admiral Giuseppe Cavo Dragone, who heads the NATO Military Committee, Canada's Senior Associate Deputy Minister of National Defence Kelvin Brosseau, and Seychelles' Chief of Defence Forces Major General Micheal Rosette.

Defence collaborations and security challenges were some of the common themes of these meetings.

Singh also addressed a gathering of leading think tanks and academia where he shared India's vision for regional security and strategic engagement.

The flurry of engagements comes in the context of a broader visit to Singapore that has seen Singh undertake a packed schedule of defence diplomacy. On Thursday, Singh co-chaired the 16th Defence Policy Dialogue with Permanent Secretary (Defence) of Singapore Joseph Leong, reaffirming the robust bilateral defence partnership between the two nations.

WITH PTI INPUTS

NEW BSF OUTPOSTS INAUGURATED

Shah visits India-Pak border in Bhuj

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BHUJ: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday visited the India-Pakistan border in Bhuj, Gujarat, where he interacted with Border Security Force (BSF) personnel at the G-7 Border Outpost and inaugurated the newly developed G-7 and G-13 Border Outposts.

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, senior officials from the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Intelligence Bureau, the Border Management division and BSF officers accompanied Shah during the visit.

Addressing BSF personnel, Shah praised the force for safeguarding the country's borders under some of the harshest geographical and climatic conditions. He said BSF jawans remain deployed in temperatures ranging from minus 45 degrees Celsius to over 45 degrees Celsius, while operating across deserts, marshlands, forests and mountainous terrain.

Real estate fraud: CBI files 10th chargesheet

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed its 10th chargesheet in the ongoing probe into an alleged large-scale homebuyers' fraud, naming M/s Shubhkamna Buildtech Pvt. Ltd. and its directors in connection with a housing project in Greater Noida.

According to the agency, the company and its directors allegedly cheated homebuyers and investors through false promises, misleading claims and deceptive assurances linked to the project. Investigators alleged that funds were dishonestly collected from buyers, causing significant financial losses to investors while securing wrongful gains for the accused.

The chargesheet has been filed before a competent court



Union Home minister Amit Shah poses for photographs along with Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel and security personnel during the inauguration ceremony of two new border outposts, in Bhuj, Gujarat

Under provisions of the Indian Penal Code related to criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal breach of trust.

CBI officials said documentary evidence and financial records indicated a coordinated effort to mislead homebuyers. Investigators claimed the material gathered pointed to deliberate actions rather than isolated lapses. The agency said investigations are currently underway in 50 cases registered on the directions of the Supreme Court. These matters relate to allegations that funds collected for housing projects were diverted without authorisation. The probe also covers claims that several construction firms, along with unidentified bank officials, misled homebuyers and investors.

MPOST

have also been added in forward areas. Smart fencing systems have been introduced to make infiltration more difficult and improve monitoring capabilities along vulnerable stretches of the border.

Shah said the Centre is working on a technology-driven border security framework that will rely on drone networks, radar systems and real-time monitoring tools. The proposed system aims to integrate the efforts of

the BSF, local administration, intelligence agencies, police and border communities to ensure coordinated surveillance and faster information-sharing.

Referring to border fencing projects in West Bengal, Shah said the newly formed local administration had provided prompt approval for land required for fencing work, which, according to him, would help curb illegal infiltration and strengthen border management.

He said the Narendra Modi government is committed to transforming India's border regions into highly secure zones through the use of advanced technology and modern infrastructure. Stressing the importance of surveillance systems and smart monitoring tools, Shah said the focus is now shifting from dependence on manpower alone to a more technology-oriented security approach along the country's borders.

Reliance ADA Group loan fraud case: CBI files first chargesheet

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Friday filed its first chargesheet in a bank fraud case linked to the Reliance ADA Group before a Special CBI Court in Mumbai, naming 16 accused, including Reliance Communications Limited, five of its senior executives and 10 bank officials from the SBI, Bank of Maharashtra and the erstwhile Syndicate Bank.

According to the agency, the accused have been charged under various provisions of the IPC related to criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal breach of trust, along with sections of the Prevention of Corruption Act dealing with abuse of official position and miscon-

duct by public servants.

The CBI alleged that irregularities were committed in the sanction and disbursement of loans and credit facilities extended to Reliance Communications Limited by a consortium of public sector banks. Investigators are examining the role of company executives as well as bank officials involved in approving and processing the credit facilities.

As part of the probe, the agency scrutinised transaction records, internal audit findings, correspondence and fund routing data linked to the disputed loans. Officials said the investigation revealed alleged lapses in oversight mechanisms and possible violations of banking norms. According to CBI, SBI had sanctioned a term loan of Rs 1,200 crore to the com-

pany, while Bank of Maharashtra extended Letters of Credit (LCs) worth Rs 500 crore. The Syndicate Bank allegedly provided additional LC facilities amounting to Rs 350 crore. These transactions are currently under scrutiny for alleged compliance violations and misuse of funds.

The case originated from a complaint filed by SBI, which alleged a wrongful loss of Rs 2,929.05 crore caused to banks by Reliance Communications Limited and Anil Ambani.

The FIR stated that a consortium of 11 banks led by SBI had sanctioned various rupee-term loan facilities to the company. The total exposure of 17 public sector banks in the matter reportedly stood at Rs 19,694.33 crore.

ED conducts raids in Delhi, Goa in Rs 155 cr bank fraud case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has conducted fresh search operations in connection with an alleged Rs 155.21 crore bank fraud involving Mahesh Timber Pvt Ltd and associated entities, leading to the seizure of cash, foreign currency and several incriminating documents.

The searches were carried out by the Chandigarh Zonal Office of the ED on May 18, 2026, at premises linked to accused persons, including Deepak Singla, Ayush Tiwari and Amreek Singh Gill, in Delhi and Goa under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

During the raids, officials seized unaccounted cash amounting to Rs 27.75 lakh along with 6,000 Singapore Dollars. Investigators also recovered ledgers of the accused firms, incriminating documents and electronic devices suspected to be linked to the laundering of proceeds of crime.

The action is part of an ongoing probe initiated on the basis of a CBI FIR registered against Mahesh Timber Pvt. Ltd., its directors and others under provisions of the Indian Penal Code and the Prevention of Corruption Act.

According to the ED, the case relates to the alleged fraudulent enhancement of Foreign Letters of Credit (FLCs) through unauthorised SWIFT amendments without corresponding entries in banking systems.

The alleged manipulation is believed to have caused wrongful losses of around Rs 155.21 crore to the erstwhile Oriental Bank of Commerce and other consortium banks.

Investigators claimed that nearly Rs 195.02 crore was fraudulently transferred abroad through manipulated FLCs without any genuine timber imports. Customs verification reportedly found that several Bills of Entry and Bills of Lading submitted to banks were forged.

Govt committed to taking yoga to every household: Haryana CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday chaired a high-level meeting to review preparations for the International Yoga Day and directed officers to ensure grand scale and extensive public participation.

The theme for this year's International Yoga Day is 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing'.

The chief minister said the state-level main event will be organised in Panchkula, while special yoga programmes will also be conducted at the district, sub-division and gram panchayat levels to ensure yoga reaches every section of society.

Saini said that according to this year's theme, yoga camps, awareness drives and special outreach programmes will be organised throughout



FILE PIC

Haryana. He said these initiatives will especially encourage senior citizens to adopt yoga and lead healthier lifestyles.

“Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, yoga has received unprecedented global recognition and respect. Today, countries across the world are embracing India's ancient tradition and holistic way of life,” he said. Emphasising his government's commitment to connecting the younger gen-

Saini chaired a high-level meeting to review preparations for the Int'l Yoga Day

eration with India's cultural values and traditions, he said it is also working towards the vision of a 'Healthy India and a Healthy Haryana'.

The campaign should be transformed into a mass movement, Saini said and asked officers concerned to ensure that Yoga Day celebrations go beyond mere formalities.

He directed that schools, colleges, panchayats, social organisations and voluntary groups should actively participate so that maximum people can be connected with yoga.

ANALYSIS OF HEAT-RELATED MORTALITY ACROSS 10 INDIAN CITIES

Study: 1 day of extreme heat causes 3,400 excess deaths across country

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A single day of extreme heat causes about 3,400 excess deaths across India, while a five-day heatwave causes nearly 30,000, a study has estimated.

Researchers Piyush Narang and Ashok Gadgil from the India Energy and Climate Center at the University of California Berkeley, US, said that even though global studies highlight a surging heat-related mortality, granular spatial-temporal data on how heatwaves affect mortality in India's districts remain inaccessible to common researchers.

The team adapted findings from a multi-city analysis of heat-related mortality across 10 cities in India to estimate excess deaths across all districts in the country.

'Excess deaths' is a public health metric that refers to the difference between total deaths over a specific period and deaths that could be expected to occur based on historical data. The study, published in

KEY POINTS

» 'Excess deaths' is a public health metric that refers to the difference between total deaths over a specific period and deaths that could be expected to occur based on historical data

» Heatwave to severe



heatwave conditions were prevailing in north, central and east India, with temperatures consistently exceeding 45 degrees Celsius

the journal *Frontiers in Environmental Health*, integrated district-level mortality rates from the Civil Registration System and population projections for 2024 to obtain district-level excess death estimates under one-day and five-day heatwave scenarios.

“We estimate that a single day of extreme heat causes approximately 3,400 excess deaths nationally; a five-day heatwave causes nearly 30,000,” the authors wrote.

Heatwave to severe heatwave conditions were prevailing in north, central and east India, with temperatures con-

sistently exceeding 45 degrees Celsius in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, parts of Uttar Pradesh and Haryana over past few days.

Mapping heat-induced mortality risk to individual districts revealed that the state of Uttar Pradesh alone accounts for about 8,100 excess deaths during a five-day heatwave, while excess deaths in districts, including Ahmedabad, Jaipur and Surat, each exceed 250 in a single event.

A 2.3-fold disproportion between mortality burden and economic capacity was found in the five highest death-bur-

JAMMU: Security forces continued 'Operation Sheruwali' for the seventh consecutive day on Friday to hunt down two to three Pakistani terrorists believed to be hiding in the forests of Jammu and Kashmir's Rajouri district, while another anti-terrorist search operation was launched in neighbouring Poonch district, officials said.

The forces targeted specific suspected terrorist hideouts with heavy firepower as the ultras continued shifting positions across the difficult terrain, valleys and gorges in the Doralim-Gambhir Moghla belt of the Manjakote area, the officials said.

Joint teams of police and security forces launched a cordon-and-search operation in the Surankote region of Poonch district on Friday after receiving intelligence regarding suspected



Security personnel maintain a tight vigil following an anti-terror operation in Rajouri's Dori Maal forest area

PTI

terrorist movements. There were reports about the presence of two to three individuals, which prompted a thorough search of the area, they added.

Operations were still ongoing when the last reports were received.

In Rajouri, the search opera-

of Police (IGP) Jammu Bhim Sen Tuti and a CRPF Inspector General visited the area on Wednesday and reviewed the ongoing anti-terror operation in the dense forests.

On Thursday, heavy firing and multiple grenade launcher assaults by security forces resulted in visible plumes of smoke rising from the forested area, indicating successful strikes on targeted locations during the operation, officials said.

Security forces have been diligently tracking the movement of the suspects, following blood stains believed to have been left by the fleeing terrorists on Monday. They successfully uncovered a hideout after a brief exchange of fire while strengthening their cordon in the area where the blood stains were found, they added.

MPOST

New nano-catalyst may cut medicines' cost

NEW DELHI: Scientists at the Institute of Nano Science and Technology (INST), Mohali, have developed a light-driven nano-catalyst that could make the manufacturing of medicines and industrial chemicals cleaner, cheaper and more energy-efficient.

The research team, working under the Department of Science and Technology, created a nanocomposite by combining gold and palladium nanoparticles with a light-absorbing molecule known as BODIPY. According to the researchers, gold nanoparticles absorb light energy and transfer it to BODIPY, which then channels the energy to palladium, the active catalyst, enabling chemical reactions to proceed faster with lower energy consumption.

The study, led by Dr Prakash P. Neelakandan, allows chemical reactions to take place under milder conditions using water instead of toxic solvents and light instead of high heat.

Researchers said integrating gold, BODIPY and palladium into a single system improved catalytic performance.

MPOST

PLFI chief commander arrested in Jharkhand

RANCHI: Jharkhand Police has arrested the chief commander of the banned People's Liberation Front of India (PLFI), a splinter group of the Maoists, who carried a bounty of Rs 10 lakh on his head, a senior official said on Friday.

The accused, identified as Amrit Horo (34), was arrested on Thursday during a raid in Mahugaon forest area within Ranchi district's Lapung police station limits following a tip-off that he, along with some associates, had assembled there to execute a crime, the official said.

At least 50 criminal cases are pending against Horo in districts, including Chaibasa, Khunti, Gumla and Ranchi, Ranchi SSP Rakesh Ranjan said.

MPOST

Nation Briefs

MANIPUR: TRUCK DRIVER DIES IN MILITANT FIRING IN UKHRUL

IMPHAL: A truck driver was killed and a police constable was injured when suspected militants fired at a convoy of goods vehicles in Manipur's Ukhrul district on Friday, an officer said. “A joint team of security forces, including BSF, CRPF and police were escorting some 15 to 20 trucks towards Ukhrul district when they came under attack near TM Kasom from suspected militants, killing a truck driver at the spot”, the officer said. Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Friday strongly condemned the firing incident.

PROPERTY DISPUTE TURNS FATAL: SIX KILLED IN KARNATAKA VILLAGE

VIJAYAPURA: An alleged property dispute took a fatal turn when six people, among them five members of a family, were killed in this district on Friday, police said. The incident occurred in Govindapura village in Chadachana taluk of the district. Preliminary investigation suggests that the clash erupted during a mediation meeting convened to resolve a long-standing dispute over around 10 acres of land between the victims' family and another family from a nearby village. A senior police officer said a verbal altercation broke out between the two families during another mediation meeting held on Friday over the same issue. “Following this, deadly weapons were used, and firing took place, leading to the deaths of six people,” he said.



EDITORIAL

BEYOND THE BATTLEFIELD

The horrors of war are usually measured in deaths, destroyed buildings, shattered infrastructure and displaced populations. Yet some of its deepest scars are borne silently, away from battlefields and beyond the reach of television cameras. The reported rise in early marriages in Gaza is one such tragedy. According to recent accounts, families devastated by conflict, poverty and displacement are marrying off daughters as young as 13 in the hope of providing them safety, shelter and financial security. The result, however, is often the opposite. Many of these girls face abuse, sexual violence, dangerous pregnancies and the abrupt end of their childhood. The stories emerging from Gaza are not merely about child marriage; they are about the collapse of the social structures that ordinarily protect children. They reveal how war does not simply kill people. It dismantles families, distorts choices and creates circumstances in which desperate decisions become normalised. When a mother who has lost her husband and son believes that marrying off a young daughter is the safest option available, it is evidence of a humanitarian catastrophe that extends far beyond military calculations and diplomatic negotiations.

The tragedy is that these marriages are often driven not by tradition alone but by sheer desperation. In a territory where homes have been destroyed, schools have ceased functioning, jobs have disappeared, and humanitarian aid remains uncertain, many families find themselves trapped between impossible alternatives. Parents who would never have considered early marriage before the conflict are now confronted with the daily realities of hunger, insecurity and displacement. Some girls reportedly view marriage as a means of reducing the burden on their families or gaining access to aid allocated separately to married couples. Such choices cannot be understood through the conventional lens of consent. A child who chooses marriage because every other avenue has collapsed is not exercising genuine freedom. Rather, she is responding to circumstances shaped by war and deprivation. The international community often debates ceasefires, borders and political settlements, but the human cost of prolonged conflict is also reflected in these intimate decisions made inside tents, shelters and overcrowded camps. Every early marriage recorded in such conditions is a reminder that war reshapes not only territories but life trajectories.

Particularly alarming is that the rise in early marriages appears to reverse years of social progress. Before the current conflict, Gaza had witnessed a gradual decline in child marriage rates. Educational opportunities, awareness campaigns and changing social attitudes had slowly pushed the numbers downward. That trend now appears to have been undone. Official figures suggest that more than one-fifth of marriages registered during the war period involved girls under the age of 18, while hundreds involved girls younger than 15. Human rights advocates warn that the actual numbers may be considerably higher because many marriages remain unregistered amid the chaos of conflict. History has repeatedly demonstrated that wars often erode hard-won gains in education, healthcare and women's rights. Advances that take decades to achieve can disappear within months of instability. The Gaza experience serves as a stark reminder that development and social reform are fragile achievements. They depend not only on policies and programmes but also on peace and security. When conflict becomes prolonged, vulnerable groups invariably bear the heaviest burden, and girls are often among the first casualties of social regression.

The consequences of early marriage extend far beyond the wedding ceremony. Medical evidence has long shown that adolescent pregnancies carry significantly higher risks for both mothers and infants. Young girls face greater chances of complications during childbirth, miscarriages and long-term health problems. Equally damaging are the psychological consequences. Many child brides are isolated from friends, denied educational opportunities and exposed to unequal power dynamics within marriage. Reports of domestic abuse and sexual violence among young brides in Gaza underscore the dangers inherent in such arrangements. The expectation that marriage will provide protection often proves illusory. Instead, it can place girls in environments where they possess little autonomy and few avenues for escape. Once education is interrupted and motherhood begins, opportunities for economic independence become increasingly limited. Thus, the impact of child marriage is not confined to the present crisis; it shapes the future of an entire generation. Societies emerging from conflict require educated, healthy and empowered young people to rebuild institutions and communities. Early marriage undermines that very foundation.

Ultimately, the rise of child marriage in Gaza should be viewed as a warning about the broader consequences of prolonged humanitarian crises. The issue is not confined to one territory or one conflict. Similar patterns have been observed in war zones from Syria to Yemen and in refugee camps across the world. Whenever insecurity, displacement and poverty converge, children become vulnerable to exploitation and harmful coping mechanisms. Addressing this challenge requires more than legal restrictions on marriage age. It demands sustained humanitarian assistance, functioning schools, healthcare services, economic support for families and, above all, a durable peace that restores a sense of normalcy. The international community must recognise that protecting children is not a secondary concern to be addressed after the guns fall silent. It is central to any meaningful response to conflict. The stories emerging from Gaza remind us that the true measure of war's devastation is not only found in ruins and casualty figures but also in the stolen childhoods of girls forced to grow up far too soon.

GREEN THOUGHTS



SUDHEER KUMAR SHUKLA

THE WRITER IS HEAD-THINK TANK, MOBIUS FOUNDATION, NEW DELHI

Clean energy should not come at the expense of the rivers, lakes and communities it seeks to protect

As the world hurtles toward a low-carbon future, solar energy is rightly being celebrated as a beacon of sustainable progress. Among the most innovative developments in this sector is the rise of floating solar power plants—photovoltaic (PV) panels deployed over lakes, reservoirs, and even sheltered marine zones. Known as floating photovoltaic systems (FPVs), these solar arrays have captivated policymakers and investors alike with their promise: abundant clean electricity without sacrificing precious land.

In India's ambitious journey toward achieving 500 GW of non-fossil fuel energy capacity by 2030, a quiet revolution is underway—not on land, but on water. Floating solar power plants are rapidly gaining traction as an alternative means to harness solar energy, utilising the surfaces of water bodies to deploy solar arrays in a space-efficient manner.

At first glance, floating solar seems like a win-win. It avoids the land acquisition issues that plague large solar parks, reduces water evaporation, and improves panel efficiency by using water bodies as natural coolants. Leading this movement are flagship projects like the Omkareshwar Floating Solar Park (600 MW) in Madhya Pradesh and the Ramagundam Floating Solar Project (100 MW) in Telangana.

But is the picture as green as it seems?

Beneath the sheen of innovation lies a less visible, but increasingly urgent, environmental debate. Floating solar power plants—while well-intentioned—may be jeopardising the very ecosystems they are installed to coexist with. If deployed without environmental foresight, these “green islands” could prove to be ecological minefields.

A Climate Solution That Could Emit More?

It sounds counterintuitive, but recent research from the journal *Environmental Science & Technology* (2024) found that floating solar systems deployed in smaller water bodies (less than 5 hectares) can increase emissions of methane and carbon dioxide by up to 26.8%.

When solar panels cover the surface of a lake or reservoir, they reduce sunlight and wind-driven mixing. This change in microclimate decreases dissolved oxygen levels, creating ideal conditions for methane-producing bacteria to thrive. Additionally, the submerged vegetation under the shaded water begins to decay anaerobically, releasing more methane—a greenhouse gas far more potent than carbon dioxide.

While the overall carbon footprint of floating solar systems (approximately 38–55 grams of

Clean Energy at What Cost?

India's floating solar push promises clean power and land savings, but without environmental safeguards, it could damage fragile freshwater ecosystems



Scientists warn that poorly planned floating solar projects could disrupt freshwater ecosystems, biodiversity and local livelihoods

CO₂ equivalent per kilowatt-hour) remains much lower than that of coal-based power (73–110 gCO₂eq/kWh), these localised emissions are real and must be carefully considered during site selection and project planning.

Thermal Stratification and Underwater Oxygen Crisis

Floating solar panels might reduce algal blooms and evaporation, but their shading effect can have unintended consequences on water quality. Surface water temperatures under FPVs can drop by 1.5–3°C, especially during summer months. This thermal stratification disrupts the natural vertical mixing of the water column, an essential process for nutrient circulation. In turn, this leads to oxygen depletion, a condition known as hypoxia. When oxygen levels fall below 4 mg/L, fish and aquatic invertebrates begin to suffer or die.

A study published in *Nature's Scientific Reports* (2023) examined floating photovoltaic (FPV) systems on Lake Maiwald in Germany and found that the installation significantly reduced sunlight (irradiance) reaching the water surface—by approximately 73%—and lowered near-surface wind speed at the height of the solar modules by an average of 23%.

Singapore's Tengoh Reservoir FPV project is often cited as a model for environmentally responsible floating solar. There, the government implemented real-time monitoring and installed aeration systems to maintain dissolved oxygen levels. Unfortunately, most Indian projects do not incorporate such advanced safeguards.

Biodiversity: The Invisible Cost

Freshwater ecosystems are complex webs of life where light, oxygen, and nutrients interact in a fragile balance. Introducing large FPV systems can tip this balance. For instance, research has documented a 15–20% decline in fish growth rates in areas shaded by FPVs. The biomass of macrophytes—submerged aquatic plants essential for oxygen production and habitat—is known to fall by as much as 30% when coverage exceeds 70%. Even birds and raptors that hunt over open water are also affected, as are migratory fish

whose routes may be blocked by large installations.

In marine environments, the stakes are even higher. Floating structures increase water turbulence, resuspend sediments, and raise turbidity levels, harming coral reefs and benthic organisms. Moreover, these installations can become breeding grounds for invasive species, which use the artificial habitat to outcompete native flora and fauna.

As floating solar moves into estuaries and lagoons—fragile zones with high ecological value—questions arise: Are we trading marine biodiversity for clean energy? And is that a price we are willing to pay?

Leaching, Plastics, and Noise

Another underreported risk of floating solar is chemical pollution. Some older solar panels, especially those containing cadmium telluride, can leach heavy metals if they crack or corrode. Many floats and anchoring materials are made from polymers that degrade over time, releasing microplastics and chemical additives into the water.

Installation and maintenance work also introduces underwater noise pollution, increasing ambient sound levels by up to 20 decibels—enough to disturb fish communication and breeding patterns.

Then there are livelihood and access concerns. Large floating solar projects often encroach upon traditional fishing areas, displace cultural practices, and restrict community access to water bodies, particularly in tribal and rural regions.

India's Bold but Risky Bet

India is making commendable strides in renewable energy, and floating solar has significant potential—especially in a land-constrained, water-abundant country. The Omkareshwar project alone is expected to reduce carbon emissions by 1.2 million tonnes annually and conserve millions of litres of water through evaporation control.

However, many of these projects are located in tribal belts or ecologically sensitive zones. For instance, the Narmada reservoir, tapped for the Omkareshwar project, supports diverse aquatic life

and provides livelihoods to fishing communities. If not implemented with caution, these projects could displace communities, degrade biodiversity, and cause long-term environmental harm.

Researchers emphasise the need for site-specific assessments and environmental impact evaluations as critical tools to guide the sustainable expansion of FPV technology.

Moreover, floating solar projects in India are not yet covered by a dedicated Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) framework. Unlike large hydro or thermal power plants, FPVs often escape the scrutiny of the EIA Notification, 2006. This regulatory vacuum needs urgent attention.

Filling the Research Gaps

Despite the growing number of FPV projects, long-term studies on their environmental impact are scarce, especially in tropical regions. We still lack:

- Reliable data on ecological and chemical impacts
- Guidelines for sustainable design and deployment
- Monitoring systems to track seasonal changes in water quality and biodiversity

There is also no protocol to assess the cumulative impact when multiple reservoirs in the same watershed are converted into FPV sites.

Without this information, we risk deploying floating solar in a data vacuum—flying blind in the face of complex environmental challenges.

What Can Be Done?

The good news is that many of the risks associated with floating solar are avoidable or manageable—if addressed early.

- **Coverage Limits:** Coverage should not exceed 70% of the water body's surface area, and ideally should stay below 30% in biodiversity-rich or ecologically sensitive regions.
- **Eco-Responsive Design:** Newer FPV designs allow wind and sunlight to pass through, or rotate with the sun to avoid constant shading. These innovations reduce ecological disruption.
- **Material Safety:** All components must be tested for water safety, leach resistance, and long-term durability. Avoiding PVC-based floats and corrodible metals is critical.
- **Real-Time Monitoring:** Temperature, dissolved oxygen, turbidity, and nutrient levels should be continuously monitored using sensors. This data must be shared transparently with local authorities and communities.
- **Public Participation:** Fishermen, tribal leaders, and local communities must be involved in the project plan-

ning stage—not just informing afterwards. Their knowledge and rights are integral to long-term sustainability.

► **Stronger Regulation:** India urgently needs a national guideline for FPV environmental assessment. This should be part of the Central Electricity Authority's regulatory toolkit and embedded into state-level renewable energy policies.

Exploring Alternatives: Canals and Highways

While floating solar offers unique advantages, India should also explore alternative deployment models that avoid ecological conflict altogether. One promising option is the installation of solar panels over existing canals and highways. Gujarat's canal-top solar project, for example, not only generates clean energy but also prevents water loss through evaporation and makes efficient use of otherwise unused infrastructure.

Highways and roads can be similarly repurposed. Solar panels over roads do not disrupt aquatic life and can even provide shade that extends the lifespan of asphalt. These spaces are linear, already disturbed, and often closer to transmission infrastructure, reducing energy loss in transit.

Scaling up such land-neutral solar options would help reduce the pressure on sensitive water bodies while still contributing significantly to India's renewable energy goals.

Let's Not Repeat the Mistakes of the Past

Floating solar has the potential to become a key player in the fight against climate change. But as with any large-scale intervention, its success hinges on one thing: balance.

If we are serious about sustainability, we must ensure that floating solar power does not come at the cost of freshwater health, aquatic biodiversity, or rural livelihoods. Clean energy should not dirty our rivers, lakes, or coastal waters.

We cannot afford to repeat the mistakes of the past, where development outpaced ecological wisdom. Floating solar must float not just on water—but on principles of precaution, participation, and long-term ecological stewardship.

When deployed responsibly, FPVs can offer a sustainable energy solution that powers the planet while safeguarding natural ecosystems. However, if ecological concerns are overlooked, they risk becoming yet another example of greenwashing with gray consequences. Without careful consideration, we may realise too late that the true cost of clean energy has been borne by the very ecosystems we intended to protect.

Views expressed are personal

Revolt of the Youth

From Hungary to Bangladesh and from Nepal to India, young voters are increasingly challenging establishments, searching for alternatives and demanding a future they can believe in



Across nations, younger generations are demanding change, accountability and opportunity

Hungary witnessed a political transformation in April this year. Frustrated by economic malaise, high inflation, increasing joblessness, and upper-level corruption, the youth unifiedly backed Péter Magyar's TISZA party and ended Viktor Orbán's 16-year rule.

We witnessed that same impatience with the older order in our neighbouring country, Nepal. Youth-led anti-corruption movements rocked Nepal in September last year. But instead of remaining limited to protests alone, the youth exercised the power of the ballot and elected a 36-year-old rapper-Prime Minister, Balendra “Balen” Shah, in March this year.

Of the 19 million voters, 1 million were first-timers. Bangladesh also experienced the momentous uprising of July-August 2024 that led to the fall of the old guard. Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina was forced to flee the nation and eventually, an interim government was installed under Nobel Laureate, Muhammed Yunus.

Back home, it's imperative to notice the meteoric political rise of actor-politician Vijay. He thrashed every doubting exit poll and rode into the chief minister's seat fueled by the strength of young voters, who are touted to have been his single largest driving force. Interestingly, Joseph Vijay Chan-

drasekhar's TVK (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam) manifesto devoted substantial space to economic and educational modernisation as well as issues such as climate change. Post-election data has revealed that 6 out of 10 voters in the 18–25 age group cast their vote for Vijay, who offered a credible alternative to the state's two legacy parties, DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam) and AIADMK (All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam). News reports also suggest a decisive role played by the youth in West Bengal to help hand the BJP (Bharatiya Janata Party) a landslide victory against the TMC (Trinamool Congress).

There is definitely a shit once again afoot. The world for the younger generation has been highly uncertain. From global warming and climate disasters to wars and layoffs, youngsters are scared, worried, and restless. Artificial intelligence (AI) has upended their lives, teaching them the easier route to doing work, only to ease them out of a job entirely. Social media preys on their every insecurity but also amplifies the many inequities of life. They have watched previous generations ruin the environment, pollute natural resources, reward malpractice and narrow motives, and get away

with corruption. When morals and values do a volte face, when the current world order feels past its expiration date, younger generations feel lost and listless. And then they crave change; they want a destruction of older regimes in order to herald a new world order.

Enter the cockroaches. When the Chief Justice of India compared the nation's jobless youth who turned to social activism to “cockroaches” and “parasites”, it gave birth to the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP). What started as satire has now assumed a massive following, outpacing even the leading national party in its online popularity. Their fame also raises some real questions. Does this kind of support and acceptance show the exasperation of the Indian youth? If yes, why doesn't this petulance translate into votes? Or do these huge numbers signify a complete lack of faith in the existing democratic system? Is there a new political party taking shape in the wings, or will this online rally peter out? Is there a possibility that this virtual fury will spill onto the streets and become a mass movement? It's been a while since the Arab Spring, and an unrelenting Indian summer is upon us.

Views expressed are personal

EMERGING FRAMEWORK DEAL ILLUSTRATES TRUMP'S STRATEGIC DILEMMA

Trump's room to maneuver narrows as US, Iran close in on framework deal

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump finds himself in a bind as he seeks to end the war against Iran: he is under pressure to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and get U.S. gasoline prices down but at the same time faces a potential backlash from Iran hawks in his own party over any concessions to Tehran.

Trump's dilemma became clear during a week of hectic diplomacy marked by word of an emerging framework deal that, according to sources familiar with the matter, would extend a current ceasefire and release Iran's stranglehold on the vital oil-shipping route while deferring discussions of its nuclear program.

Such an interim agreement, if approved by Trump and Iran's rulers, would amount to the most significant step toward peace since he joined with Israel in attacking the Islamic Republic on February 28, and could ease the soaring energy prices the conflict has triggered.

But it could also draw the disapproval of a key segment of Trump's base - influential Republicans clamoring for him



Donald Trump speaks during a Cabinet meeting at the White House

to "finish the job" by resuming strikes to close Tehran's path to a nuclear weapon, his main stated reason for going to war.

Earlier this week, some of Trump's headline anti-Iran allies responded to reports of a possible deal with criticism, even arguing that he might gain little beyond the 2015 Iran nuclear deal negotiated by former President Barack Obama and scrapped by Trump during his first term.

Senior Republicans rarely at odds with Trump, includ-

ing Senators Lindsey Graham, Roger Wicker and Ted Cruz, urged the president not to compromise.

Trump pushed back, insisting he was in "no rush" and would only accept a "great" agreement.

Caught between the competing demands - a quick solution to high gas prices and an end to Iran's nuclear ambitions - the president has little room to maneuver.

"Trump's rhetorical swings and abrupt reversals of the past

Summary

» Such an interim agreement, if approved by Trump and Iran's rulers, would amount to the most significant step toward peace since he joined with Israel in attacking Iran

» Reopening Strait would be welcome internationally but just returns to pre-war free flow of shipping

week suggest a president trying to park a wide war in a tight spot," said Laura Blumenfeld, a Middle East expert at Johns Hopkins University.

A White House official said "negotiations are proceeding nicely and he has made his red-lines clear."

"President Trump will only make a good deal for the American people, which must ensure that Iran can never have a nuclear weapon," the official said on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive internal

matters. Leaks to the media on Thursday about the terms of the "memorandum of understanding" suggest the proposed deal leaves many of the thorniest questions unanswered.

Those include what the strait's long-term status will be, what will happen to Iran's stockpile of near-weapons-grade enriched uranium and the details of potential sanctions relief.

The emerging framework, while averting military escalation, would at this stage fall far short of Trump's earlier demand for "unconditional surrender" and his vow to dismantle Iran's nuclear program. Iran has insisted it is only for peaceful purposes.

"If these terms are accurate and if a deal is concluded, the Islamic Republic appears to be getting more in the MOU than the U.S.," Jason Brodsky, policy director of United Against Nuclear Iran, a nonprofit policy organization, said on X. "A pledge for more nuclear talks? Be wary."

Iran's Tasnim news agency said the text of the agreement had not been finalized. AGENCIES

TRUMP MULLS WHETHER TO RENEW FTA

Trade ties in limbo, Carney calls for new US deal

TORONTO: Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney called for a new partnership with the United States on Thursday, just weeks before President Donald Trump decides on whether to renew the free trade agreement between the countries.

Carney said in a speech at the Economic Club of New York that there should be a "true partnership" that reimagines cooperation in specific sectors challenged by global competition.

He made the remarks ahead of the mandatory review of United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement, or USMCA, in July.

Carney said Canada is diversifying away from the US and signing trade deals with dozens of countries around the world.



Mark Carney said there should be a 'true partnership'

"Our core objective across these partnerships is to increase our strategic autonomy. Because we live in a world where integration has been weaponised. Because a country that cannot feed, fuel or defend itself is not truly sovereign," Carney said.

Trump's actions -- including launching a trade war and

suggesting Canada become the 51st US state -- have infuriated Canadians and created the political environment for Carney to win the job of prime minister after promising to confront Trump.

The Canadian prime minister has emerged as a spokesman for a movement for countries to find ways to link

Hormuz exposes China's Indian Ocean vulnerability, new report

SINGAPORE: China's maritime vulnerability begins at the Strait of Hormuz rather than the Strait of Malacca, creating a new arena of strategic competition in the Indian Ocean among Beijing, India, France and the US, according to a report by the London-based International Institute of Strategic Studies.

Released ahead of the three-day Shangri-La Dialogue security summit that opened in Singapore on Friday, the report says the Indian Ocean Region is

Challenges the widely discussed notion of China's "Malacca Dilemma"

re-emerging as a key strategic theatre after decades of relative calm following the end of the Cold War. The report, titled "Asia Pacific Regional Security Assessment", argues that China's dependence on energy supplies moving through the Indian Ocean has made the region increasingly important to Beijing's security calculations,

while also exposing vulnerabilities that rival powers could seek to exploit during a conflict.

The study examines strategic competition around major maritime choke points linking the Middle East and Asia, with particular focus on the Hormuz and the Straits of Malacca and Singapore (SOMS). AGENCIES

Russian drone veers off course, hits NATO member Romania

'Worst incident to hit nat'l territory': Romanian Prez

BUCHAREST: A Russian drone that was part of an overnight attack on Ukraine and then went astray slammed into an apartment building in eastern Romania, injuring two people in the NATO member country, Romanian authorities said, adding to concerns that the war could spread across the alliance's borders.

The Russian drone was tracked by radar in Romanian airspace and crashed onto the roof of the building in the city of Galati, Romania's Defence Ministry said in a statement. The impact was followed by a fire. The two people suffered minor injuries, and several others were evacuated.

The Romanian military scrambled two F-16 fighter jets and a helicopter that were authorised to engage targets, and alert messages were sent to residents of the affected areas. But the aircraft didn't engage or shoot at the drone to bring it down.

Romania asked NATO for a faster transfer of anti-drone capabilities to its military, the Foreign Ministry said, calling the drone's flight a serious violation of international law.



The crashed drone caused a fire on a building, injuring two

Romania asked NATO for a faster transfer of anti-drone capabilities

The incursion was the latest in a litany of drone incidents -- from both Russia and Ukraine -- to afflict NATO member states and leave the 32-member trans-Atlantic organisation on edge, drawing strong condemnation from Romania's allies.

Gen. Gheorghe Maxim, a stand-in commander for the Romanian armed forces' joint staff, told a news conference on Friday that the strike in Galati

wasn't "an attack from Russia against Romania," but "Romanians should understand that Russia is a threat to the security of the countries in the area."

Galati is on the Danube River, near the borders of Ukraine and Moldova.

Ukrainian forces shot down 217 drones overnight on Friday, according to the country's air force. In total, Russia attacked with 232 drones and one ballistic missile. Strikes were recorded in 14 areas, the air force said.

In response to the latest incursion, Romanian President Nicusor Dan convened the NATO member's top defence body for a meeting. AGENCIES

Kenyan police arrest 8 after deadly school fire

NAIROBI: Kenyan police arrested eight female students on suspicion of arson, authorities said Friday, after a fire destroyed a dormitory at a boarding school, killing 16 children and injuring dozens of others. The motive remains under investigation.

The girls were arrested for planning and carrying out a suspected arson attack at Utumishi Girls School in central Kenya, according to the Directorate of Criminal Investigations, or DCI, a department of the national police.

In addition to the deaths, the blaze on Thursday morning left 79 others injured. Police spent the whole day Thursday questioning 30 students at the school and asked their parents to head home without the

girls and come back on Friday morning. "Investigators have conducted extensive interviews with students, teaching staff and other witnesses, while forensic teams carry out a detailed review of available CCTV footage," DCI spokesperson John Marete said.

Education Minister Julius Ogamba said Friday the school's board of management had been dissolved and the principal would face disciplinary action for failing to comply with the safety manual. "In particular, there was congestion in the dormitory and one exit door was locked, contrary to the prescribed safety requirements," he said.

Two teachers who were aware of planned unrest will also face action. AGENCIES

Seeking to unblock EU funds, Hungary PM meets EU leadership

BRUSSELS: Hungarian Prime Minister Peter Magyar will meet Friday for the first time since taking office with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen in Brussels in a bid to unlock billions of euros frozen over the democratic backsliding of his predecessor.

Partly by campaigning on forging stronger ties with the European Union, Magyar's earthquake success in the April election ended the 16-year rule of Viktor Orban, who had vilified

von der Leyen and other powerbrokers in the 27-nation bloc as he hollowed out institutional checks and balances in Hungary. Those actions, and concerns over corruption and the erosion of judicial independence under Orban, prompted the bloc to freeze the billions in funding to Budapest in 2022. A year later, the commission found that the government had carried out sufficient reforms to have around 10.2 billion euros released.

After Magyar's party Tisza

won a super-majority in parliament, which will enable deep and quick reforms, leaders in both Brussels and Budapest prioritised releasing the funds as soon as possible to help Hungary's slumped economy.

The funds are split between 10 billion euros of COVID recovery funds and 6.3 billion euros in the cohesion funds designed to lift up struggling economies within the EU. The teams from Brussels and Budapest are working to first unlock the COVID funds. AGENCIES

World Briefs

BUS HITS CARS IN VIRGINIA, KILLING 5 PEOPLE AND INJURING 34

STAFFORD: A bus struck six vehicles on Interstate 95 in Virginia as traffic slowed for a work zone, killing five people and sending 34 to hospitals, state police said Friday. The crash happened at about 2:35 am on southbound I-95 in Stafford County. All five of the people who died were in vehicles hit by the bus, and three of the injured are in critical condition, police said. "The preliminary investigation indicates that traffic was slowing southbound for an upcoming work zone," state police said in a news release.

BONDI REFUSES TO ANSWER QUESTIONS ABOUT EPSTEIN ROW

WASHINGTON: Former Attorney General Pam Bondi refused to answer questions Friday on Donald Trump's involvement in the release of case files on Jeffrey Epstein as she defended the administration's actions before House lawmakers scrutinising a process that was delayed and included personal information of potential victims. Bondi, who arrived Friday morning on Capitol Hill for her closed-door interview, was defiant in previous public testimony when she was confronted by lawmakers about the Epstein investigation. In her opening statement, she kept to the same tack. "The bottom line is: justice and transparency in this matter have been delivered at the direction of President Trump and his administration," she said, according to a written copy of her opening statement.

Ex-Shaolin Temple head monk jailed for 24 years

BEIJING: Shi Yongxin, former head priest of China's Shaolin Temple, who played a significant role in popularising kung fu around the world, was on Friday sentenced to 24 years in prison under graft charges, official media reported.

Shi was convicted of crimes including duty encroachment, embezzlement of funds and bribery, according to the Intermediate People's Court of Xinxiang City in central China's Henan Province, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. He was also fined 3.5 million yuan (\$516,000). The monk was sacked and detained in July last year for violating Buddhist precepts. The violations included maintaining long-term, improper relationships with multiple women and fathering illegitimate children.

He had been Shaolin Temple's abbot since 1999 and earned the nickname "CEO monk" for his role in transforming the institution into a popular brand worldwide.

Founded in 495 AD, the temple is located in the foothills of Song Mountain. AGENCIES

Georgia uncorks the value of Stalin's 40,000-bottle wine collection

Despite brutal reputation, Stalin was also an enthusiastic wine drinker & collector

TBILISI: Tangled cobwebs hang from the ceiling in the dimly lit cellar, while a sweet, musky aroma fills the air inside a repository housing one of the world's most unusual wine collections -- once owned by Georgia's most infamous son, Josef Stalin.

For the first time this week, the Georgian government opened the vault in the capital Tbilisi, unveiling around 40,000 rare French and Georgian wines, some dating back to the early 19th century. Officials now plan to auction off the collection and use the proceeds to establish a wine education school in Georgia, a country proud of its ancient wine-making heritage.

The collection includes prized bottles from Bordeaux's most celebrated estates, many of which originally belonged to Russian Tsar Alexander III and his son Nicholas II. After the 1917 Russian Revolution, Soviet authorities seized the Romanov imperial collection,



Georgia's PM Irakli Kobakhidze at the opening of the wine cellar

and Stalin later became its custodian, gradually adding Georgian wines he personally favoured.

Irakli Gilauri, owner of Gilauri Wines, who worked with Georgia's agriculture ministry on the project, said the auction could elevate Georgia's profile among global collectors.

"The collection can help put Georgia on the collectors'

map," he said.

Nestled in the South Caucasus, Georgia often describes itself as the birthplace of wine. Archaeological discoveries suggest the country has maintained a continuous wine-making tradition for nearly 8,000 years, making viticulture deeply woven into its cultural identity. Stalin, born in the Georgian town of Gori, ruled

In Short

» It plans to auction off the collection, some of which dates from the early 19th century, and use the funds to open a wine education school in Georgia

» His trove includes wine from Bordeaux's most famous estates that were once owned by Russia's Tsar Alexander III and his son Nicholas II

the Soviet Union from 1924 until his death in 1953. Despite his brutal reputation and role in mass purges and political repression, he was also known as an enthusiastic wine drinker and collector with a preference for Georgian varieties.

Inside the cellar, rows of dusty bottles stand stacked behind iron bars, their faded labels barely visible under lay-

ers of age. The amber liquid inside some of the bottles glows faintly under the weak light, giving visitors a glimpse into a forgotten chapter of history.

Among those allowed into the vault this week was Victor Chen, a wine collector from Dallas, Texas, who travelled to Tbilisi specifically to see the collection.

Peering closely at the bottles, Chen compared the experience to discovering hidden treasure. "I feel like you're Indiana Jones opening up a cave: it could be nothing, it could be something," he said, referring to the fictional archaeologist from the film franchise. "There's not many things that are still historical moments at this point. And this could be one of them."

The Georgian government hopes the auction will attract wealthy collectors and wine enthusiasts from around the world, while also drawing attention to the country's distinctive wine culture. AGENCIES

CEASEFIRE DEAL LEFT CONTENTIOUS ISSUES UNRESOLVED

Israeli push deeper into Gaza raises alarm, Hamas warns of escalation

GAZA/CAIRO: Hamas said on Friday that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's declaration that his country would expand its area of control in Gaza was a dangerous escalation, as European states and residents of the Palestinian territory also voiced alarm at the plan.

Under a ceasefire deal in October Israel's military was to remain in control of 53% of Gaza, but Netanyahu said on Friday that it would expand that area to an initial 70%, without laying out details or a timeline.

The Palestinian militant group, which triggered two years of devastating warfare in Gaza with its October 7, 2023, attack on Israel, described his comments as a plan for ethnic cleansing and forced displacement of Palestinians.

"Any attempt to impose a new reality of occupation in Gaza is null and illegitimate," said Ismail al-Thawabta, head of the Hamas-run Gaza govern-



Hamas says Netanyahu's plan equates to ethnic cleansing FILE

ment media office, adding that Netanyahu's statement "represents a dangerous escalation".

More than eight months into the ceasefire, and with global attention fixed on the war in Iran, Gaza's underlying conflict remains stubbornly unresolved with continued Israeli attacks, little aid reaching civilians and the risk of major new violence.

Any further reduction in space available to the more than 2 million Gaza residents who are mostly crammed into tents in the tiny Palestinian territory risks worsening already dire conditions there.

"Where do we go? To the sea? There is no space," said Mohammed al-Shagra, 72, in Khan Younis. Last year's deal brokered by U.S. President

Summary

» Netanyahu said on Friday that it would expand that area to an initial 70%, without laying out details or a timeline

» "Any attempt to impose a new reality of occupation in Gaza is null and illegitimate," said Ismail al-Thawabta, head of the Gaza govt media office

Donald Trump established a Board of Peace to oversee a phased ceasefire, and was ratified by the United Nations Security Council.

Last year's deal brokered by U.S. President Donald Trump established a Board of Peace to oversee a phased ceasefire, and was ratified by the United Nations Security Council.

However, many of the

toughest areas of dispute including the disarmament of Hamas, a full Israeli withdrawal and the make-up of a Gaza government were postponed to later in the process. The Board of Peace negotiators have been talking to both sides on the disarmament issue.

Israel and Hamas have repeatedly accused each other of violating the truce. Israeli strikes in Gaza have killed more than 900 Palestinians since the start of the truce while Palestinian militant attacks have killed four Israeli soldiers.

Israel's military and the prime minister's office did not immediately respond to a Reuters request for additional information and comment on Netanyahu's statement. A spokesperson for the Board of Peace said it would not have a comment on Netanyahu's statement. A British foreign ministry spokesperson said any further expansion of Israeli control in Gaza would be unacceptable.

AGENCIES

Putin eyes escalation amid Kyiv deadlock and home unrest

MOSCOW: Facing a battlefield stalemate in Ukraine and growing war fatigue among Russians, President Vladimir Putin appears ready to try to change the narrative around the conflict.

He looks likely to sharply escalate the Russian aerial attacks on the Ukrainian capital in the hope it will shore up his sagging domestic approval ratings and persuade an increasingly pessimistic audience at home that Moscow is winning the war, now in its fifth year.

Russia's warning to carry out "consistent and systematic" missile strikes on Kyiv, accompanied by a call for evacuating foreign embassies from the capital, signals Putin's intention to expand Russia's barrage despite the heavy costs and potential international outrage.

Massive drills of Russia's nuclear forces earlier this month and a series of belligerent statements from Moscow warning Kyiv's European allies about possible retaliation for what the Kremlin cast as their involvement in Ukrainian drone attacks have underlined Putin's intention to up the ante.

After a series of gains last year, Russia's advances along the over 1,000-kilometer front line have ground to a near halt recently, and Ukraine's armed forces have launched successful counterstrikes and reclaimed some ground.

"The character of the war



He looks likely to sharply escalate the Russian aerial attacks on the Ukrainian capital

is shifting in favor of Ukrainian forces, at least for now," the Washington-based Institute for the Study of War said in a recent analysis. "Russian forces' rates of advances are stagnating while Ukrainian forces are employing novel tactics and operational concepts in efforts to break out of positional warfare."

The battlefield gridlock undermines Putin's declared goal of quickly capturing the eastern Donetsk region still under Ukrainian control. Kyiv has rejected his demands to withdraw from the region as a

condition for a ceasefire. At the same time, Ukraine has significantly expanded its long-range strikes on Russian energy facilities and arms factories, inflicting increasing damage. Putin scaled down the annual May 9 Victory Day parade, fearing Ukrainian drone strikes. Days later, a massive drone attack on Moscow's suburbs killed three and showed that even the densely protected capital isn't fully immune from assault.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the attacks were "significantly changing the situation — and, more broadly, the world's perception of Russia's war."

Acknowledging the growing threat of Ukraine's deep strikes, Russian lawmakers this week approved a bill that says the country's banks should bear the cost of installing drone-jamming systems.

AGENCIES

Laos cave rescue begins as first villager evacuated

BANGKOK: Rescue divers in Laos on Friday night safely evacuated the first of five local villagers who had been trapped in a cave for more than a week by floodwaters.

Laos and Thai rescue workers posted the news on social media, along with a video showing the first rescued villager with a lamp strapped to his forehead.

The villager, who was not immediately identified, was walking unsteadily with the assistance of two men. They handed him over to other team members amid a waiting crowd for a medical check.

The five had been found by divers on Wednesday, but that left rescue workers with two serious tasks: extricating the five and finding two more who are still missing.

It was not clear if more evacuations would be attempted Friday night

Rescue teams had pumped water out of the flooded cave's passages on Friday, but an overnight rainstorm complicated their work. The trapped men have already been supplied with water, soft food, and foil blankets to keep them warm.

A video shot inside the cave on Thursday vividly illustrated the desperation the trapped men are feeling.

AGENCIES

millenniumpost
CLASSIFIEDS
CHANGE OF NAME
I, Srinithi Rajan, D/o C. Senthil Rajan, residing at B-3, 3rd Floor, Type – 6, Tower-10, East Kidwai Nagar, P.O. Sarojni Nagar, South West Delhi-110023, have changed my name from Srinithi Rajan to S Srinithi Rajan for all future purposes.

Debts Recovery Tribunal-I, Delhi
4th Floor, Jeevan Tara Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001
TA NO. 1168/2022
UNION BANK OF INDIA ..APPLICANT
vs
DEEPAK KUMAR CHAUDHARY ..RESPONDENT
AND ORS.
To,
(1) M/S UNNATI FORTUNE HOLDING REGISTERED OFFICE AT T-07-LL-02 COMMON WEALTH GAMES VILLAGE NEW DELHI-110092
Whereas the above-named applicant has instituted a case for recovery of Rs. 39,92,523/- (Rupees thirty nine lakhs ninety two thousand five hundred and twenty three Only) against you and whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in ordinary way. Therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance before the Ld. Registrar on 01.06.2026. [For further details kindly visit DRT Website www.drttribunal.gov.in Phone Number: 011-23748473].
Take notice that in case of your failure to appear on the above mentioned day before this Tribunal, the case will be heard and decided in your absence.
(i) All concerned may attend their cases by hybrid mode (by physical appearance in the Court or through CISCO WEBEX VCLink)
(ii) For online appearance through VC all the Advocates/Litigants shall download the Cisco Webex application/software;
(iii) "Meeting ID" and "Password" for the next date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar/Recovery Officer./Vand Recovery Officer-II shall be available one day prior to the next date at DRT Official Portal i.e. "drt.gov.in" under the Public Notice Head.
(iv) In any exigency qua that, the Advocates/Litigants can contact the concerned official at Ph. No. 011-23748473.
Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal on this 7th MAY, 2026.
By order of this Tribunal

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्रथम तल, कॉर्पोरेट कॉम्प्लेक्स, पी - 2, सैक्टर - ओमेगा - 1, ग्रेटर नोएडा, जनपद गौतमबुद्धनगर (उ.प्र.)
Toll Free No. 18001808296, वेबसाइट - www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com
पत्रांक : वाई.ई.ए. / OSD(M) / 2026 / 410 दिनांक 29.05.2026
ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्र सरकार / केन्द्र शासित / अर्द्धशासित / सार्वजनिक उपक्रमों के कार्यों का कम से कम चार वर्ष का अनुभव रखने वाले ठेकेदारों / फर्मों से ई-निविदायेँ आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सोल्यूशन द्वारा निविदायेँ द्विस्तरीय पद्धति से खोली जायेगी।
कार्यालय आदेश संख्या : वाई.ई.ए. / OSD (M)/2026/409 दिनांक 29.05.2026 के अनुपालन में यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण की कार्यों में संविदाकार द्वारा यदि न्यूनतम दरदाता (L1) द्वारा स्वीकृत बीओक्यू (BOQ) लागत से 10% तक कम दरे कोट की जाती है, तो कोई अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी जमा नहीं करनी होगी। लेकिन यदि न्यूनतम दरदाता द्वारा स्वीकृत बीओक्यू लागत से 10% से अधिक कम दरे कोट की जाती है, तो 10% से अधिक जितना भी प्रतिशत कम दरे कोट जाएगी, प्रत्येक 1% पर 1% की दर से अतिरिक्त सुरक्षा / परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी जमा करानी होगी।
उक्त अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी अनुबंध का निषादन (एग्रीमेंट करने) के समय ठेकेदार द्वारा जमा कराई जाएगी तथा परफॉर्मेंस गारन्टी एफ.डी.आर. / सी.डी.आर. / बैंक गारन्टी / एन.एस.सी. के रूप में न्यूनतम संविदाकार द्वारा अनुबन्ध गठन से पूर्व देनी होगी, जो कार्य के अन्तिम बीजक होने के बाद वापिस होगी।
क्रम सं. कार्य का नाम / वर्क सर्फिस अनुमानित लागत
1 Supply Erection Testing and Commissioning of 11kv overhead line for Existing plot Village-dyoraar to near Plot CESC Green Power Ltd. Sector-80 yea (WC-E&M-03) रु. 19.35 लाख
2 Operation and Maintenance of Steel Light at Sector -33 (2026-2027) yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 21.30 लाख
3 Jointing 33/11 kv substation to 220/132/33 kv Substation with existing 33 kv HT line and accessories in Sector 24 yaida (WC-E&M-03) रु. 29.90 लाख
4 Operation and Maintenance of Steel Light at Sector -29 (2026-2027) yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 30.16 लाख
5 SI/ITC of 11kv U/G Line Network and Dismantling of 11kv overhead Line Front Plots Gh-01A to Gh-1D Sector-22D yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 37.83 लाख
6 Providing Street Light at Village-Siroli Bangar yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 48.95 लाख
जिन्हें दिनांक 04.06.2026 से 16.06.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है।
प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन दिनांक 18.06.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।
क्रम सं. कार्य का नाम / वर्क सर्फिस अनुमानित लागत
7 Providing Street light at Village-Dayanatpur and Begmabad yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 118.10 लाख
8 SI/ITC Pumping Set and Other work for UGR in sector -32 yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 122.90 लाख
9 Construction of Underground L.T Network for Pocket-5C of Sector - 18 yaida (WC-E&M-03) रु. 196.14 लाख
10 Construction of Double Circuit 33kv Underground Line from 220/132/33kv Substation in Sector - 24 to 33/11kv Substation (ESS-01) in Sector -24A yaida (WC-E&M-03) रु. 235.17 लाख
11 Construction of 11/0-415kv Sub-Station (03 Nos) in Sector-24A yaida (WC-E&M-03) रु. 464.55 लाख
12 Construction of 33kv Underground line from 220kv Sub-station Sector-18 to 33/11kv Sub-station (ESS No.-06) in Pocket - 7C Sector-18 yaida (WC-E&M-03) रु. 608.34 लाख
13 Construction of 33/11kv Sub-Station Ess No-01 in Sector 22E yea (WC-E&M-02) रु. 627.58 लाख
जिन्हें दिनांक 05.06.2026 से 17.06.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है।
प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन दिनांक 19.06.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।
निविदा प्रपत्र उत्तर प्रदेश इलैक्ट्रॉनिक्स कारपोरेशन की वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
इच्छुक ठेकेदारों से अनुरोध है कि वे नियमित रूप से उक्त वेबसाइटों को देखते रहें क्योंकि निविदाओं के सम्बन्ध में कोई बदलाव अथवा अतिरिक्त सूचना वेबसाइट पर ही उपलब्ध करायी जायेगी।
विशेष कार्याधिकारी (एम.)
यमुना विकास प्राधिकरण
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग / हाउसिंग कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीद - फरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनीआइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।

e-Procurement Cell OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
SPECIAL WORKS DIVISION
BUILDING CONSTRUCTION DEPARTMENT, RANCHI.
VERY- VERY SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITATION QUOTATION
Quotation Reference No:BCD/Special Work Division BCD, Ranchi/NIQ-12/2026-27
(Rate Purpose Only)
E- quotations are invited for the work of Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract and Operation of Building Management System Installed at New Jharkhand Bhawan, Bangla Sahib Road, New Delhi for the One Year for Operation and maintenance of BMS System work etc. for all Materials from Reputed Shop Keepers, Manufacturers, Suppliers, Retailers, Distributors, Furniture Suppliers, Registered B.C.D. Contractors and other for following items. They should quote their rates for unit mentioned in the table. If they do not deals all of the below mentioned items. Then they are allowed to quote their rate for part of the items which ever they deals. The rates should be exclusive of all types of Taxes, GST, Contractor's Profit and overhead charges etc, but inclusive of Royalty. All Rates should be exclusive of Labour Cess.
Term and Condition
1. The quotationer shall furnish pan, GST registration no.
2. The rate quoted by quotationer shall be firm and final.
3. The undersigned reserves the right to accept or reject/cancel any or all quotations without assigning any reason thereof.
नोट:- 1. वेबसाइट में ई-कोटेशन प्रकाशन की तिथि 01.06.2026 के अपराह्न 3:00 बजे।
2. वेबसाइट में ई-कोटेशन अपलोड की अंतिम तिथि 08.06.2026 के अपराह्न 3:00 बजे तक।
3. ई-कोटेशन खोलन की तिथि एवं समय 09.06.2026 अपराह्न 3:30 बजे।
4. ई-कोटेशन आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता कार्यपालक अभियंता, विशेष कार्य प्रमण्डल, भवन निर्माण विभाग, रांची।
5. ई-कोटेशन प्रकोश का दूरभाष सं-7903899611
विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट jharkhandtenders.gov.in में देखा जा सकता है।
Nodal Officer
e-Procurement Cell, Office of the Executive Engineer
Special Works Division, BCD, Ranchi
PR.NO.381025 Building(26-27):D

PUBLIC NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005
The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.
Sr. No. Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address Description of Secured Asset to be enforced Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice NPA Date
1. Anil Yadav/ Phool Chand Yadav/ House No.230 Sector-23, Haryana Gurgaon- 122017/ LBGUR00004782966 Plot No.574-C, Block-H, 1st And 4th Floor, Palam Vihar, Situated in And Around Village Chauma & Carterpuri, Tehsil & District Gurgaon, Haryana- 122017 16/05/2026 Rs. 20,18,263,72/- 06/ April/ 2026
2. Anil Yadav/ Phool Chand Yadav/ House No.230 Sector-23, Haryana Gurgaon- 122017/ LBGUR00004860986 Plot No.574-C, Block-h, 1st And 4th Floor, Palam Vihar, Situated in And Around Village Chauma & Carterpuri, Tehsil & District Gurgaon, Haryana- 122017 16/05/2026 Rs. 34,287,81/- 06/ April/ 2026
3. Harish Kumar/ Nisha/, Village Solda, Faridabad Haryana Faridabad- 121002/ LBFBD00006647586 Unit No: 605, Tower B1 Floor No. 6, Vashisti Heights, Village Baselwa, Sector- 87, Faridabad, Haryana- 121002 16/05/2026 Rs. 90,837/- 13/ Feb/ 2026
4. Harish Kumar/ Nisha/, Village Solda, Faridabad Haryana Faridabad- 121002/ TBFBD00006457016 Unit No: 605, Tower B1 Floor No. 6, Vashisti Heights, Village Baselwa, Sector- 87, Faridabad, Haryana- 121002 16/05/2026 Rs. 17,34,916/- 13/ Feb/ 2026
These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
Date: May 30, 2026
Place: Delhi/ Ncr
Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.
Sr. No. Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs) Name of Branch
1. Parul Dhawan/ Akshara Sharma (Since Minor) Through Legal Natural Guardian Parul Dhawan/ Akshar Sharma (Since Minor) Through Legal Natural Guardian Parul Dhawan/ LBDL00002089897/ LBDL000005509429 Unit Bearing No Carnation 02, 1st Floor, Block No. Carnation, Edeco Residency Greens, Situated At Plot No. 12, Pocket B, Sector P1, Gautam Budh Nagar, Greater Noida- 201307/ May 25, 2026 April 30, 2025 Rs. 47,16,864,22/- Delhi/ Ncr
The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: May 30, 2026
Place: Delhi/ Ncr
Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

बिहार सरकार
कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल, हाजीपुर
शुद्धि-पत्र
इस कार्यालय का पत्रांक-789 अनु0 दिनांक-17.03.2026 द्वारा निर्गत ई0-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या (SBD)-39/ हाजीपुर /2025-26 (कार्य का नाम-महिला औद्योगिक प्रशिक्षण संस्थान, हाजीपुर, वैशाली के परिसर में 100 आसन वाले बालिका छात्रावास (G+3) निर्माण कार्य (विद्युत कार्य सहित)। जिसका पीओआर सं0-26874 (BCD) 2025-26 है जो दिनांक-21.03.2026 को दैनिक समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित हुआ है को अपरिहार्य कारणवश अबधि विस्तार किया जाता है।
क्र0 विवरण पूर्व में निवारित तिथि संशोधित तिथि
1. परियोजना विवरण (आवलेख करने एवं भिन्नता बनाने (आवलेख करने) की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय दिनांक-10.04.2026 से 04.05.2026 को अप0 3:00 बजे तक। दिनांक-05.06.2026 से 03.06.2026 को अप0 3:00 बजे तक।
2. निविदा (तकनीकी बीड) खोलने की तिथि एवं समय दिनांक-05.06.2026 को अप0 3:30 बजे तक। दिनांक-01.07.2026 को अप0 3:30 बजे तक।
3. प्रौद्योगिकी मॉडल की तिथि, समय एवं स्थान दिनांक-17.04.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप0 को अधीक्षण अभियंता, भवन अंचल, मुजफ्फरपुर का कार्यालय। (2) दिनांक-24.04.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप0 को मुख्य अभियंता (उत्तर) भवन निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का कार्यालय। (1) दिनांक-11.6.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप0 को अधीक्षण अभियंता, भवन अंचल, मुजफ्फरपुर का कार्यालय। (2) दिनांक-17.06.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप0 को मुख्य अभियंता (उत्तर) भवन निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का कार्यालय।
इसे इस हद तक संशोधित समझे तथा शेष सभी शर्तें यथावत रहेगा।
निविदा से संबंधित नियमों, शर्तों के विशेष जानकारी के लिए कार्यपालक अभियंता, वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल से सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।
कार्यपालक अभियंता,
वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल, हाजीपुर
उक्त सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।
PR. No. 004383 (BCD) 2026-27
नशामुक्त हो जाए बिहार, सुरक्षित रहे घर परिवार।

BSES BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi
TENDER NOTICE Date: 30.05.2026
Sealed tenders under two parts (Un priced & priced) are invited for the Supply & Execution of following from all Bidders:-
NIT No. Brief Item Description Estimated Cost (₹) Cost of EMD (₹) Due Date & Time of Submission Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/ FK/PR/HV/1364 SUPPLY OF 66KV 3CX30Q SQ MM GRADE ALUMINIUM CONDUCTOR POWER CABLE 8.5 Crores 8.5 Lacs 12.06.2026 15:00 HRS 12.06.2026 16:00 HRS
Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/-
For any query call on 011-49107235 or e-mail on Brpl.Eauction@reliancecda.com
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submitmission of tender documents etc, please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com Head (Contracts & Materials)
Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527 Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com

NORTHERN RAILWAY
INVITATION OF TENDERS
THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM
Tender Notice No. 16/2026-2027 Date : 27.05.2026
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-
S. Tender No. Brief Description Qty. Closing Date
01 12265005A HEAVY DUTY PASSENGER ESCALATOR 49 NOS 23.06.26
02 02265091 4.5 KW UNDER SLUNG TYPE CONSTANT 658 NOS 23.06.26
03 12265006 HEAVY DUTY ELEVATORS 42 NOS 23.06.26
04 15265070 EDDY CURRENT ARRAY TESTING EQUIPMENT 1 SET 29.06.26
05 02260069 BATTERY CHARGING UNIT CUM PRE-COOLING TRANSFORMER 35 NOS 06.07.26
06 15235293A TELESKOPIK BOOM CRANE OF MINIMUM 175 T 8 NOS 21.07.26
07 12261186A SINGLE CORE ELASTOMERIC CABLE SIZE 150 SQ. 3392 MTR 27.07.26
08 09262347 BOLSTER SPRING OUTER FOR BLC WAGON 5010 NOS 10.08.26
NOTE - 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No Manual offer will be entertained.
1815/26
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Resilient Indian economy may face West Asia headwinds: RBI

RBI's balance sheet swelled to Rs 91.97 lakh crore at end of March 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: India's economy could face headwinds due to higher energy prices and supply chain disruptions, while the likelihood of El Nino conditions could hit agriculture output, the RBI said in its annual report released on Friday.

However, healthy corporate and bank balance sheets, the government's continued thrust on capital expenditure and the implementation of trade agreements with key partners are expected to sustain investment and growth momentum.

The RBI released its Annual Report for 2025-26, a statutory report of its Central Board of Directors, on Friday. Market volatility persisted due to geopolitical risks and valuation concerns but surged towards the end of March 2026 following the West Asia conflict.

The Indian economy exhibited resilience in 2025-26, amidst several external headwinds, supported by strong private consumption, sustained investment and sound macro-economic fundamentals.

The report said that the outlook for the Indian economy in 2026-27 remains positive, supported by strong macroeconomic fundamentals, although a prolonged West Asia conflict



The total number of counterfeit notes detected jumped to 2,29,746 pieces in FY26, up from 2,17,396 in the preceding fiscal

Highlights

- » CPI-based inflation for FY27 is projected at 4.6% with risks tilted to the upside, the RBI said
- » Detection of counterfeit currency notes in also rose 5.7% in FY26, led by a sharp rise in fakes found in Rs 500 and Rs 200 denominations
- » Fake Rs 500 notes remained most detected denomination, rising 20.5% to 1,41,907 pieces during the year

may pose downside risk.

The RBI also said the outlook for the agriculture sector in FY27 remains contingent upon the progress and distribution of the south-west monsoon. The likelihood of El Nino conditions poses downside risks to agriculture output, it added.

On price situation, the report said inflation in 2026-27 is likely to remain aligned with the target on the back of adequate foodgrain stocks, sufficient reservoir levels and stable agricultural prospects despite possible El Ni±o conditions and above-normal summer temperatures. "However, the

evolving upside risks to inflation may emanate from multiple other factors such as spike in global fuel and commodity prices amid geopolitical tensions, potential spillovers to input and wage costs, and volatility in exchange rate," it said.

Considering all these factors, consumer price index (CPI)-based inflation for 2026-27 is projected at 4.6 per cent with risks tilted to the upside, the RBI said.

RBI's balance sheet swelled to Rs 91.97 lakh crore at the end of March 2026, up 20.6 per cent year-on-year, due to a rise in domestic investments as well

as gold and foreign investments.

The balance sheet size increased by Rs 15,71,699.15 crore from Rs 76,25,421.93 crore as on March 31, 2025, to Rs 91,97,121.08 crore as on March 31, 2026, the report said.

The Increase on the assets side was due to a rise in domestic investments, gold and foreign investments by 44.9 per cent, 63.8 per cent and 7.9 per cent, respectively. As on March 31, 2026, the report said total gold held by the RBI was 880.52 metric tonnes as compared to 879.58 metric tonnes as on March 31, 2025, an increase of 0.94 metric tonnes of gold in the year.

"Of the 880.52 metric tonnes, 312.32 metric tonnes of gold is held as an asset of the Issue Department as compared to 311.38 metric tonnes as on March 31, 2025," it said. The remaining 568.20 metric tonnes, same as on March 31, 2025, is treated as an asset of the Banking Department, RBI said.

The report further said banks and financial institutions, taken together, reported 10,114 fraud cases involving Rs 48,021 crore in 2025-26, against 23,722 cases involving Rs 32,803 crore in FY25. An assessment of bank group-wise fraud cases over the last three years indicates that although the number of frauds

for public and private sectors banks has reduced, the amount involved has increased over the years. While the number of frauds was the highest under card/internet/digital payments category during FY24 and FY25, advances category accounted for the largest share in FY26. In value terms, frauds were concentrated in the advances category across three years.

Detection of counterfeit currency notes in the banking system also rose 5.7 per cent in 2025-26, led by a sharp increase in fakes found in Rs 500 and Rs 200 denominations.

The total number of counterfeit notes detected jumped to 2,29,746 pieces in FY26, up from 2,17,396 in the preceding fiscal.

Fake Rs 500 notes remained most detected denomination, rising 20.5 per cent to 1,41,907 pieces during the year from 1,17,722 in FY25.

Meanwhile, the volume of Rs 500 denomination banknotes in circulation increased about 11.2 per cent in FY26.

The volume of Rs 500 notes jumped to 7,05,482 lakh pieces at end-March 2026, from 6,34,458 lakh pieces a year ago.

In value terms, Rs 500 notes in circulation increased to Rs 35.27 lakh crore in FY26, from Rs 31.72 lakh crore in FY25.

Sensex tanks 1,092 pts on selling in financial and oil & gas stocks

The mcap of BSE-listed cos declined by Rs 5,77,442.84 crore to Rs 4,64,97,814.78 crore (\$4.88 trillion)

OUR CORRESPONDENT

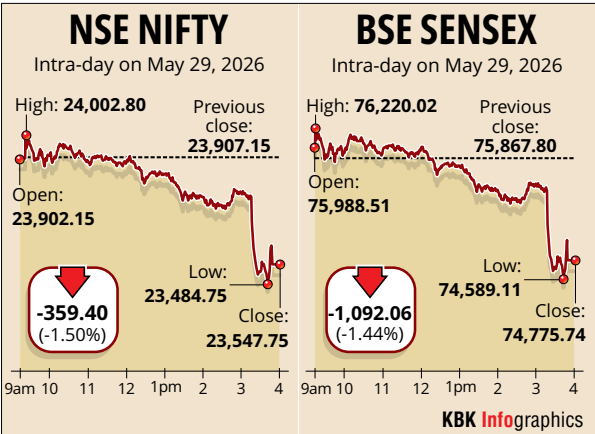
MUMBAI: Benchmark Sensex tumbled 1,092 points and Nifty closed below 24,550 on Friday due to last-minute profit booking in financials and oil & gas shares amid reports of a below-normal monsoon season rainfall.

Dragged by late selling, the 30-share BSE Sensex declined by 1,092.06 points, or 1.44 per cent, to settle at 74,775.74. The index opened higher and moved in a tight range for most of the session. However, heavy profit booking in Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, Mahindra & Mahindra and Bajaj Finance dragged the benchmark down by 1,278.69 points, or 1.68 per cent, to 74,589.11 in the pre-close session.

Falling for the third consecutive session, the 50-share NSE Nifty dived 359.40 points, or 1.50 per cent, to end at 23,547.75.

Among 30 Sensex firms, Power Grid, InterGlobe Aviation, NTPC, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Steel and Bajaj Finance were the major laggards. Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech, Larsen & Toubro and Infosys were the gainers.

The market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies declined by Rs 5,77,442.84 crore to Rs 4,64,97,814.78 crore (USD 4.88 trillion).



Among sectoral indices, Oil & Gas tumbled 2.75%, Metal (2.30%), Utilities (2.23%), Hospitals (2.16%), Energy (2.08%), Commodities (1.94%), Auto (1.90%) and Services (1.58%)

The BSE SmallCap Select index tanked 1.26 per cent and MidCap Select index dropped 0.73 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, Oil & Gas tumbled 2.75 per cent, Metal (2.30 per cent), Utilities (2.23 per cent), Hospitals (2.16 per cent), Energy (2.08 per cent), Commodities (1.94 per cent), Auto (1.90 per cent) and Services (1.58 per cent). IT, Telecom and Focused IT were the gainers.

A total of 2,599 stocks declined, while 1,670 advanced

and 194 remained unchanged on the BSE.

On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark dropped 639.61 points, or 0.84 per cent, and the Nifty declined 171.55 points, or 0.72 per cent.

FII's offloaded equities worth Rs 1,042.70 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the Sensex declined 141.90 points, or 0.19 per cent, to settle at 75,867.80.

The Nifty skidded 6.55 points, or 0.03 per cent, to end at 23,907.15.

RBI to explore CBDC pilot in cross-border transactions

MUMBAI: The RBI plans to expand the use of the central bank digital currency (CBDC) in cross-border transactions and direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes during FY27, according to its 2025-26 annual report.

The RBI said it launched multiple CBDC pilots in FY26 under DBT schemes of the Centre & state governments, using programmability features of digital rupee.

To strengthen cross-border payments, the RBI signed an MoU on digital asset collaboration with the Monetary Authority of Singapore (MAS) and held bilateral discussions with the Singapore regulator and the Central Bank of the UAE to operationalise cross-border CBDC pilots.

The RBI also joined multilateral initiatives led by the BIS Innovation Hub aimed at improving cross-border payments through CBDCs.

In FY27, the RBI plans to widen CBDC pilots across retail and DBT use cases, explore tokenisation of financial assets and expand participant coverage. It also aims to operationalise bilateral and multilateral CBDC pilots with select use cases.

The RBI plans to introduce a framework for testing innovative CBDC-based products and services under its CBDC and Asset Tokenisation sandbox.

CBDC-R circulation value stood at Rs 771.66 crore as of March 31, 2026, down from Rs 1,016.46 crore a year earlier.

Rupee being increasingly used for imports & exports invoicing over the years: RBI report

MUMBAI: Rupee is being increasingly used for import and export invoicing over the years, showed the data compiled by the Reserve Bank of India, which said the INR internationalisation process has been mutually beneficial to all trading partners.

Over the past few years, several measures have been undertaken by the RBI to enhance the role of INR as an international currency through its increased usage for both current and select capital account transactions.

In its annual report released on Friday, the RBI said the ascendance of INR as an invoicing and settlement currency is likely to offer protection against exchange rate risk, reduce the requirement for maintaining costly forex reserves in convertible currencies, and provide



other benefits.

In this context, the use of the domestic currency also facilitates the development of bilateral exchange rate markets and reduces transaction costs in foreign exchange transactions.

There has been a considerable pick-up in INR-based invoicing and settlement since July 2022, RBI said.

During the period August 2022-July 2025, the compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of imports and exports invoiced in

INR has been at 20.9 per cent and 12.7 per cent, respectively. Further, the latest data on trade invoicing and settlement in Indian Rupee (INR) during 2025-26 exhibit a year-on-year growth for export invoicing (6.5 per cent), import invoicing (9.5 per cent), export settlement (2.7 per cent) and import settlement (41.2 per cent), over the corresponding period of the previous year.

In absolute terms, INR invoicing in imports stood at Rs 2.85 lakh crore in 2025-26, up from Rs 2.60 lakh crore in 2024-25 and Rs 1.94 lakh crore in 2023-24. In case of exports, the invoicing stood at Rs 3.27 lakh crore during the last fiscal, up from Rs 3.07 lakh crore in 2024-25 and Rs 2.87 lakh crore in 2023-24, the data showed.

INR settlement in imports

stood at Rs 1.60 lakh crore during 2025-26, compared to Rs 1.13 lakh crore in 2024-25 and Rs 99,680 crore in the year before.

In case of exports, the settlements were valued at Rs 1.72 lakh crore during 2025-26, Rs 1.67 lakh crore in 2024-25 and Rs 1.75 lakh crore in 2023-24.

The INR internationalisation process has been mutually beneficial to all trading partners, and based on the principles of reciprocity, it has given a fillip to trade invoicing in several other emerging market currencies, RBI said.

The Indian rupee traded with a depreciating bias during the last fiscal year amidst trade-related uncertainties, geopolitical tensions, and foreign portfolio investment (FPI) outflows in the equity segment. FII

Rupee rises 73 paise to 94.85 against US dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated 73 paise to close at 94.85 against the US dollar in early trade on Friday, as renewed optimism over the peace deal between the US and Iran boosted market sentiments.

Forex traders said the USD/INR pair appreciated on an overnight decline in crude oil prices and a fall in the US dollar, after the US and Iran reached an understanding to extend the ceasefire for another 60 days.

On Thursday, the US and Iranian negotiators reached a tentative agreement to extend the ceasefire by 60 days and start a new round of talks on Iran's nuclear programme.

At the interbank foreign

exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.77 against the US dollar, then touched an intra-day high of 94.97 and a low of 95.78 during the day.

At the end of Friday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 94.85, up 73 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee settled higher by 12 paise at 95.58 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.13, up 0.11 per cent. Forex traders said attention has now shifted toward the upcoming RBI Monetary Policy Committee meeting scheduled for June 3-5.

BPTP launches luxury residential project in Gurugram with estimated value of ₹2,500 cr

GURUGRAM: BPTP Limited has launched Downtown 66, a premium residential development in Sector 66, Gurugram, with an estimated gross development value (GDV) of around Rs 2,500 crore.

The project, coming up on Golf Course Extension Road, will feature 504 luxury apartments in 3 and 3.5 BHK configurations, with prices starting from Rs 5.32 crore. The development is being built with an estimated investment of nearly Rs 1,200 crore.

Rising about 150 metres, Downtown 66 has been designed as a walkable urban community inspired by global downtown districts, integrating

The project will feature 504 luxury apartments in 3 and 3.5 BHK configurations, with prices starting from Rs 5.32 crore

residences with lifestyle, dining, entertainment and wellness spaces.

The project adopts a hospitality-led planning approach, focusing on curated social spaces, resident privacy and experience-driven design. It includes dining areas, lounges

and entertainment zones aimed at creating a self-contained social ecosystem for residents.

BPTP said wellness has been integrated into the overall design through dedicated fitness, recovery and relaxation zones, along with landscaped open spaces. The development will offer around 1.35 lakh sq. ft. of amenities and landscaped areas, including a clubhouse, yoga and meditation rooms, hammam, sauna, jacuzzi, gymnasium and indoor heated pool.

Architecturally, the towers

will feature glass-and-metal facades designed to maximise daylight, ventilation and panoramic views. Each floor will house four residences with

wraparound decks and multiple high-speed lifts. The structure has also been designed in line with seismic Zone V standards for high-rise buildings.

The project has received IGBC Platinum pre-certification and incorporates energy-efficient systems, passive cooling strategies and water conservation measures. Located in one of Gurugram's key micro-markets, the development offers connectivity to Golf Course Road, Sohna Road, NH-48 and Dwarka Expressway.

Hong Kong-based AEDAS is leading the architecture and interior design, while Singapore-based Coopers Hill is handling landscape planning. MPOST

Indian-owned cos in UK rise in record investment year

Bilateral trade between India and the UK rose 11.7% year-on-year to 47.4 billion pounds in 2025

LONDON: The number of Indian-owned companies operating in the UK rose nearly 60 per cent year-on-year to 1,912 in 2026, with their combined turnover reaching 105.77 billion pounds, according to the latest 'India Meets Britain Tracker'.

The annual report, led by Grant Thornton and launched in London by Indian High Commissioner P Kumaran, showed a sharp increase from 1,197 firms with a turnover of 72.14 billion pounds in 2025.

Employment generated by these companies also climbed

CLOSER LOOK

- » The combined turnover of Indian-owned firms reached 105.77 bn pounds, 'India Meets Britain Tracker' said
- » The annual report showed a sharp rise from 1,197 firms with a turnover of 72.14 billion pounds in 2025
- » According to the report, 66 Indian companies recorded annual revenue growth of at least 10 per cent

to 203,549 from 126,720 a year earlier.

The report noted that bilateral trade between India and the UK rose 11.7 per cent year-on-year to 47.4 billion pounds in 2025, the year the two countries signed the

Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA).

Kumaran said the India-UK relationship is now driven by economic opportunity, with India contributing scale, growth and talent, while the UK offers innovation, finance

and expertise.

Grant Thornton Partner Anuj Chande said the India-UK corridor is evolving into a strategic partnership spanning technology, clean energy and advanced manufacturing.

He added that CETA is expected to accelerate trade and investment flows further once implemented.

According to the report, 66 Indian companies recorded annual revenue growth of at least 10 per cent, with an average growth rate of 61 per cent.

Technology, media and telecom remained the dom-

inant sectors for Indian businesses in the UK, followed by manufacturing and pharmaceuticals.

London continued as the preferred destination, hosting 38 per cent of Indian firms, though growth in other regions also gathered pace.

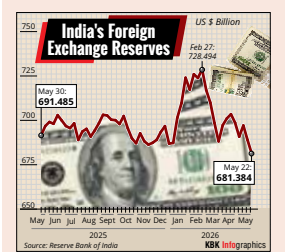
The report highlighted rising operational costs, regulatory complexities and competition as key challenges, while noting that the UK's stable legal and financial systems and focus on clean energy and digital technology continue to attract Indian investment.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



PNB Housing Finance Ltd announced its support towards the Indian Navy for delivering advanced healthcare facilities at the Naval Station Health and Wellness Centre, Swastika, located within INS India Campus in New Delhi. The facility was inaugurated by Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi CNS, Shashi Tripathi, President NWWA in the presence of Ajai Shukla MD & CEO PNB Housing Finance Ltd & Gita Nayyar, Chairperson, CSR Committee along with senior officials of the Indian Navy and PNB Housing Finance. MPOST

Forex kitty drops \$7.5 bn to \$681.38 bn



MUMBAI: India's forex reserves dropped \$7.51 billion to \$681.38 billion during the week ended May 22, the Reserve Bank said on Friday.

In the previous reporting week, the kitty had dropped \$8.094 billion to \$688.894 billion.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the Middle East conflict.

For the week ended May 22, foreign currency assets, decreased \$2.872 billion to \$543.032 billion, the central bank's data showed. The value of gold reserves also declined \$4.53 billion to \$114.786 billion during the week.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDR) were down by \$77 million to \$18.748 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) was also down by \$33 million to \$4.818 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the RBI data.

ONLY 1% OF ISSUES REMAIN TO FINALISE TRADE DEAL: GOR

‘No partnership better positioned than US-India for emerging tech’

‘We’re gathered at a defining moment, one where critical and emerging technologies are fundamentally reshaping the global balance of power’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: No partnership is better positioned than the one between India and the US to seize emerging opportunities, particularly in high-technology and critical minerals, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said on Friday, while noting that only one per cent of issues remain to finalise the proposed trade deal between the two sides.

In an address at an event, the envoy also said that the US has been actively re-calibrating its export control policies to reflect the current technological and geopolitical landscape and balance legitimate security concerns with enabling commerce and innovation.

Gor touched upon various facets of India-US relations and said there is significant opportunities to expand it further in areas of artificial intelligence, trade and investment, critical technology, pharmaceuticals and research and innovation.

“We’re gathered at a defining moment, one where critical and emerging technologies are fundamentally reshaping the global balance of power. And I believe no partnership is better



United States Ambassador to India Sergio Gor

I want us to be ambitious & shape US-India relationship into defining strategic partnership of the 21st century

positioned to lead that charge than ours,” he said.

“At the same time of this immense transformation, I want us to be ambitious and shape the US-India relationship into the defining strategic partnership of the 21st century -- one that delivers tangible benefits for both of our nations and our people,” he said. Gor was speaking on “US-India TRUST Initiative: Advancing Partnership in

Highlights

» Trump administration has identified “new centres of power” such as India, leading to initiatives such as TRUST, Gor said

» The goal is to encourage innovation with our most trusted partners while ensuring sensitive technologies are protected, Gor said

» Bilateral trade has grown from \$20 billion to over \$220 billion in goods and services in just over two decades

The goal is to encourage innovation with our most trusted partners while ensuring sensitive technologies are protected, the envoy said.

US Under Secretary of State for Public Diplomacy Sarah Rogers also briefly addressed the event, highlighting the importance the Trump administration attaches to its ties with India. “I don’t think we could be luckier than we are to have a partner like India in a critical region,” she said.

In his remarks, Gor, citing the upswing in the bilateral economic engagement, said the proposed interim trade agreement between the two sides is nearing finalisation and that the bilateral trade has grown from \$20 billion to over \$220 billion in goods and services in just over two decades.

“Our current interim trade agreement is on the table for us to finalise and that will unlock prosperity for both of our countries. Just last week, India had sent a team to Washington DC to finalise the last one per cent of that trade deal,” Gor said.

“Next week, we will welcome a US delegation here to continue those talks. We fully

expect that the trade deal will be signed over the next few weeks and months,” he added.

India and the US in February released a joint statement about agreeing on a framework for an interim trade deal for reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. Gor said deeper economic ties between the two sides reflected broader engagement and stronger economic integration.

“Our investment in trade expansion offers transformative potential. President Trump’s goal is to facilitate bilateral trade in a way that creates unprecedented opportunities for American businesses and workers.

“Our current interim trade agreement is on the table for us to finalise and that will unlock prosperity for both of our countries,” he said.

“Today, the US is one of India’s largest trading partners, and India is among the top trading partners of the US. Importantly, this growth is increasingly driven by innovation, investment and high value sectors, from digital trade and advanced manufacturing to energy and emerging technologies,” he said.

PSU banks asked to adopt prudent expenditure & maintain resilience

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The finance ministry on Friday asked public sector banks (PSBs) to adopt prudent expenditure and austerity measures at all levels while maintaining resilience amid evolving global uncertainties.

Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju, while chairing a meeting to review the financial performance of PSBs, advised them to provide proactive and need-based support to eligible borrowers under ECLGS 5.0, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms with adequate oversight, improve operational efficiency and explore new business opportunities to sustain profitability and long-term growth.

Banks were advised to maintain preparedness and adaptability to the recent crisis in the Middle East and evolving global situation, the finance ministry said in a statement.

Performance of PSBs across key areas, including business growth, profitability, asset quality, implementation of government schemes, financial inclusion, digital ecosystem, MSME credit flow, cyber resilience and operational risk management was comprehensively assessed.

It was highlighted that PSBs demonstrated strong financial and operational performance during FY26.

Aggregate business of public sector banks reached approximately Rs 283.3 lakh crore as on March 31,



2026, while aggregate net profit increased to around Rs 1.98 lakh crore, recording the highest-ever annual net profit in the history of PSBs, it said.

Asset quality also remained robust, with Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA) reaching a historic low of 1.93 per cent and Net Non-Performing Assets (NNPA) declining to 0.39 per cent, reflecting continued strengthening of balance sheets and prudent risk management practices, it said.

Progress under major financial inclusion initiatives, including Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, social security schemes, Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana, PM Vishwakarma and digital lending programmes, were also reviewed, it said.

Public sector banks continue to play a pivotal role in expanding financial access and strengthening last-mile delivery of banking services across the country, it said.

The status of implementation of end-to-end digital lending journeys for small-value loans and welfare-linked schemes was also reviewed during the meeting.

PSBs highlighted measures such as paperless processing through e-KYC and digital documentation, straight through processing (STP) and integration with government platforms to improve accessibility and customer experience, it said.

Deliberations also covered strengthening of digital banking ecosystems, enhancement of cyber security frameworks and initiatives for improving access to credit for MSMEs and other productive sectors of the economy, it said.

During the meeting, a coffee table book on ‘Aapki Poonji, Aapka Adhikar (Your Money, Your Right)’ was unveiled.

It captures the nationwide campaign undertaken to empower citizens to identify and reclaim unclaimed financial assets and highlights collaborative efforts by banks, financial institutions, regulators and other stakeholders towards facilitating tracing, claim settlement and restitution of unclaimed financial assets to their rightful owners.

Over the past six months, more than Rs 6,800 crore has been restituted to nearly 29 lakh claimants across the country, it said.

The revamped website of the Department of Financial Services was also launched during the meeting, it said.

Designed with a citizen-centric approach, the portal offers enhanced accessibility, seamless navigation and improved dissemination of information, it said.

Jio IPO nears as Ambani eyes wider stakeholder participation



NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries Ltd Chairman Mukesh D Ambani is evaluating pathways to broader stakeholder participation in Jio Platforms as the timeline set by him for the company’s IPO nears.

During the AGM of RIL in August 2025, Ambani set the timeline of the first half of 2026 for listing Jio.

Ambani, in RIL’s annual report published on Thursday, said the company is taking deliberate steps to strengthen Jio’s institutional framework, enhance transparency and prepare it for opportunities ahead as the digital services evolve into a global technology leader.

“We will continue to evaluate strategic pathways that can broaden stakeholder participation and support Jio’s long-term growth, always guided by the principle of sustainable value creation,” Ambani said.

RIL holds 66.43 per cent of the paid-up equity share capital of Jio Platforms Limited (JPL). Meta and Google hold 17.71 per cent of the balance, 33.57 per cent in JPL. Analysts estimate that the Jio IPO can be the biggest public offer to date at a valuation in range of \$130 billion to \$180 billion. PFI

Moody’s upgrades RIL to Baa1 on strong balance sheet, diversified bizs

NEW DELHI: Moody’s Ratings has upgraded Reliance Industries Ltd to Baa1 from Baa2 - two notches above India’s sovereign rating, citing the conglomerate’s resilient credit profile, diversified operations and strong financial discipline.

The ratings agency said Reliance benefits from its leading positions across oil-to-chemicals, digital services and retail, as well as counter-cyclical business segments and significant international exposure, with more than one-third of revenue coming from exports.

The agency added that Reliance’s scale, diversified earnings streams and limited dependence on government-linked revenues support its ability to generate stable earnings through economic cycles.

Moody’s also highlighted the company’s strong liquidity position, with about \$25 billion in cash and modest debt levels, alongside sustained cash-flow generation and strong access to domestic and international capital markets.

The upgrade comes under Moody’s revised sovereign-linked ratings methodology, which allows some companies to be rated up to two notches above the sovereign if they demonstrate strong resilience and limited exposure to domestic economic stress.

However, Reliance’s rating remains capped at two notches above India’s sovereign rating of Baa3 because of its significant exposure to the domestic economy through its fast-growing telecom and retail businesses, Moody’s said.

The agency assigned a sta-

ble outlook to Reliance, mirroring the outlook on India’s sovereign rating and reflecting expectations that earnings growth across most business segments will keep credit metrics strong over the next one to two years.

Moody’s said an upgrade would depend on an improvement in India’s sovereign rating, while maintaining key metrics including funds from operations-to-net debt above 25 per cent, net debt-to-EBITDA below 2.0 times, and EBITDA-to-interest coverage above 7.0 times.

A downgrade could result from a sharp deterioration in operating performance, aggressive capital spending, large acquisitions or shareholder payouts that materially increase borrowings, the agency said. PFI

Vedanta secures highest credit rating in over decade following ICRA Upgrade

NEW DELHI: Vedanta Group on Friday said that it has received its highest domestic credit rating in over a decade after rating agency ICRA upgraded the long-term ratings of its key group entities to AA+.

Securities with an AA+ rating are considered to have a high degree of safety regarding timely servicing of financial obligations. Such securities carry very low credit risk.

“ICRA upgraded the long-term ratings of Vedanta Ltd and Vedanta Aluminium Metal Ltd (VAML) to AA+ with a stable outlook, while Talwandi Sabo Power Lim-

ited (TSPL) was upgraded to AA- Stable from A+/Watch Developing,” Vedanta said in a statement.

The agency also reaffirmed the Group’s short-term rating at the highest category of A1+. The latest rating action marks Vedanta’s highest domestic credit rating since 2014 and represents a significant milestone for the Group as two of the largest businesses emerging from the demerger framework have now secured an AA+ rating.

Together, these two businesses account for over 75 per cent of the group’s long-term debt. PFI

IIFCL reports record sanctions of ₹57,680 crore in fiscal 2025-26

NEW DELHI: India Infrastructure Finance Company Limited (IIFCL) reported record annual sanctions of Rs 57,680 crore in FY 2025-26, marking a 13 per cent increase over the previous year, as the state-owned infrastructure financier expanded its lending activities and strengthened asset quality.

Managing Director Rohit Rishi said annual disbursements rose 16 per cent year-on-year to Rs 32,972 crore, while cumulative disbursements reached around Rs 1.89 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026. On a consolidated basis, total disbursements crossed Rs 2.14 lakh crore.

IIFCL’s standalone loan book grew nearly 17 per cent



IIFCL MD Rohit Rishi

to Rs 81,715 crore during the fiscal, supported by expansion across infrastructure sectors and a diversified lending portfolio.

The company’s operating income nearly doubled over the past five years to Rs 6,972 crore in FY26 from Rs 3,618 crore in

FY22, while operating profit rose to Rs 2,197 crore from Rs 1,168 crore. Profit before tax stood at Rs 1,984 crore and profit after tax at Rs 1,379 crore during fiscal 2025-26.

Net worth increased to Rs 17,898 crore from Rs 16,395 crore a year earlier, while the capital to risk-weighted assets ratio remained strong at 20.53 per cent.

IIFCL also reported a sharp improvement in asset quality, with gross NPAs declining to 0.40 per cent from 1.11 per cent last year, and net NPAs reducing to zero. Around 96 per cent of its assets were externally rated ‘A’ and above as of March 2026. MPOST

UJVN Limited launches weekly ‘No Vehicle Day’

NEW DELHI: UJVN Limited has decided to implement a weekly “No Vehicle Day” across its offices to promote energy conservation, fuel savings and environmental protection in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s sustainability call and Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami’s green development vision.

Managing Director Ajay Kumar Singh said all GMs and DGMs have been directed to designate one day each week as “No Vehicle Day”. Saturdays will be observed at the headquarters, while regional offices will select suitable days. The firm has also instructed offices to minimise air-conditioner usage and use them only when necessary to

reduce power consumption. Employees are being encouraged to use bicycles, public transport and electric vehicles.

UJVN has also directed canteens to reduce cooking oil usage, encouraged virtual meetings wherever feasible, and advised limiting non-essential expenditure and foreign travel.

As part of its renewable energy initiatives, UJVN has installed rooftop solar plants and solar trees with a combined capacity of 238 kW at its headquarters and additional rooftop solar systems with 91 kW capacity at offices in Dakpathar, Dhakrani, Rishikesh and Haridwar. EV charging facilities have also been set up at the Ujjwal headquarters campus. MPOST

IndiGo posts ₹2,537 cr Q4 loss due to multiple headwinds

The country’s largest airline had a profit of Rs 3,067.5 crore in the year-ago period

NEW DELHI: Flying into the red, IndiGo on Friday reported a loss of Rs 2,536.9 crore in the March quarter due to multiple headwinds, including challenging operating conditions and rupee depreciation.

The country’s largest airline had a profit of Rs 3,067.5 crore in the year-ago period.

For the 2025-26 fiscal, the carrier posted a net loss of Rs 2,393.6 crore, but excluding the impact of foreign exchange and exceptional items, it would have been a profit of Rs 7,502.5 crore, it said in a release.

Total income in the fourth quarter of the 2025-26 fis-

CLOSER LOOK

» For the financial year 2025-26, the carrier posted a net loss of Rs 2,393.6 crore

» But excluding the impact of forex and exceptional items, it would have been a profit of Rs 7,502.5 crore

» Total income in Q4 FY26 rose over 3% to Rs 23,830.7 cr from Rs 23,097.5 cr in the same period a year ago

cal rose over 3 per cent to Rs 23,830.7 crore from Rs 23,097.5 crore in the same period a year ago, according to a release.

“For the quarter ended March 2026, IndiGo reported a net loss of INR 25,369 million. Excluding the impact of for-

ign exchange and exceptional items, the company reported a net profit of Rs 19,206 million,” the release said.

Despite continuing external disruptions in 2025-26, IndiGo said its capacity rose 9.5 per cent on an annual basis, and the

total income grew 6.4 per cent to Rs 89,513.4 crore.

“Exceptionally sharp rupee depreciation, changes in labour laws and a challenging operating environment offset the operational profit and the company reported a net loss of Rs 23,936 million,” the airline said.

In 2025-26, the foreign exchange loss was around Rs 8,100 crore, and the impact of the December flight disruptions stood at Rs 580 crore. Besides, the expenses related to the implementation of the new labour laws were at Rs 1,200 crore, as per the airline’s financial statements. PFI

IndiGo MD Rahul Bhatia said FY26 was marked by an exceptionally challenging operating environment, which materially impacted its profitability.

“During the year, our capacity grew by 9.5 per cent, and total income increased by over 6 per cent. Excluding the impact of foreign exchange and exceptional items, IndiGo delivered a profit of Rs 75 billion,” he said.

In the June quarter, capacity in terms of ASKs (Available Seat Kilometres) is expected to grow around 3-4 per cent as compared to the first quarter of fiscal year 2026. PFI

HYDERABAD: NMDC reported its strongest-ever operational and financial performance in FY26, driven by higher production, strong sales and improved operational efficiency.

Iron ore production rose 21 per cent year-on-year to a record 53.16 million tonnes, while sales increased 13 per cent to 50.24 million tonnes, the highest annual volumes in the company’s history.

The strong operational growth lifted FY26 turnover by 33 per cent to an all-time high of Rs 31,554 crore. EBITDA rose 9 per cent to Rs 10,737 crore,



Amitava Mukherjee, CMD, NMDC

while profit before tax (PBT) increased 9 per cent to Rs 10,155 crore. Net profit grew 11 per cent to Rs 7,421 crore.

NMDC incurred capital expenditure of Rs 3,690 crore during the fiscal. The board recommended a final dividend of

Re 1 per share, taking the total dividend payout for FY26 to Rs 3,077 crore, including the interim dividend of Rs 2.5 per share declared earlier.

The company also reported strong fourth-quarter performance. Iron ore production increased 22 per cent year-on-year to 16.27 million tonnes, while sales rose 21 per cent to 15.30 million tonnes. Quarterly turnover surged 61 per cent to Rs 11,173 crore. PBT rose 22 per cent to Rs 2,875 crore, while net profit climbed 35 per cent to Rs 2,020 crore. EBITDA for the quarter grew 21 per cent to Rs 3,072 crore. MPOST

Where there's a Gill...

Captain sends GT into third IPL final; Sooryavanshi's heroics go in vain

MULLANPUR: Shubman Gill produced a conventional batting masterclass in the age of muscle on the way to a majestic hundred here on Friday, leading Gujarat Titans to a dominating seven-wicket win over Rajasthan Royals and a third final in five seasons of the Indian Premier League.

First it was boy wonder Vaibhav Sooryavanshi who played some astonishing shots in a brilliantly paced 96 off 47 balls to steer Rajasthan Royals to 214 for six after Royals opted to bat on a used surface in the Qualifier 2.

The target was in the range of a top-heavy Titans but they ended up making short work of it courtesy a special 167-run stand off 77 balls between the prolific opening duo of Gill (104 off 53) and Sai Sudharsan (58 off 32).

Freakishly, Sudharsan lost the control of his bat for the second game in a row to be hit wicket. Titans coasted to the target in 18.4 overs.

Titans will meet defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the final in Ahmedabad on Sunday, days after being hammered by the same team in Dharamsala.

Highlighting their remarkable consistency, Titans have entered the final thrice since



Shubman Gill's 53-ball 104 included three sixes and 15 fours

PTI

their inaugural season in 2022 when they lifted the trophy.

Rajasthan Royals have two X-factor players in Sooryavanshi and Jofra Archer and both had to deliver to take their team to the final. Sooryavanshi did but on a rare occasion Archer went wicket-less in the powerplay and the others failed to step up.

The manner in which Gill

and Sudharsan batted in the chase was a treat for the purists of the game. Piercing the field with proper cricketing shots is their strength and that is what they did to perfection.

Gill loves the pull shot and he executed it with ease even against the express pace of Jofra Archer. He used the feet against spinners for boundaries and used the same tactic to reach

his hundred, picking Jadeja for a four over extra cover.

With the kind of season Gill has had, he has made a strong case for his inclusion in the India T20 squad after being dropped in the lead-up to the World Cup. He collected 15 fours and three sixes in his classy knock.

There was a bigger crowd in attendance than on Wednesday

2

Gill is the only player to hit two centuries in Indian Premier League playoffs

night, and the majority of them turned up to watch 15-year-old Sooryavanshi go about his beligerent business.

They got more than their money's worth with Sooryavanshi continuing to boss the best bowlers around, including Kagiso Rabada and Jason Holder on this occasion.

Having lost Yashavi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel inside the second over, Sooryavanshi needed to adapt on a used surface where Mohammed Siraj, Rabada and Prasidh Krishna came with a clear plan: bowl back of a length into the body and throw in the odd bouncer to contain Sooryavanshi.

With the same pitch picked for the second game in a row, the ball did not come on to the bat as nicely as it did in the Eliminator.

AGENCIES

UNBEATEN ON CLAY THIS SEASON

Kostyuk slays on clay as Swiatek rolls past compatriot Linette

PARIS: Still unbeaten on clay this season, Marta Kostyuk reached the fourth round at the French Open for the second time on Friday and set up a big match against four-time champion Iga Swiatek.

The 15th-ranked Ukrainian is in an excellent run of form and extended her winning streak on clay to 15 matches with a 6-4, 6-3 win over Viktorija Golubic on yet another hot day in Paris. Ahead of Roland Garros, she won in Madrid — the biggest title of her career — after she claimed another clay-court title in Rouen, France.

She previously reached the fourth round in Paris in 2021, when she lost to Swiatek. A rematch is coming up next after Swiatek defeated fellow Polish player Magda Linette 6-4, 6-4.

"Marta is having a great season," said Swiatek, who has not won a title on clay since the 2024 French Open. "She always had a game to play well. Did some semifinals of big tournaments before. Now she won Madrid. So good for her."

Swiatek, however, has won in straight sets all three times she has played Kostyuk and has experience on her side in Paris, holding a 43-3 record overall at Roland Garros.

"I'm still the person who



Marta Kostyuk meets Iga Swiatek next

AP

Swiatek defeated fellow Polish player Magda Linette 6-4, 6-4

lost to her three times, and she's won this tournament four times," Kostyuk said. "I would love to be the one who is a favorite in this match, but I still don't think it's the case, even though I have this really long streak."

Also advancing to the fourth round was 36-year-old Sorana Cirstea, who routed

Solana Sierra and became the oldest player in the Open Era to claim a 6-0 6-0 win in a Grand Slam tournament. She will next face Wang Xiyu of China, who beat Ukrainian Yulia Starodubtseva 6-3, 7-5. The Chinese qualifier has still not dropped a set in her campaign.

Eighth-seeded Mirra Andreeva progressed with a 6-4, 6-2 win against Czech opponent Marie Bouzkova. Andreeva leads the women's tour with 32 victories this season. Her fourth-round match pits her against Jill Teichmann, who beat 10th-seeded Karolina Muchova 6-1, 7-5.

AGENCIES

PART WAYS AS EXPECTED

Pant-LSG partnership: A brief chapter closed



Rishabh Pant returns to the pavilion

PTI

NEW DELHI: Dashing keeper-batter Rishabh Pant was on Friday relieved of Lucknow Super Giants' captaincy after a disastrous 2026 IPL season in which they finished last among 10 teams.

Pant was set to lose captaincy, something which was reiterated by LSG's Director of Cricket Tom Moody.

"Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) wish to formally announce that Rishabh Pant has requested to be relieved of his captaincy duties with the franchise, and the franchisee has accepted his request with immediate effect," the franchise said in an official statement.

"Rishabh approached the franchisee with this request and we have respectfully accepted it," Moody was quoted as saying in the media release.

"These decisions are never easy. We are grateful for everything Rishabh has brought to this dressing room as captain," the former Australian all-rounder added.

It can be said with a degree of certainty after talking to those tracking developments that the 28-year-old Pant might not want to stay back merely as a player and could either be available for trading or released for auction.

“

These decisions are never easy. We are grateful for everything Rishabh has brought to this dressing room as captain

Tom Moody

As a batter, it turned out to be a woeful season in which he got only 312 runs in 14 innings.

As chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar pointed out, Pant should now look at being the best batter that he can be in Test cricket and then work his way up the white-ball ladder once again. It's time for him to think beyond captaincy and care for the batter in him which can win matches for India.

LSG were decent in their first two years when they made it to play-offs under KL Rahul's captaincy and Gautam Gambhir's mentorship.

However, things started going downhill from the 2024 season, when Gambhir had left for KKR.

AGENCIES

Women's hockey team take lead in Oz

PERTH: India struck two field goals to defeat hosts Australia in the third game to take a 2-1 lead in the four-match women's friendly hockey series, here on Friday.

The two sides displayed a disciplined defensive display as the first two quarters went goalless.

India eventually found the breakthrough in the third quarter when Sonam (36th minute) scored to put the visitors ahead. India continued their momentum in the final quarter when Lalremsiami (49th) doubled the lead.

The Indians then defended in numbers to deny any breakthrough to the Australian side to secure a deserving win.

The fourth and final match of the series will be played on Saturday at the same venue.

India had lost 1-2 against Australia in the series opener but bounced back strongly to beat the hosts 4-2 in shoot-out after both the sides were locked 1-1 at the end of regulation time in the second match.

The Indians have impressed in most aspects of the game in the tour so far, especially in defence and midfield. The tour series is important ahead of the Nations Cup.

AGENCIES

Gukesh's Norway nightmare goes on; Praggnanandhaa stays second

OSLO: World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen returned to winning ways with a crushing victory over reigning classical world champion D Gukesh, sending the young Indian to the bottom of the standings, while R Praggnanandhaa stayed second after beating Vincent Keymer in Armageddon at the Norway Chess here.

Seven-time Norway Chess champion Carlsen, who had endured a sluggish start to the tournament, climbed from last to sole fourth with 4.5 points after bagging three full points, while a dejected Gukesh slipped away quietly from the playing hall through a side exit, leaving scores of young fans waiting for autographs.

Going into Friday's rest day, Alireza Firouzja remained comfortably on top despite suffering his first defeat of the event -- an Armageddon loss to Wesley So after their classical game ended in a draw.

Firouzja still collected a valuable point to move to 8.5, maintaining a healthy 2.5-point lead over sole second-placed Praggnanandhaa on six points.

American Wesley So sits third on 5.5 points, a point ahead of Carlsen, while Keymer is on four.

At the bottom is reign-



Magnus Carlsen played a nice game with the black pieces

NORWAY CHESS

Gukesh sinks to bottom after losing to Carlsen

ing world champion Gukesh on 3.5 points, as the tournament threatens to turn into another nightmare campaign for the young Indian ahead of his world title defence against challenger Javokhir Sindarov later this year.

There were no table-slams or dramatic "Oh my God!" moments from Carlsen this time, unlike his emotional loss to Gukesh last year, as the Norwegian great clinically converted his advantage with the black pieces.

"I wouldn't say I was super-

motivated today. I kind of had enough after playing really poorly for three days in a row with very little time. Today, I didn't have a lot of expectations, but I was happy with the way things went in the opening," Carlsen said after the game.

The five-time world champion admitted that he was surprised by Gukesh's choice of opening. "I was surprised by Nf3. I wasn't sure if I couldn't take it, but it seemed like a draw at most. He sometimes plays a little too ambitiously and I think he did that today as well. He wanted to prove a serious advantage, and I'm not sure there was one. Eventually, he played himself into some trouble and I gradually took over," Carlsen added.

AGENCIES

UCL final: Unstoppable force of PSG meets immovable object in Arsenal

BUDAPEST: Attack vs defense? Beauty vs the beast? Art vs science? Even if that's too simplistic a way of looking at the Champions League final between Paris Saint-Germain and Arsenal on Saturday, it pretty much sums up the clash of styles likely to be on show at the Puskás Aréna in Budapest.

In one corner is Luis Enrique's PSG, the top scorer in this season's Champions League with 44 goals — that's an average of more than three per game — and the clinical, relentless juggernaut that blew away Inter Milan 5-0 in last year's title match for the biggest win in a final in the competition's 70-year history.

In the other is Mikel Arteta's Arsenal, the newly crowned English champion which owns by far the Champions League's meanest defense, a smother-



Arsenal's player train on the eve of the final

X

ing off-the-ball set-up, and the most efficient, advanced set-piece threat around. The unstoppable force vs. the immovable object? Something

like that. If anyone has the tools to stop PSG from becoming just the second team to retain the title in the Champions League era, it's surely Arteta.

Arsenal have kept 9 clean sheets — 3 more than any other team in UCL

Best team at defending Luis Enrique is in no doubt. "They're the best defensive team in Europe," the PSG coach said of Arsenal, "and they have been for a few years."

The statistics bear this out. In this season's Champions League, Arsenal have kept nine clean sheets — three more than any other team — and let in just six goals in their 14 games. Two of those goals came in the final round, a dead match against

Kairat Almaty because Arsenal had already qualified. PSG, by comparison, has conceded 22 goals.

Over in the Premier League, Arsenal had shutouts in exactly half of the 38 games in its title-winning campaign and let in just 27 goals, the fewest by eight. By the time the title was clinched with a round to spare, Arsenal had played 37 games and allowed just one shot on target or fewer in 13 of them.

Arteta typically deploys a back four consisting of four center backs — a tactic first used in English soccer by his mentor, Pep Guardiola — with a screening midfielder in either Declan Rice or Martin Zubimendi in front. Get through all that and there's David Raya — arguably the Premier League's best goalkeeper this season — to bail the team out.

AGENCIES

Messi is in Argentina's WC squad as Scaloni calms injury fears

BUENOS AIRES: Amid a worrying rash of injuries, Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni sought to dispel doubts by confirming that most of the reigning world champions, including captain Lionel Messi, will be part of the squad that will seek a second consecutive title at the 2026 World Cup.

Messi, about to turn 39, headlines the 26-man World Cup roster announced by the Argentine Football Association on Thursday.

Of those called up, 17 players were part of the team that triumphed four years ago in the final against France in Qatar.

Several of those players were in doubt due to injuries of varying severity, close to the June 1 deadline set by FIFA for finalising World Cup squads. Among them was Messi himself, who is suffering from muscle fatigue and strain in his left hamstring, which prevented him from finishing the match with Inter Miami last Sunday.

The club has officially stated that his recovery time will depend on "his clinical and functional progress." Messi will be playing in his sixth World Cup, having previously participated in Germany 2006, South Africa 2010, Brazil 2015, Russia 2018 and Qatar 2022.



Goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez, who fractured the ring finger of his right hand during last week's Europa League final in which Aston Villa defeated Freiburg, has also been confirmed.

Scaloni also included defender Cristian Romero, who is recovering from a sprained collateral ligament in his right knee suffered in mid-April while playing for Tottenham, and fullbacks Nahuel Molina and Gonzalo Montiel, who scored the decisive penalty kicks in the 2002 World Cup shootout against France, both of whom are recovering from muscle injuries. Argentina, also world champions in 1978 and 1986, will debut on June 16 against Algeria in Group J, which also includes Austria and Jordan.

AGENCIES

Nadal opens up about battle with foot injury

LONDON: Rafael Nadal, winner of 22 Grand Slams and one of the 'Big Three' along with Roger Federer and Novak Djokovic who ruled tennis for two decades, spent most of his career in pain as he willed himself to play through a chronic foot injury.

The Spaniard, who retired in 2024, said he took immense risks with his health to keep his tennis career going, after a Netflix series called 'Rafa' provided an in-depth look into his physical and mental struggles to pursue greatness.

"I've had to make decisions about my health, where you are on the borderline between right or wrong. But if I hadn't explored all that, I probably would have had 10 fewer Grand Slams... this is the reality," Nadal told the BBC in an interview published on Friday.

Nadal was diagnosed with a rare condition called Mueller-Weiss syndrome after he broke his foot during the Madrid Open final of 2005, months after he won the French Open on his first attempt aged 19, clinching his first Grand Slam title.

Although the condition, which was caused by his extensive training as a child under his uncle Toni, put his career at risk, Nadal refused to give up.

AGENCIES



Regd. Office: ICICI Bank Limited, Landmark, Race Course Circle, Vadodara- 390007

Corporate Office: ICICI Bank Towers, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai- 400051

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Shal Tower Plot No. 23, New Rohtak Road Karol Bagh New Delhi-110005

Notice for Disclosure of Legal Heirs of Deceased Borrower

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that Home Loan LBFD00004694265 (Credit facility) was granted to PRASHANT YADAV OF BORROWER, Co-Borrower, Guarantor/Mortgagor (excluding deceased borrower) (Borrowers) along with the deceased NAMITA YADAV by ICICI Bank Ltd. (The Bank).

We would like to inform you that the demise of NAMITA YADAV has come to our knowledge during field visits conducted by the Bank officials and by telephonic communications on the registered contact numbers. In this regard, letter dated 26 May, 2026 was previously sent to the registered addresses of the Borrowers and the deceased NAMITA YADAV, for providing information about the Legal Heirs of the deceased Borrower. Therefore, this Notice is hereby given for sharing details of the Legal Heirs of the deceased NAMITA YADAV with supporting documents for updating the Bank's records, within 15 days of publication of this Notice. You may submit the above-mentioned details to RAJ KUMAR by visiting Address: : ICICI BANK LTD PLOT NO. 7, COMMUNITY CENTRE S.D. TOWER, SECTOR 8, ROHINI NEW DELHI - 110085

Date: May 30, 2026 SD Authorised Officer
Place: Faridabad (Haryana) For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sajauddin S/o Kamruddin R/o 650, E-Block, Jahangir Puri, Azadpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence CC No. 3343/2022 u/s 138 NI Act at P.S. Shalimar Bagh, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Sajauddin** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sajauddin** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr. P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sajauddin** accused of CC No. 3343/2022 u/s 138 NI Act at P.S. Shalimar Bagh, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **22.07.2026**.

By Order: Sh. Apoorv Bhardwaj,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02 (North-West),
Room No. 113, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6791/NW/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Notice for Shortlisting of PAD/Non-PAD Items/Brands

For and on behalf of the President of India, Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Delhi Division, Northern Railway invites applications in prescribed format from renowned and eligible manufacturers/suppliers/firms for shortlisting of PAD/Non-PAD items/brands for sale/supply at catering establishments over Delhi Division, Northern Railway for the period 01.04.2027 to 31.03.2029.

Applications for shortlisting may be submitted in the office of Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi during working hours between 10:00 hrs to 17:00 hrs on any working day up to 31.07.2026 (15:00 hrs).

Applications received within the stipulated period shall be considered for primary shortlisting and the shortlisting shall remain valid as per terms and conditions of the notification.

Detailed notification, eligibility criteria, terms & conditions and application form are available on Northern Railway website i.e. <https://nr.indianrailways.gov.in>.

Any corrigendum/modification, if any, shall be available on the aforesaid website only.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1820/26



Regd. Office: ICICI Bank Limited, Landmark, Race Course Circle, Vadodara- 390007

Corporate Office: ICICI Bank Towers, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai- 400051

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Shal Tower Plot No-23, New Rohtak Road Karol Bagh New Delhi-110005

Notice for Disclosure of Legal Heirs of Deceased Borrower

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice Is Hereby Given That Home Loan TBSIR00007339226/ TBSIR00006309718/LBSIR00006339130/LBSIR00007352374 (Credit Facility) Was Granted To Nirmala Kumari of Borrower, Co-Borrower, Guarantor/Mortgagor (Excluding Deceased Borrower) (Borrowers) Along With The Deceased Neha Sachdeva By ICICI Bank Ltd. (The Bank).

We Would Like To Inform You That The Demise of Neha Sachdeva Has Come To Our Knowledge During Field Visits Conducted By The Bank Officials and By Telephonic Communications on The Registered Contact Numbers. In This Regard, Letter Dated May 26, 2026 Was Previously Sent To The Registered Addresses of The Borrowers and The Deceased Neha Sachdeva, For Providing Information About The Legal Heirs of The Deceased Borrower.

Therefore, This Notice Is Hereby Given For Sharing Details of The Legal Heirs of The Deceased Neha Sachdeva With Supporting Documents For Updating The Bank's Records, Within 15 Days of Publication of This Notice. You May Submit The Above-Mentioned Details To Bittu By Visiting Address: ICICI BANK LTD 16/753, Opposite Hotel Jai Vilas Beside BPCL Parmeshwar Service Station, Dabwali Road Sirda Haryana- 125055

Date : May 30, 2026 Authorised Officer
Place : Gurgaon (Haryana) For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Kuldeep S/o Jeevan Singh R/o E77/460, Nehru Camp Jhuggi, IP Extension, Mandawali, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 63/2014 U/s 323/341/34 IPC, P.S. Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kuldeep** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kuldeep** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kuldeep** of case **FIR No. 63/2014 U/s 323/341/34 IPC, P.S. Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class -03
East District, Court No. 16
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/6248/ED/2026 (Court Matter)

APPENDIX IV-A

Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **India SME Asset Reconstruction Company Limited [CIN :U67190MH2008PLC181062]** ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 18.06.2026 from 09.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 27,49,261/- (Rupees Twenty Seven Lakh Forty Nine Thousand Two Hundred Sixty One only) pending towards Loan Account No. **HHLVA500387234**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till **25.05.2026** with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. **26.05.2026** along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **VINOD TIWARI and RICHIA TIWARI**.

The Loan Account bearing No. **HHLVA500387234**, along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s), including the Immovable Property, has been assigned by Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL") (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) to and in favour of the Secured Creditor acting as a Trustee of **ISARC - 2025 - 2026 - 5 Trust** vide Assignment Agreement dated **26.12.2025**. The Secured Creditor has duly taken over the financial facility from SCL and is thus, vested with all powers and entitled to recover its outstanding dues in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) and / or enforcement of security interest in relation to the Immovable Property. The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be **Rs. 18,00,000/- (Rupees Eighteen Lakh only)** and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be **Rs. 1,80,000/- (Rupees One Lakh Eighty Thousand only)** i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

FLAT NO. UG - 3, UPPER GROUND FLOOR, M. I. G. REAR LEFT HAND SIDE (WITH/UT ROOF RIGHTS), AREA ADMEASURING 55.74 SQ. MTR. I. E. 600 SQ. FT. COVERED AREA, CONSTRUCTED ON PLOT NO. B - 1/153, IN THE COLONY KNOWN AS "DLF DISHAAD EXT. - 2", SITUATED AT VILLAGE BHOPURA, TEH. & DIST. GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH. BOUNDED AS :-

EAST : PLOT NO. B - 1/152

WEST : FLAT NO. UG - 4

NORTH : COMMON PASSAGE & FLAT NO. UG - 2

SOUTH : OTHER PLOT

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.isarc.in; Helpline No : 0124-5910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

**ed-
INDIA SME ASSET RECONSTRUCTION COMPANY LIMITED**

Date : 27.05.2026

Place : GHAZIABAD

Trustee of ISARC - 2025 - 2026 - 5 Trust

Regd. Office: ICICI Bank Limited, Landmark, Race Course Circle, Vadodara- 390007

Corporate Office: ICICI Bank Towers, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai- 400051

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited shal Tower Plot No-23, New Rohtak Road Karol Bagh New Delhi-110005

Annexure 54

Notice for Disclosure of Legal Heirs of Deceased Borrower

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that Home Loan LBGUR00005259695 (Credit facility) was granted to PARMINDER KAUR, Co-Borrower, Guarantor/Mortgagor (excluding deceased borrower) (Borrowers) along with the deceased SIDDHARTH, by ICICI Bank Ltd. (The Bank).

We would like to inform you that the demise of SIDDHARTH has come to our knowledge during field visits conducted by the Bank officials and by telephonic communications on the registered contact numbers. In this regard, letter dated 26 May, 2026 was previously sent to the registered addresses of the Borrowers and the deceased SIDDHARTH, for providing information about the Legal Heirs of the deceased Borrower.

Therefore, this Notice is hereby given for sharing details of the Legal Heirs of the deceased SIDDHARTH, with supporting documents for updating the Bank's records, within 15 days of publication of this Notice.

You may submit the above-mentioned details to TARUN PRASHAR by visiting Address: ICICI BANK LTD PLOT NO.19, Sector-12 A Opp. Bal Bharti School, Dwarka New Delhi- 110075

Date : May 30, 2026 SD Authorised Officer
Place : Gurgaon (Haryana) For ICICI Bank Ltd.



GAIL Gas Limited

[A wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited]

NOTICE FOR HIRING OF CONTRACTORS FOR CGD PROJECT

GAIL Gas Limited intends to engage experienced contractors/ agencies through an on-the-spot Walk-In Selection process for the execution of DPNG LMC/GI works across various Geographical Areas (GAs) of GAIL Gas Limited.

The Walk-In Selection Process shall be conducted at the Venue and Time mentioned below for the following GAs:

S. N.	GAs	DPNG LMC/GI works
1.	Seraikela-Kharsawan & West Singhbhum (Jharkhand)	
2.	Puri-Nayagarh-Ganjam (Odisha)	01.06.2026, 02.06.2026 and 03.06.2026 10:00 AM to 5:30 PM
3.	Raisen, Sehore & Shajapur (Madhya Pradesh)	
4.	Dhanbad (Jharkhand)	
5.	Mirzapur, Chandauli & Sonbhadra (Uttar Pradesh)	
6.	Sundargarh-Jharsuguda (Odisha)	

Venue:
Conference Room, 3rd Floor, GAIL Gas Limited, GAIL Jubilee Tower B-35/36, Sector-1, Noida

Interested bidders may submit relevant supporting documents, including Work Experience Certificates, GST Registration, PAN, PF/ESI Registration (wherever applicable), and details of available manpower and equipment.

The bidder shall submit a copy of at least one work order awarded during the last seven (07) years as proof of experience in execution of PNG connection/pipeline-related works in the gas, water supply, drainage, telecom, or any other utility sector for GAIL/GAIL Gas and/or their Group Companies, or for any other company.

Detailed Terms & Conditions shall be available at following link: <https://gailgas.com/eoi/expression-interest>

Contact Person

- arnab.samanta@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:7055515333)
- sandeep.sharma@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:9599477955)
- saksham.gupta@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:9988092246)
- anil.kumar1@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:7763807378)

All corrigendum/addendums to this notice will be hosted on the GAIL Gas website only. Hence, you are requested to visit the website regularly.

Corporate Identification Number : U40200DL2008G0178614



DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS KATHUA

E- mail: sspkathua@jkpolice.gov.in Fax/Phone No.:01922-234010

LOOK OUT NOTICE

On 19-05-2026, one person namely Jaswant Singh S/O Rajinder Singh R/O Dewal Tehsil Billawar District Kathua lodged a written report at P/S Billawar stating therein that his wife namely Neha Rajput, age 32 years is missing from home on 27-04-2026. The complainant tried his best to search his wife but all in vain. On this, missing report vide DD No. 15 dated 19-05-2026 has been entered at Police Station Billawar. During the course of investigation, best efforts were made to locate missing individual, whereas she is still un-traced.

As such Description Roll/Photograph of said missing individual is being shared with the appeal that anybody having clue/information about her whereabouts may inform us accordingly. The informer will be rewarded suitably-

DESCRIPTION ROLL

- Name Neha Rajput
- Husband Jaswant Singh
- Permanent Address Dewal
- Present Address Dewal
- Tehsil Billawar
- Police Station Billawar
- Age 32 years
- Height 5 feet
- Complexion Fair
- Built Normal
- Face Oval
- Eyes Black
- Languages known Hindi/ Dogri

PHOTOGRAPH



Any information related to the whereabouts of the subject may be communicated on following contacts:-

- DPO Kathua- 01922-234010 (Phone/Fax)
- dpokathua@jkpolice.gov.in (Mail ID)
- PCR Kathua- 01922-234311 (Phone/Fax)
- Police Station Billawar - 01921-22022

DIP No:DIP/J-2867/26 **Sd/-Sr. Superintendent of Police, Kathua.**



UJVNL Limited

(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprise)

H.O.: "UJWAL", MAHARANI BAGH, G.M.S. ROAD, Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508

CIN No U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website : www.ujvnl.com

पत्र सं. 456 दिनांक: 29/05/2026

Tender Notice

The office of Executive Engineer (Generation), Maneri Bhai Stage-II, Chinyalisaur (Uttarkashi) invites online bids from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below :

Tender No: NIT- (1) 10/EE (GEN)/MB-II/2026-27, (2) 11/EE (GEN)/MB-II/2026-27, (3) 12/EE (GEN)/MB-II/2026-27, (4) 13/EE (GEN)/MB-II/2026-27

Name of work / Supply/Services: 1) Cleaning and repairing of stator core punching of 76 MW Capacity Hydro Generators of Dharasu Power House, MB-II, Chinyalisaur, Uttarkashi .

2) Providing and fixing of various printed sign boards for MB-II, Dharasu Power House.

3) General Cleaning work at MB-II, Dharasu Power House for the year 2026-27.

4) ELCID Testing of Stator of 76 MW Hydro Generator at MB-II, Dharasu Power House.

Estimated cost: Rs 1627920/-, Rs 881100/-, Rs 1867215/-, Rs 488040.00/-, only + GST extra respectively

Date of availability of bid document on website : - 30.05.2026

Last date for submission of Bids- 21.06.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs.

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"

Executive Engineer (Generation)

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vijay @ Hau @ Arun, S/o: Ishwar Singh, R/o: RGA 101-102, DDA Flat, Raghuvir Nagar, Delhi** and **H.No-9701, Gali No-10, Multani Dhandra, Paharganj, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 85/2018, Dated: 01/05/2018, U/s: 394/397411/34 IPC & 25/27/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Khyala, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Vijay @ Hau @ Arun** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vijay @ Hau @ Arun** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vijay @ Hau @ Arun of P.S. Khyala, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Pooja Talwar
ASJ (FTC)-01, West Distt., Room No. 313,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/6925/WD/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

CORRIGENDUM

Ref: SLT notice letter No. NR-HQ0MECH(CHG)/10/2026-O/oSSE/Chg/1/HQ/NR dated 25.05.2026 (publish on 26.05.2026).

Sub: - Corrigendum pertaining Special Limited Tender (SLT) e-tender notice for the Work: "Better On-Board Services (OBHS and linen Distribution) in identified trains of NR through Empanelled firms for the period of Two Years (730 days)". (Tender No-NRMECHCHG 1026 Better OB)

For the subject SLT tender document, the date of submission of SLT proposal on IREPS website is extended from 09.06.2026 by 15:00 hrs. to **10.06.2026 by 15:00 hrs.**, with Corrigendum as under:

Corrigendum Slip

Description	Existing	Should be read as
5 Earnest Money (on Line)	Rs. 22,36,270/- (in favour of FA&CAO, Northern Railway, New Delhi.)	22,36,300
10 Date and time of tender opening	09.06.2026, 15.30 Hrs. onwards If the date of opening happens to be a holiday or otherwise the tender shall be opened on the next working day.	10.06.2026 by 15:00 hrs

Note: This is the First Corrigendum.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

DP/6840/N/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C/84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Shahrugh @ Akram S/o Mullaji @ Irfan, R/o Jhuggi No. 367, CD Park, Jahangirpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 111/2021, U/s 380/454/34 IPC, PS Subzi Mandi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Shahrugh @ Akram** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Shahrugh @ Akram** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Shahrugh @ Akram** of case **FIR No. 111/2021, U/s 380/454/34 IPC, PS Subzi Mandi, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **29.06.2026**.

By Order
Preeti Rajoria
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 32
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/6840/N/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C/84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Aftab S/o Saidudin R/o B-26, Street No. 5, Mandawa, Joshi Colony, Fazalpur, Shakarpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 800382294/2025, U/s 303(3) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Aftab** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Aftab** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Aftab** of Case **FIR No. 800382294/2025, U/s 303(3) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Kirandeep Kaur,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 05
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/6952/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Sanjay Kumar, S/o Sh. Kailash Kumar, R/o H.No. N-71, A-block, Old Chandrawal, Majnu Ka Tilla, Civil Lines, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 286/2019, U/s: 279 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Kashmir Gate, New Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Sanjay Kumar**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Sanjay Kumar**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Sanjay Kumar, FIR No. 286/2019, U/s: 279 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Kashmir Gate, New Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.06.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11,
Central, Court No. 138, First Floor,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/7002/N/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rohit @ Achhu @ Aju, S/o Rajendar Singh R/o H.No.L-232, Raghuvir Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.384/2019 u/s 392 IPC, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rohit @ Achhu @ Aju** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rohit @ Achhu @ Aju** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rohit @ Achhu @ Aju** of **FIR No.384/2019 u/s 392 IPC, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **04.08.2026**.

By Order,
Shashank Nandan Bhatt
Metropolitan Magistrate, West District, Room No.356,
DP/6932/WD/2026 3rd Floor, Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi

DP/6932/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rashid, S/o Md. Nasir R/o H.No.F2/573, Ground Floor, Sunder Nagri Nand Nagri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case e-FIR No.80110351/2025 u/s 305(a)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Md Rashid** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Md Rashid** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Md Rashid** of e-FIR No.80110351/2025 u/s 305(a)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.07.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Preeti Rajoria
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No.32, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/6980/N/2026



UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION GANDHI NAGAR JAMMU

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

e-NIT No. DGN/17 of 2026-27 Dated 25-05-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S.No	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised Cost (Rs. in Lacs)	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	Construction of Medical Sub Centre Building at Gujjar Colony Channi Hammat, Jammu (Under Capital Component 2025-26) UT Sector Infrastructure / Development works)	PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar	131.65	3000	263300 (2% of the Advertised Cost)	01 Year	(1200 Hrs) on or after 10-06-2026	"A" Class

Position of AAA :- Accorded by Director Health Services Jammu vide order No. 03-DHSJ (P) of 2025 dated 01-07-2026 amounting to ` 137.63 Lacs

Position of TS :- Sanctioned by Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Zone Jammu vide order No. 72 of May 2026 amounting to ` 133.45 Lacs.

Project Authority :- Director Health Services Jammu

Major Head of Account :- Under Capital Component 2025-26 UT Sector Infrastructure/Development works-

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jtenders.gov.in> as per below schedule.

1	Date of issue of tender Notice	25-05-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 25-05-2026 to 09-06-2026, 1800 Hrs
3	Date, time and place of pre-bid meeting	01-06-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu
4	Bid submission Start Date	25-05-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	09-06-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	10-06-2026 on or after 1200 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

1. Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of e-challan through Treasury indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and name of work duly crediting to 0059 (Revenue) favoring Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu and upload the same i.e treasury challan/receipt, Earnest money/Bid security in shape of CD/ FDR/ RG pledged to Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu. The CD/ FDR/ RG shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original instruments in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of LI be submitted to the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu at the date of allotment.

2. The electronic bidding system would not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. In case of late submission of bids, the system will not accept the modification. In case of late submission of bids, the system will not accept the modification. In case of late submission of bids, the system will not accept the modification.

3. The date and time of opening of Financial Bids shall be notified on Web Site [www.jtenders.gov.in](http://jtenders.gov.in) and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial bids of responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu. The date for same shall be intimated separately.

4. The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of technical bids.

5. The earnest money shall be forfeited, if :-

- Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.
- Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issue of letter of acceptance.
- Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Jammu's Circular No. CE/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.

6. Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.

6.1 Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jtenders.gov.in to acquaint bid submission process.

6.2 To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get "Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)" as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors.

6.3. The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic form with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.

6.4. Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.

6.5. Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

DIP No: DIP/J-2787/26

Sd/- (E. Karanjeet Singh)
Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar

DP/6932/WD/2026



'TOXIC CHANGES HOW YOU SEE MAN-WOMAN DYNAMIC'

Kiara said Nadia's character made her rethink what she knew about love & relationships

Kiara Advani arrived on the set of 'Toxic' with her lines memorised and her head in exactly the place her director Geetu Mohandas had asked for. Then she was handed three pages of brand-new Kannada dialogues she had never seen before. That morning on the set of the Yash-starrer turned into what she now calls the best scene of her career.

'Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups', the upcoming Kannada action film, which also stars Nayanthara, Huma Qureshi, Tara Sutaria and Rukmini Vasanth, has been postponed multiple times and so far, doesn't have a release date. The film was shot in Kannada and English but will be released in multiple languages. For Kiara, it has also been, by her own admission, the most demanding work of her career.

Speaking about the film with 'Bombay Times', Kiara said the character of Nadia made her rethink what she knew about love and relationships. "With 'Toxic', which is coming up, I think it completely changes the way you see the man-woman dynamic. In fact, even for me, when Geetu Mohandas narrated the script to me, it took a while for me to understand that 'okay, this is also normal'. It may be gray, it may not be in your conventional space, but there's a certain lib-



eration in love."

That moment of recognition stayed with her long after the narration ended. "That's when Nadia was narrated to me and I was like, 'Wow'. I mean, I wish I were capable of being so detached and liberated in my own thoughts and the way I, you know..."

The first look at Nadia presents Advani set against a circus backdrop, balancing glamorous aesthetics with emotional depth that suggests grief and melancholy beneath the surface spectacle.

AGENCIES

BIARRITZ FILM FESTIVAL

Ishaan Khatter becomes jury member

The actor will be joining Kristen Stewart, Whitney Peak and many others

Bollywood actor Ishaan Khatter became the latest addition to the Jury Panel at the Biarritz Film Festival.

The actor will be joining the previously announced jury members, which include the names of Kristen Stewart, Whitney Peak, Raphael Querard and others, according to a press release.

The festival will start on June 23 and conclude on June 28. It is a prominent European cinema event in Southwest France dedicated entirely to youth,

emerging talent and the future of global storytelling. Other members joining the jury are French filmmaker Nathan Ambrosioni, French actress Suzy Bemba, Italian director Carolina Cavalli and British actor Esme Creed-Miles.

Khatter is known for his roles in projects such as 'Dhadak', 'A Suitable Boy', 'Homebound' and others.

He also starred in 'Netflix' murder-mystery miniseries 'The Perfect Couple', which marked his Hollywood debut.

He will next feature in 'Jugaadu' and the next season of 'Netflix' series 'The Royals'. P11



THE PYRAMID SCHEME

Fuelled by dreams, ambition & survival

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' unveiled the intriguing trailer of its upcoming 'Original' series 'The Pyramid Scheme', a compelling drama that explores the dangerous allure of quick money, ambition and fraudulent pyramid schemes. The series features an ensemble cast with Paramvir Singh Cheema, Ranvir Shorey, Shekhar Suman, Aanjan Srivastava, Alia Jafry and Ashish Raghava in the lead roles and supported by Akhilen-dra Mishra, Smrita Bansal, Vijay Kumar,



Indresh Malik, Ravi Bhel, Sushant Singh, Sonal Jha and Sadanand Patil in pivotal roles.

The trailer opens into a world of flashy wealth and big promises of changing your destiny in merely six

The trailer opens into a world of flashy wealth and big promises of changing your destiny in merely six months. We are introduced to Goldy (Paramvir Singh Cheema) and Manoj Srivastava (Ranvir Shorey), two men with different aspirations, pulled into the glittering maze of 'sapno ka business model' that is based on pyra-

mid marketing, a world that promises them quick money, respect and success by just convincing others to join the system. Easy enough to do, right? But the higher Goldy and Manoj climb this pyramid of success, the shakier the ground beneath them gets. Will the company turn their dreams into reality or bury them under jumbo-sized problems?

Paramvir shared, "Goldy is a character completely different from anything I've played till now. He hails from Haridwar, the Gateway of Gods and that essence reflects deeply in who he is."

'IF I COULD DO WHAT DOWNEY DID FOR ME...'

Tom Holland hopes to mentor next Spider-Man

Hollywood star Tom Holland said he wants to help set up the next chapter of the 'Spider-Man' franchise and he hopes that he can do for a future successor what Robert Downey Jr did for him.

The 29-year-old British actor first played Peter Parker in 2016's 'Captain America: Civil War', before reprising the role in three standalone films as well as several 'Marvel Cinematic Universe' (MCU) titles such as 'Avengers: Infinity War' and 'Avengers: Endgame'.

Holland said he has often thought about eventually handing over the mantle to another character from the 'Spider-Man' universe, such as Miles Morales, Spider-Gwen, Spider-Woman or someone else from the web-slinging family.

"For whoever's next... I would love to be a part of setting up the next chapter. Whatever that looks like, I don't know," he told 'Empire' magazine.

"But, if I could do what Downey did for me, then I would be so content swinging off into the sunset," he added, referring to Downey Jr's role of Tony Stark aka Iron Man, who served as a mentor figure to Holland's Peter Parker



Holland is now gearing up for his fourth solo outing, 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day'

in 'Spider-Man: Homecoming' in 2017.

Holland is the third actor to play Peter Parker on the big screen after Tobey Maguire and Andrew Garfield, both of whom appeared alongside him in 'Spider-Man: No Way Home' in 2021. He is now gearing up for his fourth solo outing, 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day'. The movie, which picks up after 'No Way Home' with Peter Parker navigating a world where no one remembers his identity, is set for release on July 31. P11

Chris to headline film based on Australia's Tatts Finke Desert Race

'Off-road racing has been a passion in my family for a long time,' says Hemsworth

Hollywood star Chris Hemsworth is set to star in and produce a feature film based on Australia's legendary Tatts Finke Desert Race.

According to 'Deadline', the Australian actor's production banner 'Wild State' has inked an exclusive partnership with the event's organisers to develop multiple projects around the gruelling two-day motorsport competition. The feature, which will serve as a starring vehicle for the 'Thor' actor, is in early development with Ricky Staub and Dan Walser penning the script.

'Wild State', which Hemsworth co-founded with Ben Grayson, is also producing unscripted content around the race, including a project following freestyle motocross legend Robbie Maddison as he competes in the event for the first time.

"Off-road racing has been a passion in my family for a long time and we at 'Wild State' are thrilled to partner with the Tatts Finke Desert Race on the eve of its 50th anniversary and bring this epic competition to a global audi-



ence," Hemsworth said.

The Tatts Finke Desert Race, one of the biggest annual sporting events in Australia's Northern Territory, is widely regarded as the country's most exciting off-road race. It is considered among the most difficult courses in the world, held across one of the planet's most remote terrains. The event will mark its 50th anniversary in June this year.

Through 'Wild State', Hemsworth has previously produced

his 'Disney+' series 'Limitless' with Chris Hemsworth, Netflix's 'Extraction' franchise, 'Crime 101' and the upcoming 'Apple' sci-fi mystery 'Cor-sair Code'.

The actor is currently filming for the third film in the 'Extraction' franchise. He will be next seen reprising the fan-favourite 'Marvel' superhero Thor in 'Avengers: Domsday'. Set to be released in theatres in December this year. P11



The Tatts Finke Desert Race is widely regarded as the country's most exciting off-road race

Prime Video announces June 12 as global premiere for 'Raakh'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

June 12 is the premiere date of the upcoming 'Prime Original' series 'Raakh'. Directed and executive produced by Prosit Roy, the series is created, written and co-directed by Anusha Nandakumar and Sandeep Saket, with dialogues by Ayush Trivedi. Produced by Deepak Dhar, Rishi Negi, Mrinalini Jain and Shyam Rathi under the banner of 'Endemol Shine India' in association with 'BhaDiPa', 'Raakh' stars Sonali Bendre,

The series stars Ali Fazal, Sonali Bendre and Aamir Bashir in lead roles

Ali Fazal and Aamir Bashir in lead roles.

'Raakh' is an investigative drama that unfolds as a visceral study of the criminal mind and the darkness that lingers beneath the surface of everyday life. When two teenagers vanish without a trace, a close-knit family is shattered

and an entire city is left on edge. A relentless investigating officer launches a nationwide manhunt to uncover the truth. Still, the deeper he goes, the more the case pulls him into a world of violence and human depravity.

"With 'Raakh', we had a brilliant script, but the on-screen execution has been even better," said Nikhil Madhok, director and head of 'Originals', 'Prime Video India'.

Prosit Roy, Director and Executive Producer, said:

"'Raakh' has been one of the most creatively fulfilling and emotionally intense projects I have worked on, because at its heart, it goes far beyond being a crime thriller. What excited me most about 'Raakh' was the opportunity to merge the thrill of a gripping manhunt with an unflinching exploration of trauma and the darker impulses of human nature. Anusha and Sandeep have created a world that is meticulously researched, intricately layered and rich with moral ambiguity."

